

New York University

[my] Theory on Consciousness & Pendulums:

Integrating Pre/Faces

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Abstract

Tracing the transmission of Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda's musical, devotional, and pedagogical praxis from her 1970 recordings through the contemporary kinship networks sustaining her legacy, this thesis asks what her work *does*—how it operates as a phrnetic technology of sensorium, [re]activating forms of encounter, recognition, and collective becoming in bodies and communities that receive it as transmission rather than as commodity. A beginning bridge chapter receives *Monument Eternal* (1977) as philosophical text, opening the cosmological vocabulary the thesis develops and the recordings articulate in their own medium. Three case studies follow—close listenings of "Turiya and Ramakrishna" (1970), the ashram version of "Journey to Satchidananda" (2017), and "Translinear Light" (2004)—each extended through an ethnographic vignette drawn from field-orientation in New York City's contemporary avant-garde music scene between 2023 and 2026. The *Year of Alice* (2024–2025) has brought Coltrane's work into unprecedented cultural visibility—yet her practice continues to exceed the categories through which the critical reception apparatus attempts to receive it. The transmission moves through the kinship networks that receive it on its own terms. It is a [re]sounding message.

Keywords: Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda, phronesis, consciousness, phenomenology, mosaic-lensed deframement, psychocarceral enframement, presencing consciousness, autoethnography

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Beyond those artists and thinkers, i engaged hundreds of people in the spaces i explored during field-orientation—artists, academics, professionals, and all manner of thoughtful souls. i encountered scholars studying neuroscience, language, and AI ethics whose seemingly unrelated paths had led them to the same rooms, where we discussed our fields in relation to live music spaces. We found overlapping resonance without looking for it. My classmates' projects and perspectives were a steady source of provocation and inspiration. Sampy Sicada, Areli Rocha, Cody Curtain, Jess Mills, Amy Arif, Reihannah, and Yutong (Ellen) Shi are members of my cohort with whom i connected at varied depths. Friendly faces who understand the particular pressures of an intensive program matter more than they might seem to from outside—and i want to be clear that many other classmates were equally kind and thought-provoking. These are simply the people with whom something clicked a bit further. bt friedenberg is the classmate with whom i built the deepest connection. As our friendship grew, we explored the concepts in our courses and theses together, carried those explorations into the city, and shared in many forms of art and cultural life while unpacking our thinking.

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This is a summary. The full scope of who and what shaped this work would fill its own volume. i am thankful for every person i encountered, and especially for those named here. All love to each of you and i wish nothing but blessings ahead.

“This book is selflessly presented to my truly sacred Supreme Lord.”

Coltrane-Turiyasangitananda, 1977, p. 6

Table of Contents

<i>Abstract.....</i>	<i>ii</i>
<i>Acknowledgements</i>	<i>iii</i>
<i>Note on the Text.....</i>	<i>v</i>
<i>Introduction.....</i>	<i>1</i>
Into the Looking-Glass: Early Oughts [Con]Vexation	1
Thesis Statement: Always-Already Part-of-It	2
Biographical Ground: Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda.....	5
Autobiographical Figuration: [Trans]Missive Entries	9
<i>Methodologies.....</i>	<i>11</i>
A Thousand Words; Worth a Picture	12
On Grounding.....	17
Cosmotechnical [non]Lineages	18
Mosaic-Lensed Deframement.....	21
Radical Reflex-Ability	24
Through Her Wisdom Eye	25
<i>Literature Review</i>	<i>27</i>
Creolization: Structures of Relation.....	27
On Archivization	28
Subject: Object; Figure: Ground	30
Awakened by the Unstruck.....	32
Repeat... i Repeat: It's Better Not-Spoken-Of.....	34
New Meanings.....	38
Psychocarceral Enframement	39
Reasonance.....	41
Chapter Overview.....	41
<i>Chapter One: Opening... the Wound.....</i>	<i>44</i>
Gaze Upon the Surface of Infinity	47
Now, Be Here	49
<i>Chapter Two: Case Study 001— “Turiya & Ramakrishna”</i>	<i>50</i>
<i>Chapter Three: Case Study 002— “Journey [to] Satchidananda”</i>	<i>62</i>
<i>Chapter Four: Case Study 003— “Translinear Light”</i>	<i>71</i>
<i>[In]Con-Clusion.....</i>	<i>81</i>

References	98
Discography.....	106
Appendix A – Textual Retentions.....	120
Appendix B: Fugitive Ephemera	134

Note on the Text

The lowercase *i* throughout this thesis is a deliberate methodological commitment, not a typographical inconsistency—a visual-conceptual resistance to what Donna Haraway (1988) names the [G]od *trick* of disembodied, sovereign authorship. Bracket-hyphen poetics break words open at the sites where their generative possibilities live. The prose-poetic register the thesis sustains throughout is grounded across five converging methodological traditions—phenomenology, qualitative methodology, media studies historiography, decolonial feminist philosophy, and Black feminist poetics—as the chapter on methodology articulates at length. Two appendices follow the body of the thesis: *Textual Retentions* gathers expanded primary texts the thesis engages; *Fugitive Ephemera* gathers materials from the transmission's contemporary circulation in non-linear arrangement. Unless otherwise noted in the body text, the appendices are offered as companion traces the reader may enter on their own terms.

Introduction

“Forgive me father, for I have categorized. I have labeled and I have pigeonholed. So sayeth the penitent music historian” (Kahn, 2020).

Into the Looking-Glass: Early Oughts /Con/Vexation

i discovered Alice Coltrane’s music through a pirated fiber-optic cable connection. At 15, contemplating a request from my father—who had just buried his own mother—to learn Santana’s “*Soul Sacrifice*” for his future wake, i stumbled into a peer-to-peer anomaly on Soulseek.¹ A stranger, bypassing the bandwidth constraints of my 56k modem, shared their T1 connection to transfer Santana’s entire discography instead—but with a specific directive: “Start with ‘Illuminations’.” This was not a work of the rock star Santana but rather of a given-name, Devadip²—the spiritual comrade of Alice Coltrane, with whom he had composed the movements to his label’s chagrin. i was not studying a genre. i was being initiated into a sonic lineage through a stranger’s generosity and my father’s mortality. The transmission had begun before i had any framework to receive it. In later years, John Coltrane’s “*Psalm*”—the final movement of *A Love Supreme*—hung on the wall of my bedroom. The poem was itself Coltrane’s offering of gratitude for his own deliverance from heroin addiction—a prayer on the boundless potential of vibrational reality, on the unity of all things in God. He had woven the

¹ Soulseek is a peer-to-peer file-sharing application launched in 2001, used primarily for the exchange of music files. Its architecture relies on direct user-to-user transfer—the same relational infrastructure through which the transmission this thesis traces has always propagated

² Devadip: from the Sanskrit deva (god, divine) and dīpa (lamp, light)—“the lamp, light, and eye of God.” Carlos Santana received the name from guru Sri Chinmoy in October 1972 and was a disciple from 1972 to 1981, recording three albums under the name Devadip Carlos Santana: *Illuminations* with Turiya Alice Coltrane (1974), *Oneness: Silver Dreams, Golden Reality* (1979), and *The Swing of Delight* (1980). Though Alice Coltrane was not herself a Chinmoy disciple, she and Santana maintained a concurrent spiritual and musical mentorship during this period, and *Illuminations*—composed to the Columbia label’s commercial chagrin—stands as the first-fruit of that collaboration.

words of the poem into the saxophone's melodic line, a spoken prayer hidden³ inside the instrument's voice, legible only when the liner notes revealed what the horn had been saying all along. i had placed those words on my wall in the early days of recovery from the same affliction—not as decoration but as a reminder of the gratitude i have for every day i experience in a life after death. i had discovered Alice's music before i ever understood the full breadth of John's. The transmission had been sounding in my house before i had sensed its voice.

Thesis Statement: Always-Already Part-of-It

This thesis argues that Alice Coltrane⁴ Turiyasangitananda's *musicoanagogical*⁵ practice enacts a phronetic technology of sensorium [re]attunement: a living transmission the case studies demonstrate through the researcher's initiated subjectivity and trace through ethnographic field-orientation in New York City's contemporary avant-garde scene(s). Her recordings, devotional practice, and ashram infrastructure function as nodal entry points into a transmission that exceeds any single artifact. The question this work pursues is not what Coltrane's praxis *is* but what it *does*—what forms of encounter, recognition, and collective becoming it continues to activate in bodies and communities that receive it as transmission rather than as commodity.

Existing scholarship has approached Coltrane's work biographically and musicologically (Berkman, 2010), within Black women's mystical-utopian lineage (brown, 2021), through Afrofuturist sonic experimentation (Eshun, 1998), and within the type of cultural-historical

³ Coltrane had deployed a similar technique in "Alabama" (1963), shaping the saxophone's rhythmic cadence from the flow of Dr. Martin Luther King Jr.'s eulogy following the 16th Street Baptist Church bombing in Birmingham—the attack that claimed the lives of Addie Mae Collins, Cynthia Wesley, Carole Robertson, and Carol Denise McNair.

⁴ Turiyasangitananda is the spiritual name Alice received from the Supreme, which she translates at the close of *Monument Eternal* as "The Transcendental Lord's highest song of bliss" (Coltrane-Turiyasangitananda, 1977, p. 52).

⁵ i adopt Doraiswamy's (2024) term *musicoanagogical* to name a practice in which music operates as the vehicle for anagogic encounter.

synthesis the *Year of Alice*'s lionization-project has occasioned (Beta, 2026). Michael Gallope's *The Musician as Philosopher* (2024)—published after this thesis's research question had already been formulated—has most directly opened the philosophical reading the present thesis extends, situating Coltrane within a postwar New York vernacular avant-garde whose musicians (alongside David Tudor, Ornette Coleman, the Velvet Underground, Patti Smith, Richard Hell) were resistant philosophers operating at the threshold of music's ineffability. Gallope's chapter on Alice, centered on *Universal Consciousness* (1971), reads her music as a *novel mobilization of ineffability*—a “polyphonic, overabundant, oblique” alchemy that interpellates the listener with desire for a transcendence that would “forever appear beyond the capacities of description” (Gallope, 2024, p. 180).

This thesis joins Gallope's reading and extends it into a register his framework leaves underdeveloped. Where Gallope reads Coltrane's music as a *novel mobilization of ineffability*—an alchemy that interpellates listeners with desire for a transcendence that would “forever appear beyond the capacities of description” (Gallope, 2024, p. 180)—this thesis acknowledges the ineffable-transcendent dimension and joins a broader contemporary scholarship (brown, 2021; Doraiswamy, 2024; among others) in reading Coltrane's praxis as also a sustained translation of immanence: the cultivation of a present-tense, embodied, collectively-trained sensorium for which the divine is not just transcendent-as-elsewhere but also immanent-as-here, available to a body and a community trained to register vibratory reality at the threshold where conceptual capture begins. The energetic substrate as field of *Absolute Consciousness*, the austerity-disciplined body, the collective devotional infrastructure, the ashram as working site of daily practice—these are not gestures toward transcendence alone but articulations of immanence as a practical relational condition. *Presencing consciousness*, the term this thesis develops to name

what Coltrane's practice cultivates, names these immanent aspects of a non-dual register: not the transcendent that exceeds description, but the present that exceeds capture by the conceptual apparatus a body has been trained to bring to it.

This is the philosophical project the thesis receives as an *assemblage*—Coltrane's writings, recordings, ashram pedagogy, musical practice, and the kinship networks that have continued the work as a heterogeneous gathering of elements that hold together as a single working practice without subordinating any element to the others or to a master-articulation that would govern them. The case studies engage three recordings ('Turiya and Ramakrishna,' 1970; 'Journey to Satchidananda' in its 1980s ashram version, released 2017; 'Translinear Light,' 2004), extending the philosophical reading across the chronological span Gallope's framework brackets—and trace, through ethnographic field-orientation in the contemporary New York avant-garde scene (2023–2026), how the assemblage continues to operate as living transmission in present-tense bodies and communities.

The chapter on methodology that follows this introduction articulates the commitments under which the engagement operates and grounds the writerly register the thesis sustains throughout. The literature review gathers the theoretical apparatus the inquiry deploys, discussing external sources for their methodological and conceptual relevance to Coltrane's praxis. A beginning bridge chapter then engages *Monument Eternal* (1977) as initiatory philosophical text, opening the cosmological vocabulary the thesis develops and the recordings articulate in their own medium. Three case studies follow: the first engages "Turiya and Ramakrishna" (1970); the second engages "Journey to Satchidananda" (2017) in its ashram bhajan form; the third engages "Translinear Light" (2004). Each case study closes with a vignette bringing visibility to the contemporary kinship networks that have formed around her memory. This work's final chapter

returns to those networks and their ongoing operation in rooms the thesis has inhabited throughout the research period.

Biographical Ground: Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda

This journey begins in Detroit on August 27, 1937—Alice was the fifth and youngest child of Solon and Ann McLeod, a family rooted in the Black church and the Detroit musical life that surrounded it.⁶ Solon drove a truck; Ann kept the household; the family worshipped at a Baptist parish where Alice would become the church pianist, starting Classical piano lessons at age seven. The McLeod home stood a few doors from a young Berry Gordy, whose Motown Records would later sound from the same neighborhood where Alice was learning her first chords. By adolescence she was already working in the Detroit scene as a serious pianist, and her formative apprenticeships unfolded alongside the musicians shaping postwar American music from the city's clubs—among them Tommy Flanagan and Bennie Maupin, and especially the pianist Barry Harris, whose devotion to Bud Powell's harmonic vocabulary made him both the city's most authoritative Powell adept and Alice's informal mentor through these years. The blues, gospel, and bebop converging in 1950s Detroit were the musical inheritance she carried forward in her hands.

She married vocalist Kenneth "Kenny" Hagood in 1959, and the two soon sailed for Paris. Once there, Alice sought out the pianist whose playing had shaped her own from the beginning—Bud Powell himself, then living in semi-exile at the *Hôtel La Louisiane* in *Saint-Germain-des-Prés*, under the care of the French jazz devotee Francis Paudras. What passed for lessons, in Alice's

⁶ Biographical details throughout this section draw primarily from Beta (2026), *Cosmic Music: The Life, Art, and Transcendence of Alice Coltrane*, supplemented by Adams (2016), Berkman (2010), and Christovale (2025). The Sun Ra / Weiser Books anecdote regarding John's encounter with Hazrat Inayat Khan's *The Mysticism of Sound and Music* is documented in Beta (2026) via pianist Lonnie Liston Smith's first-person recollection.

later telling, was something closer to sustained proximity: she would spend hours at Powell's apartment, absorbing his playing by direct presence, finding in his company a familial and spiritual steadiness that mattered to her beyond any transmitted technique. On a spring night in 1960, she was in the audience at the Olympia Theatre when the Miles Davis Quintet played Paris on its European tour, with John Coltrane holding down the tenor chair—Alice was seated far back in the hall, catching her first sight of the saxophonist from across the distance of a crowded auditorium. Something in what she heard that night began to move her toward a music she could sense but could not yet name. In October of that year her daughter Michelle was born in Paris. The marriage soon dissolved, and by the following year Alice had returned to Detroit as a single mother, rejoining the local scene with ears that had been through something the city could register but not explain.

The early 1960s found her composing as well as playing. Her earliest writing credit was a piece called "Soulsphere," recorded with Bennie Maupin in Detroit. The vibraphonist Terry Gibbs heard her at a Detroit club, recognized immediately what she could do, and brought her into his touring band—by late 1962 they were in the studio together at A&R Studios in New York. The following year, Gibbs and Alice landed a week at Birdland with the John Coltrane Quartet playing opposite them. She had seen John at a distance more than once before that week—the Olympia in 1960, the wings of the Minor Key in Detroit—but Birdland was where they actually met. They were both shy. The conversation that would become their life together started slowly, across nights of facing each other from opposite bandstands in the same room and gradually found its language at a back-corner table after the sets had ended. By 1965, Alice had replaced McCoy Tyner as pianist in the John Coltrane Quartet. The brief, incandescent period that followed produced some of the most uncompromising music of either of their careers—*Concert*

in Japan, Live at the Village Vanguard Again!, Stellar Regions, Expression, Interstellar Space. Their shared practice was devotional as much as musical, drawing on Vedanta, Sufism, and the writings of Paramahansa Yogananda, J. Krishnamurti, and the Sufi master Hazrat Inayat Khan, whose *Mysticism of Sound and Music* had reached John through Sun Ra—pianist Lonnie Liston Smith having himself turned up the book at Weiser Books, a Manhattan spiritual spot where he’d seen Ra and Coltrane digging in (Beta, 2026).

John died on July 17, 1967. Alice was thirty, a widow with four children, and the jazz establishment had already begun sorting her into the role of keeper-of-his-archive—custodian rather than composer, heir rather than author in her own right. What she did instead exceeded anything the reception apparatus was prepared to hear. She formed her own ensembles. She recorded across the late 1960s and 1970s with Pharoah Sanders, Cecil McBee, Rashied Ali, Charlie Haden, Ben Riley, Frank Lowe, Carlos Santana, and with the harp John had purchased for her shortly before his passing—an instrument she taught herself because no existing harpist in the jazz tradition played the way she intended a harp to sound. She took up the Wurlitzer organ as the primary instrument of her devotional composition. In 1972 she moved the family to Southern California, settling first in Encino and then in Woodland Hills, where “the seeds of what would become the Vedantic Center she later founded began to take root (Beta, 2026).” By the middle of that decade her devotional and compositional lives had collapsed into a single ongoing practice—what Beta describes as her having arrived at “a new plateau”—and the recordings of that stretch (*Universal Consciousness, World Galaxy, Lord of Lords, Eternity, Radha-Krsna Nama Sankirtana, Transcendence*) document the transformation chapter by chapter. She received formal initiation from Swami Satchidananda along with the religious name Turiyasangitananda, meaning “the highest song of God”. In the early 1980s she relocated her

growing community to 48-acres in the Santa Monica Mountains, near Agoura Hills, and gave the site its name: Sai Anantam Ashram. She lived there for the following twenty-six years, teaching a daily devotional practice grounded in singing, scriptural study, and the perennialist commitment that every tradition, fully inhabited, opens unto the same clearing. Across these decades she composed a body of devotional music for the ashram community—*Turiya Sings*, *Divine Songs*, *Infinite Chants*, *Glorious Chants*—distributing the recordings on private-press cassette and reaching a wider audience only when the *World Spirituality Classics Vol. 1: The Ecstatic Music of Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda* compilation was released by Luaka Bop in 2017, a full decade after her ascension. She wrote *Monument Eternal* in 1977, near the beginning of this period—a slim, self-published spiritual manifesto whose ideas the literature review that follows will engage. *Monument Eternal* was the first and most widely circulated of Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda's spiritual writings. *Endless Wisdom* followed in the early 1980s, presented as guidance literature for seekers and accompanied by a book signing and chanting concert at the Shared Visions bookstore in Berkeley; *Divine Revelations*, compiled in 1995 as a hardbound volume dedicated to "the lotus hands of Sri Sathya Sai Baba" and credited as "Inscribed by A.C. Turiyasangitananda", gathered the messages she had received from the Lord across two decades of ashram life (Beta, 2026). Alongside these three book-length texts she also produced shorter essays, lyrical poems, and devotional prayers—all circulating primarily within the Sai Anantam community and its extended kinship network during her lifetime, and now in the early stages of being brought back into wider circulation by the Coltrane estate as part of the ongoing stewardship of her work.

She ascended on January 12, 2007, in Los Angeles. The word *ascension*, rather than death or passing, is the word the ashram community uses, and it is the word this thesis adopts: the

Swamini's ascension names the continuation of her practice into a register the *genre of Man* (Wynter, 2003) cannot read. Her son Ravi Coltrane, the Sai Anantam Ashram Singers under the music direction of Surya Botofasina, harpist Brandee Younger (who plays Alice's actual restored harp today), and a kinship network spanning generations and continents continue her practice in living, present-tense form. The 2024–2025 *Year of Alice*—the concentrated surge of reissues, exhibitions, performances, and tributes honoring her life—is one expression of that continuation. This thesis is another.

Autobiographical Figuration: [Trans]Missive Entries

i had traveled to New York once before, in November 2023—i flew back to Florida on November 17, the day André 3000's *New Blue Sun* was released and listened to it on repeat in the cabin for the length of the flight home. A few weeks later, in December 2023, i was navigating a season of compounding losses: my maternal grandfather's death, an intimate relationship severed without warning, a close friend in acute crisis. The algorithm had delivered Rajna Swaminathan's *Apertures* to my feed earlier that year, and a one-off concert of the album at the Apollo Café in Harlem drew me back to the city i had just returned from visiting. The album's closing track, "*Surrender Is Easier Said Than Done*," carried the lines "*I thought I could see so far ahead / Little did I know, I was clouded / Surrender is easier said than done*" — the three lines were landing in every direction. What i encountered at the Apollo Café was a profoundly moving embodiment of care, communal grieving, and healing. The next evening, back home in FL, standing on my back patio, a notification came through. The group's vocalist ganavya had found me on Instagram, asking if i was the one who had traveled from Florida. Her friends had mentioned chatting with me after the show. She thanked me for coming all that way and told me to come say hi next time. In our brief exchange, she shared a PDF of *Monument*

Eternal—still very difficult to find at the time. Her kindness and attention to care moved me deeply.

By the next summer, i had moved to NYC to start grad school. On February 6, 2025, at Rough Trade Records in Times Square, i attended the public celebration of *Monument Eternal*'s second edition, some forty-eight years after its initial publication. On the panel were music journalist and NYU Tisch professor Ashley Kahn, Alice's son Ravi Coltrane, and NYU Steinhardt artist faculty harpist Brandee Younger. What had been moving through my life for over two decades had simultaneously been moving through the culture at large: the *Year of Alice*. The personal and the institutional had converged—because they share a substrate.

After the panel, i found my way to Ravi Coltrane and told him that his father's openness about addiction—that prayer of gratitude woven into the saxophone's voice—had helped carry me through my own. Ravi's face changed. He took my hand and held it and thanked God for my healing, explaining he was always glad to know that his family's story had been a light to someone walking a similar road. We stood like that for a moment. The transmission the *Psalm* had carried into my bedroom in Florida had completed its arc, twenty years on, in his hand around mine in a record store in Times Square. He also shared that the family is working now to bring all of his mother's writings—the longer texts as well as the shorter essays and devotional poetry—back into print, extending into wider circulation what the ashram community had carried in private for decades.

i write this thesis on Lenape land—the territory from which the Stockbridge-Munsee Band of Mohican Indians, of whom i am kin, were dispossessed through genocide. The disjunction between what the eye reads on the surface of the researcher's body and what the genealogical and acoustic record carries is a partial-condition from which this inquiry proceeds.

This work names what it resists: *psychocarceral enframement*—the condition in which the subject becomes the mason of their own perceptual enclosure, building with scripts inherited below the threshold of conscious awareness. The same topographic territory that delivered *Apertures* to my feed, that connected ganavya to my Instagram, that carried the *Year of Alice* into cultural visibility, can orient toward capture as readily as toward care. That the transmission moved through this territory is the argument. The aperture and the prison share a substrate. What determines the difference is the quality of attention the subject brings to the encounter.

Methodologies

This chapter, unconventionally, precedes the literature review. The five methodological traditions that converge here first—phenomenology, qualitative methodology, media studies historiography, decolonial feminist philosophy, Black feminist poetics—each argue that the register and relational-ethical commitments of inquiry are not separable from what an inquiry can come to know; they constitute the conditions under which literature becomes legible as literature-for-this-practice rather than as a neutral field. Together with the principle of *unilateral duality* that follows (Laruelle, 1998), these commitments establish the orientation through which the next chapter's interlocutors are received as constellated nodes in a non-hierarchical cosmic mosaic.

This thesis asks what Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda's practice *does*—how it operates, what conditions of being-with[out] and -there/here it makes possible, and how that possibility remains operative in the present. The proliferating scientific and mathematical consciousness literature treats consciousness as an object present-at-hand, available for measurement, categorization, and explanatory capture. This thesis operates in a different register—oriented toward what calls us to

think and be—with care—rather than what submits to being measured. The research question is oriented toward *phronesis*—practical wisdom as contingently uncodifiable, recognized only in the particular (Kristjánsson & Fowers, 2024) as transmission.

Agamben (2009) provides the methodological correlate to this orientation. His account of the *paradigm*—a form of knowledge that proceeds from singularity to singularity, neither inductively from particulars to universals nor deductively from universals to particulars—names the logic by which Coltrane's practice functions in this investigation (pp. 31–32). She is a singular case whose intelligibility radiates laterally, making visible a field of phenomena—presenced consciousness, co-constitutive knowledge generation, and the holding-open of *the break*⁷—that no general theory could have predicted. The paradigm renders the rule thinkable for the first time (p. 10).

A Thousand Words; Worth a Picture

The thesis sustains a prose-poetic register the reader will encounter throughout—in the introduction's vignettes, in the close listening passages of the case studies, in the bracket-hyphen poetics that breaks words open at the sites where their generative possibilities live, in the lowercase *i* that refuses sovereign authorship (a visual signification of the conceptual resistance to what Haraway calls the [*G*]od *trick*), and in the intermingling of researcher voice with primary-source voice that lets the transmissions carry their own cadences through the thesis' sentences. The register is a methodological commitment, grounded in a body of scholarship

⁷ *The break*, in Fred Moten's formulation, names the site at which Black musical practice performs "a cutting and abundant refusal of closure" (Moten, 2003, p. 85). The thesis's term *holding-open the break* extends Moten's own *holds open* construction—articulated most pointedly where Moten writes of the photograph of Emmett Till's face as that which "holds open the question of what looking might mean in general" under the weight of Mamie Bradley's demand that her son be seen (Moten, 2003, p. 209)—into the register of sustained praxis: the praxis through which the thesis itself holds open the names and transmissions it traces, refusing their closure into forgetting. The literature review engages Moten's full exposition in the subsection, "*Subject: Object; Figure: Ground.*"

across five disciplinary traditions that have independently argued for this choice under these conditions.

Max van Manen's *Researching Lived Experience* (1990/2016) is the hermeneutic-phenomenological work the thesis's prose-poetic register inherits from most directly. Working in the Utrecht-school phenomenological tradition, van Manen argues that “phenomenological research is a poetizing activity”⁸ —the understanding phenomenology produces requires a register that carries the reader into the structure of lived experience rather than reporting on it from outside (p. 13). The poetizing he names is not the crafting of lines but re-calling “in a language that speaks the world rather than abstractly speaking of it”—a move he grounds in Merleau-Ponty's (1973) original *singing of the world* and situates adjacent to Heidegger's engagement with Hölderlin. For van Manen, writing is central to the research process rather than a concluding step: it is the condition under which phenomenological insight becomes available to a reader at all. The thesis's close listenings share this Utrecht-tradition commitment to disclosure over report. They trace what Coltrane's practice does to the listener's attention at specific moments of a recording, and they enact the attention-giving rather than reporting on it.

Laurel Richardson's "Writing: A Method of Inquiry" (1994/2005) extends the commitment into qualitative social-science methodology. Richardson argues that writing is itself a method of inquiry—the researcher thinks differently when writing in different forms, and certain kinds of knowledge become available only when the writer is given permission to work in forms the

⁸ *Dichtung* (German): the word ordinarily translates as *poetry* but names, in the Heideggerian-Hölderlinian tradition van Manen draws on, a broader mode of language in which truth is disclosed through composition rather than description. It carries a secondary sense in ordinary German of *density* or *thickness* — the concentration of meaning compressed into language beyond what literal prose could carry. Gadamer (1960/2004) develops the concept at length in *Truth and Method*, distinguishing *Dichtung* from *Poesie* (poetry as literary genre) and locating it as the condition under which hermeneutic understanding becomes possible.

conventional scholarly register excludes. Among the writing experiments she proposes, poetic representation is the practice most directly relevant to this thesis: representing interview and primary-source speech using "the words, rhythms, figures of speech, breath points, pauses, syntax, and diction" of the speaker, rather than paraphrasing the source into undifferentiated analytic prose (p. 942). Richardson positions poetic representation as a legitimate research finding rather than supplementary illustration—a form in which certain truths of the interview become available that analytic paraphrase would flatten. The thesis applies this principle to every primary-source quotation in the case studies: the Feather interview with Alice, the Radha Botofasina-Reyes testimony from brown (2021), the Coltrane-Turiyasangitananda passages from *Monument Eternal* (1977) and the contemporary fieldwork material are each handled in registers that attend to how the primary source actually speaks, as experienced by the researcher.

In *Marshall McLuhan's Mosaic: Probing the Literary Origins of Media Studies* (2012), Elena Lamberti provides the media-studies grounding from inside the lineage the lit review engages through McLuhan's *Understanding Media* (1964). Lamberti's humanist literary scholarship demonstrates that McLuhan's mosaic prose style—the jumps, the aphorisms, the refusal of linear argument, and the citation of advertising copy alongside Joyce alongside the pre-Socratics—was McLuhan's deliberate poetics in Umberto Eco's sense: the operative project pervading his work that led to a given form at once original and traditional. Lamberti traces the mosaic's literary inheritance through four Modernist writers (Ford Madox Ford, James Joyce, Ezra Pound, Wyndham Lewis) and through the ancient *paideia* of grammar, rhetoric, and dialectic McLuhan adapted to twentieth-century media inquiry. The mosaic is, in Lamberti's reading, an original *verbo-voco-visual* form—acoustic rather than linear, engaging the human sensorium as a tactile and participatory process rather than as distanced visual reception. The thesis's prose-poetic

register is continuous with McLuhan's media poetics, which is itself continuous with the Modernist literary poetics McLuhan inherited. McLuhan will return later in this chapter as one of the two principal naming-sources for the thesis's mosaic-lensed deframement—where his mosaic-as-method, grounded in Von Békésy's psychoacoustics, meets Glissant's *planetary creolization*. The writerly-methodological and the analytical-methodological are, in McLuhan as in the thesis, a single operation. When the lit review cites McLuhan on the bypassing of alphabetic language toward cosmic consciousness, it is citing a writer whose own prose was already performing, at the level of form, the move his content was announcing.

María Lugones's *Pilgrimages/Peregrinajes: Theorizing Coalition against Multiple Oppressions* (2003) grounds the register choice as political-philosophical commitment beyond the phenomenological and methodological reasons. Lugones names her book “a rhetorical pilgrimage toward writing from within resistance rather than about it”, arguing that the logic of resistance is *praxical* and cannot be appreciated or critiqued from outside it. The earlier chapters of her book, she writes, are where she was “learning to depart from the tradition of philosophical writing in which I was schooled” —the tradition that keeps the writer outside what is being written about, producing descriptions rather than inhabiting the conditions the writing addresses (p. 12). In place of the single analytical voice, Lugones practices what she calls *poli-vocality*—the cultivation of multiple communicative logics within a single text, refusing the impersonal universal that philosophical tradition requires. Writing about Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda's practice in the voice of the distanced observer would reproduce, inside the thesis's own writing, the operation the jazz press performed on her when it reclassified her as the widow-custodian of her husband's legacy: a flattening of the practice into the categories the reception apparatus had available. The register refusal is Lugones's rhetorical pilgrimage

extended into the conditions of this inquiry, and her poli-vocality the warrant for letting the researcher's voice, the primary source's voice, and the contemporary kinship network's voices each sound at their own cadence in the prose that engages them.

Audre Lorde's 'Poetry Is Not a Luxury' (1977/1984) makes the deepest affirmative statement of the register choice as survival and revolutionary work. Lorde writes that "poetry is not a luxury. It is a vital necessity of our existence" (p. 37)—and by poetry she means poetic thought and poetic expression as the mode by which, in her phrasing, we "give name to those ideas which are—until the poem—nameless and formless, about to be birthed but already felt" (p. 36).

Lorde's argument is that people whose experience exceeds the dominant culture's categories need a different register in order to name what is happening to them at all, and the poetic register is where that naming becomes possible. The thesis's engagement with what Coltrane's practice does—the threshold-dwelling where dissonance and resonance pulse against each other in simultaneous presence, traced in the close listenings—is precisely an attempt to name something the analytic-musicological register reaches incompletely on its own. Lorde provides the Black feminist warrant for the naming practice the thesis performs.

Five disciplinary traditions—phenomenology, qualitative methodology, media studies historiography, decolonial feminist philosophy, Black feminist poetics—have arrived independently at the same methodological position under different names. The convergence itself is a rehearsal: the case studies will stage, at a different scale, the same analytical operation the methodology's grounding has just performed—independently derived vocabularies converging on a single structural figure without collapsing into synthesis, each tradition retaining its integrity while the convergence itself becomes audible as evidence. The form of the thesis' methodological grounding enacts the form of the analytic the thesis will perform. A convergence

of five traditions on a single position is evidence that the position is structural rather than stylistic—that the prose-poetic register is what honest inquiry into this object requires and that the requirement has been named and defended by five generations of scholars across disciplines the conventional academic register treats as distant from one another.

On Grounding

Before the methodological lineages can be articulated, the condition they respond to must be named. Vandana Shiva (1993) identifies it at the most material level: *monocultures of the mind*—the global imposition of a single knowledge framework that operates by making local diversity disappear from perception (p. 9).⁹ The first externally imposed violence is invisibility. Psychocarceral enframement as the internally enacted violence of self-shrinking potentiates affordances that this monoculture manipulates to embed its logics in the psyche.

Yuk Hui (2021) extends this diagnosis into the register of technics—encompassing both the material instruments and the noetic practices through which a given cosmic order is maintained or refused. His concept of *cosmotechnics*—the unification of the cosmic order and the moral order through technical activities (p. 41)—reveals that what has been diagnosed as enframing is the essence of one particular cosmotechnical tradition: the Western Promethean one. Other traditions—Chinese, Indian, African diasporic, indigenous—maintain different relations between cosmos and technics, relations in which the technical is a practice of co-constitution with the cosmic. Hui’s call for *technodiversity*—the active cultivation of multiple cosmotechnical traditions against the homogenizing force of the globalized Western model—is the philosophical

⁹ Shiva has argued elsewhere that the “hard problem” of consciousness is itself an artifact of Cartesian partition: “typical of Cartesian thought—to take a constructed divide and then keep wondering how you’ll overcome the divide, rather than realize that the divide is constructed” (Shiva, 2024). This thesis shares that orientation—the question is not what consciousness is, but what is done with it.

architecture that Coltrane's perennialist creolization already enacts. Her atomic/atmanic physics, her devotional ontology, her composition, her multi-instrumental palette, her ashram recordings, her pedagogical encounters—these are technical activities through which a specific cosmic order is realized. Coltrane's practice is a cosmotechnical assemblage. This mosaiced view is the procedure through which this thesis holds multiple cosmotechnical traditions in simultaneous relation. Technodiversity as method.

Cosmotechnical [non]Lineages

The five writerly-methodological traditions above ground the register; the four analytical lineages below constitute the apparatus. Each is a product of the European philosophical tradition—deployed here as instruments for a transmission they could not have generated alone, in the same way that Coltrane deployed the piano, the Wurlitzer, and the recording studio as vehicles for a broader cosmic order none of those instruments were specifically designed to carry. Each is engaged here as a living philosophical project whose full implications bear on the investigation.

Laruelleian non-philosophy. François Laruelle's project identifies a structural gesture common to all philosophies—the decision by which a system of thought posits itself as sufficient to the *Real* it addresses—and suspends that gesture (Laruelle, 1998). Non-philosophy refuses to let any framework occupy the position of final authority over the *Real* it describes. Laruelle calls this the principle of *unilateral duality*: the *Real* determines thought; thought does not determine the *Real*. Every framework deployed in this thesis has been activated under this suspension. None has

been permitted to stand as the master-discourse that explains Coltrane's praxis. Her practice is the ground from which the theoretical apparatus receives its authorization.¹⁰

Rhizomatic analysis. Deleuze and Guattari's (1987) concept of the *rhizome* is a complete ontological proposition: reality constituted by multiplicities connecting at any point to any other point, without a central root or trunk to organize the relations (pp. 3–25). For this thesis, rhizomatic analysis refuses the hierarchical organization of the traditions Coltrane's radical perennialist creolization holds in simultaneous relation. No tradition is root; no tradition is supplement. The wisdom traditions of the Bhagavad Gita do not anchor the harp. The harp does not illustrate Sufi teachings, Detroit Gospel, or Stravinsky. They connect laterally, through the practitioner's body, in ways no arborescent genealogy can map. That these connections hold is because they share a ground—what Coltrane names the Absolute and what the rhizomatic ontology gestures toward when Deleuze and Guattari themselves arrive at the recognition that consistency finds its conditions “only on a properly cosmic plane, where all the disparate and heterogeneous elements are convoked” (1987, p. 327). The convergence between this cosmic plane and Coltrane's Absolute has yet to be fully acknowledged—by the authors, by their institutional reception, or by the critical traditions that have inherited the rhizome as a figure of pure horizontality. The apparent opposition between transcendence and immanence dissolves in practice—Coltrane's Absolute operates within every atom precisely because it exceeds every atom, a structure Vedantic philosophy¹¹ never needed to divide: “because of this closeness, I do

¹⁰ The adjacency between Laruelle's Real and Coltrane's Absolute—both naming what unilaterally determines thought while remaining foreclosed to the systems that would claim to explain it—is not incidental. It is the convergence that makes non-philosophy methodologically necessary for this investigation.

¹¹ Radhakrishnan, the first Vice President and later second President of India, repeatedly identifies Spinoza's metaphysics as the closest Western parallel to Advaita Vedanta, drawing extended structural comparisons between *natura naturans* and Brahman (Radhakrishnan, 1923, pp. 566–567). Deleuze and Guattari's plane of consistency is explicitly indebted to this same Spinozist substrate.

not know what loneliness is, nor do I know what it feels like to be lonely, for I am never alone” (Coltrane-Turiyasangitananda, 1977, p. 47).

Feminist autoethnography. The autoethnographic turn in qualitative research positions the researcher’s lived experience as epistemologically constitutive. Feminist autoethnography (Ellis, 2004; Boylorn & Orbe, 2014) insists that the researcher’s body carries the structures of power, privilege, and vulnerability that the research addresses—Haraway’s (1988) refusal of the disembodied observer (p. 581). In this thesis, the claim is specific: the inquiry began at fifteen on Souseek, already mid-transmission. The researcher’s initiated subjectivity is the primary demonstration of the argument. The researcher’s archive is distributed across working session documents, digital exchanges, photographs, autoethnographic narrative, and memory—the same distributed media through which the transmission itself propagates. The unconventional archive is the argument.

Arche-writing. Derrida’s (1967/1997) concept of *arche-writing* names the condition of inscription prior to both speech and writing—the trace-structure through which meaning is constituted by difference and deferral (p. 60). Lindberg (2024) notes that Stiegler explicitly stated his ambition to study in the domain of music the same question Derrida had studied under the name of grammatology (p. 181)—and the concept of *tertiary retention* that emerges from that study accounts for how Coltrane’s recorded oeuvre, her written texts, the *Akashic* register she describes, and the inscriptions that continue to propagate through the lineage function as carriers of presencing consciousness across the ruptures of death, distance, and *the monolingualism of the other*.

Mosaic-Lensed Deframement

The mosaic in mosaic-lensed deframement is not the methodology's imposition on Coltrane's practice. It is her own word. In a 1987 interview with Robert Palmer for The New York Times, Coltrane described the cosmic music she had carried forward from her shared vision with John as "a mosaic of sound and energy... an expression of the colors and varieties of sound, and how they interweave and complement each other" (Coltrane, in Palmer, 1987, as cited in Beta, 2026). The methodology adopts her figure and trains itself to honor what the figure already names: a relation in which multiple distinct elements remain audible as themselves while contributing to a larger unfolding that does not collapse them into synthesis.

This methodology has been a planetary creolization from its first breath, and the time has arrived to name what it has been doing—and to name it carefully, because the word creolization carries a historical weight that deserves to be carried rather than glided past. Édouard Glissant developed *créolisation* from the specific historical experience of the Caribbean: the forced encounter of African, indigenous Carib/Arawak, European, Indian, and Chinese populations on the plantation, generating something genuinely new while none of the source traditions dissolved into the others (Glissant, 1997, p. 33). The concept was rooted in Black Caribbean experience and emerged from Black diasporic thought. Beginning in *Poetics of Relation* (1990/1997) and culminating in *Treatise on the Whole-World* (1997), Glissant himself opened creolization to the planetary—speaking of *the creolization of the world* and offering the concept as a diagnostic of what happens wherever irreducible particulars meet in conditions of generative encounter. *Mosaic-lensed deframement*, the methodological figure this thesis has been operating under from its first breath, is a work towards the planetary creolization Glissant extended—the thesis takes the door he himself opened and walks through it.

This thesis is written from a positionality the writer holds with care: a body the eye reads as white, a kinship to the Stockbridge-Munsee Band of Mohican Indians carried in the genealogical and acoustic record, an inquiry into a Black woman whose own kinship network—as the thesis’s footnote 41 documents—included a Native American great-great-grandfather whose primal energy moved through her in meditation (Adams, 2016, p. 7). The kinship network the case studies and ending chapter trace is itself creolized in Glissant’s specific sense: African American, Punjabi-Canadian, Tamil South Indian, Nigerian-Canadian, Mohican, Mexican-American, Brazilian, Japanese, and European-American particulars among others meeting in conditions of generative encounter without any of them dissolving into the others. The methodology extends what is already enacted by the practice it engages.

The planetary operation Glissant opened the door to is not exclusive to Glissant’s vocabulary. It is the structural move at the heart of a constellation of convergent frameworks the thesis deploys. Marshall McLuhan, in the prologue to *The Gutenberg Galaxy* (1962), names his own methodological commitment in the same terms: “The Gutenberg Galaxy develops a mosaic or field approach to its problems. ... Thus the galaxy or constellation of events upon which the present study concentrates is itself a mosaic of perpetually interacting forms that have undergone kaleidoscopic transformation.” McLuhan grounds the mosaic approach in Georg von Békésy’s psychoacoustics, identifying it as “the only relevant approach” to “the simultaneous which is the auditory field” (pp. 41–43). The thesis’s *mosaic-lensed deframement* is named through McLuhan’s mosaic-as-method as much as it is named through Glissant’s planetary creolization—the two are converging on the same structural operation from different shores, one grounded in the psychoacoustics of the auditory field, the other in the lived historical experience of the Caribbean plantation. Within the same *Gutenberg Galaxy*, McLuhan deploys Joyce’s

“collideroscope” (Finnegans Wake; McLuhan, 1962, p. 75) as the figure for “the means of living simultaneously in all cultural modes while quite conscious”—*collide* for the savage and oral and sacral, *scope* for the visual and profane and civilized, the colloidal interplay holding both without resolution. Around these two principal naming-sources cluster further articulations of the same convergent operation: Laruelle’s *non-philosophy* and the principle of *unilateral duality*; Deleuze and Guattari’s *rhizome* (1987), in which lateral connection holds without root or hierarchy; Derrida’s generative *différance* (1968/1982), in which meaning is constituted by difference and deferral rather than by identity or origin; Medina’s *kaleidoscopic consciousness* (2013), in which multiple perspectival positions are held simultaneously without collapse into synthesis. These frameworks emerge from radically different positionalities—Black Caribbean diasporic, Catholic Canadian media theory, Irish modernist literature, French philosophy of religion, French post-structural philosophy, Latinx social epistemology—and most are not in any explicit relation to Black subjectivity. What they share is the structural operation the thesis enacts: the holding-open of multiple traditions in generative, non-totalizing relation, where each particular retains its integrity and the encounter generates what no single tradition could have generated alone. *Mosaic-lensed deframement* is the name this thesis offers for what the convergent constellation is doing. That McLuhan grounds his mosaic in psychoacoustics is itself part of the convergence: the figure-ground architecture the case studies will analyze in Coltrane’s recordings—the sustained tamboura field holding the interior movement of the harp—operates in the same psychoacoustic substrate where McLuhan locates the mosaic approach as the only relevant method to the simultaneous auditory field.

The procedure is the practice. Coltrane was a translator. The thesis writes about her translation-practice through a translation-practice that takes hers as its disciplinary model and the

constellation of convergent frameworks as its theoretical grounding. The mosaic that emerges across the chapters that follow is itself a small enactment of the analytic the thesis offers as a method—and an honoring of the Black Caribbean shore from which the planetary extension of creolization was first opened.

Radical Reflex-Ability

Within music studies, Monson (1996)¹² established the methodological precedent for this investigation: her study of jazz improvisation as interaction argues that *groove* is a site of mutual responsiveness—a field of collective attention in which each player’s listening is as constitutive as their playing (pp. 68–69). Grazian (2004) extends this, observing that ethnography, like music, is an interpretive practice requiring participation and improvisation whose presentation invites a multiplicity of meanings as well as self-reflection (p. 206). The fieldwork’s epistemological center is not the selected encounters documented in the vignettes but the sustained presence in the New York City avant-garde music scene within which those encounters became legible as encounters—the hundreds of shows, conversations, and ordinary nights out across 2023–2026 that constituted the researcher’s orientation and against whose accumulated texture the selected events register as significant. The vignettes are not samples from a dataset. They are the moments at which the scene’s operation rose into audibility, selected for what they revealed about the transmission rather than for representativeness. This thesis operates at the far edge of

¹² In the late stages of this research, the researcher discovered that Ingrid Monson served as one of Rajna Swaminathan’s dissertation advisors. The discovery landed on an arc already running: Swaminathan’s *Apertures* (2023), whose felt-resonances drew the researcher to the Apollo Café in December 2023 and through ganavya’s subsequent Instagram exchange into the kinship network the fieldwork traces, had itself reached the researcher through an algorithm whose pattern-of-delivery had been training on the transmission since 2001—since Souleek, the shared T1 connection, the stranger’s directive to start with *Illuminations*, narrated in the Introduction. The methodological lineage is not external to the kinship network; they are the same creolized field, and they began arriving together long before the researcher had a framework to receive them as arrivals at all. The thesis’s final chapter documents this operation at length, where the network is found to have recognized the researcher before the researcher had recognized themselves in it. Monson’s claim that groove is a site of mutual responsiveness is being instantiated by the conditions under which this footnote is written.

that trajectory: the researcher is initiated, constituted by the transmission. The departure from the tradition is itself a finding.

Through Her Wisdom Eye

The theoretical engagements of this thesis are distributed across its chapters, each of which brings a distinct constellation of interlocutors into contact with a specific articulation of the assemblage. The methodology establishes the commitments under which the engagement operates. The literature review assembles the generative vocabulary—the analytical apparatus the case studies deploy. Chapter One engages *Monument Eternal* (1977) as initiatory philosophical text, opening the cosmological vocabulary the thesis develops and the recordings articulate in their own medium. Three case studies follow, each engaging a recorded sonic artifact through the apparatus the literature review has assembled: "Turiya and Ramakrishna" (1970), "Journey to Satchidananda" in its ashram bhajan version (released 2017), and "Translinear Light" (2004). Each case study closes with an ethnographic vignette drawn from the researcher's sustained field-orientation in New York City's contemporary avant-garde music scene (2023–2026). Each case study enters through a specific sonic artifact and reads it through a kaleidoscopically generative mosaic until the deframement reveals what the artifact was always-already doing before the analysis arrived. The ethnographic field-orientation—demonstrating the transmission's ongoing operation in the present—constitutes its own chapter, where the previously examined shards of Coltrane's tertiary retentions are excited through the researcher's lived experience, tracing the *fugitive planning*¹³ (Moten & Harney, 2013) through which the

¹³ Moten and Harney's fugitive planning names a mode of collective organization that operates beneath and beyond institutional capture—"an improvisation that proceeds from somewhere on the other side of an unasked question" (Moten & Harney, 2013, p. 11). The transmission this thesis traces plans its own propagation through whatever infrastructure is available.

transmission propagates from the digital-virtual interface into the lived materiality of New York City's contemporary avant-garde music scene.

Stiegler's pharmacological framework—which Lindberg (2024) demonstrates emerged from a fundamentally musical problematic (pp. 181–184)—is explicit in the method. His account of technics as simultaneously curative and toxic provides the sharpest analysis of how psychocarceral enframement and phronetic transmission coexist within the same technological substrate. The algorithm and the ashram are both technics of memory. The difference is whether the technic is oriented toward care (*epiméleia*) or capture—and, as Hui's cosmotechnics reveals, which cosmic order orients the relation. This thesis is itself a technic—a tertiary retention that will circulate beyond the researcher's control. Its ethical obligation is to operate as an instrument of care: accountable to Coltrane's practice, transparent about its partiality, and oriented toward the co-constitutive knowledge generation that the holding-open of the break makes possible.

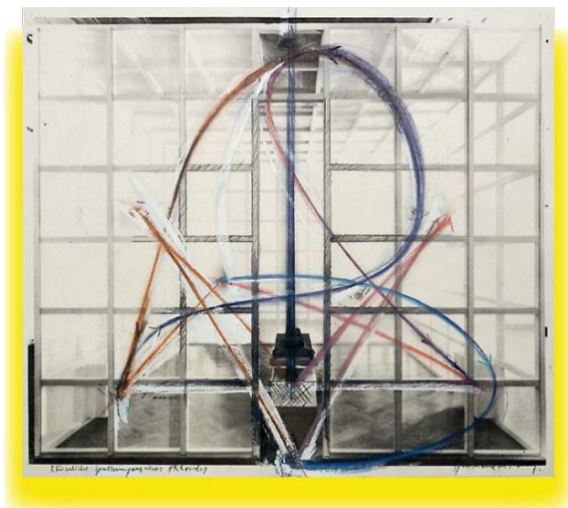


Figure 1. Bernhard Leitner, *Räumliche Spaltungen eines Akkordes* [Spatial Splittings of a Chord], from the Sound Cube (*TON-WÜRFEL*) series (reproduced in Groys, 2008). The rigid geometry of the spatial grid undergoes a splitting via the intentionality of a sounding chord—the first movement of deframement. *Museum moderner Kunst Wien* (1981) and *documenta 7* (1982). Image courtesy of Georg Kargl Fine Arts.

Literature Review

"This book will perhaps only be understood by those who have themselves already thought the thoughts which are expressed in it—or similar thoughts. [...] Its object would be attained if there were one person who read it with understanding and to whom it afforded pleasure."

— Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*, Preface (1922)

This chapter stages the interlocutors whose work the thesis draws into conversation without subordinating Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda's practice to any of their frameworks. The direction of determination runs from her inward practice outward. Each theorist enters on the theorist's own terms, is allowed to argue their case, and takes their place as a constellated node in the non-hierarchical cosmic mosaic the previous chapter has assembled. What follows is a mosaic. The mosaic resists syntheses. It is an arrayed assemblage whose coherence depends on the quality of attention brought to the spaces between its shards—and on the discipline of holding the contradictions those spaces contain rather than resolving them away.

Creolization: Structures of Relation

Édouard Glissant (1997) offers the most precise name for the operation through which Coltrane's philosophical vocabulary was composed. *Poetics of Relation* articulates creolization not as the hybridization of prior purities but as the generative encounter of irreducibly specific particulars producing something genuinely new while each source retains its distinctiveness. Glissant distinguishes *Relation identity*—identity as the capacity to be in relation without requiring a common root—from *Root identity*, the identity that secures itself by filiation and excludes what cannot be assimilated to its line (Glissant, 1997, p. 143). Relation identity is not the absence of ground; it is ground reconstituted as the capacity for what Glissant calls *donner-avec*—"giving-with"—and for opacity, the right of the other not to be reduced to the transparency a sovereign understanding would demand of them (pp. 189–194).

Glissant's *errantry* names the movement of a subject whose wandering is not exile but a disciplined refusal of the root's claim to originary authority. To err, in Glissant's sense, is to remain in relation without demanding that relation resolve into a single narrative of belonging (Glissant, 1997, pp. 18–20). This is the formal structure of Coltrane's intellectual biography—a library ranging across Vedantic scripture, Christian theology, Sufi mysticism, atomic physics, Egyptian cosmology, and the Western perennialist canon from Blavatsky forward—and it is the formal structure of her compositional practice, where a Wurlitzer organ, a harp, a tanpura, a Baptist choir, and Sanskrit bhajans are not synthesized into a new style but held in relation. The methodology of this thesis inherits the same structure: each tradition the chapter touches is received in its specificity and placed in relation to the others without being subordinated to a master frame.

On Archivization

Bernard Stiegler (1998) opens the methodological frame within which Coltrane's account of vibrational memory becomes legible at the register Western philosophy has found hardest to articulate. *Technics and Time, I* argues that consciousness is not interior to a self which subsequently engages with external technologies; consciousness and technics are co-originary (Stiegler, 1998, pp. 17–30). What Husserl named *primary retention*—the just-past held in the now of perception—and *secondary retention*—the remembered past recalled into the present — are supplemented and made possible by a third register Stiegler terms *tertiary retention*: the externalized *mnemic* support, the trace inscribed in matter—the record, the text, the photograph, the recording (pp. 243–250). Tertiary retention is not secondary to consciousness; it is the condition of any consciousness whose temporal extension reaches beyond the biological horizon of a single life.

Stiegler's account inherits the struggle Plato staged in the *Phaedrus* between *mnēmē*, living memory internal to the one who remembers, and *hypomnēsis*, the external prosthesis of memory that threatens to displace the living act (Derrida, 1981, pp. 91–95, via Stiegler, 1998, pp. 271–276). For Plato this was cause for alarm; for Stiegler it is the condition of human historical existence. There is no *mnēmē* that was not already contaminated by *hypomnēsis*; every tradition of living practice depends on the technical supports that make its transmission possible. The pharmacological framing is Stiegler's key move: tertiary retention is neither cure nor poison but *pharmakon*—it enables what it also endangers (Stiegler, 1998, pp. 152–156; cf. Derrida, 1981).

For this thesis, Stiegler's apparatus enables a reading this work has not yet staged. Coltrane's *Akasha*¹⁴ names the register itself—the field in which every vibration, thought, and movement persists as a condition of its having occurred at all. What Stiegler calls tertiary retention is the actualization of that persistence into perceivable inscription: the record, the cassette, the text, the recording. Coltrane's own account positions Akasha precisely: "positioned a few feet from a person—or, when two or more are gathered, in the center of the room" (Coltrane-Turiyasangitananda, 1977, p. 31). The Akashic field is not distant or abstract. It is the present, local register whose density the practitioner's attunement makes articulable and from which, as substrate, tertiary retentions are drawn into the Real through the technical acts of recording, composing, teaching, and transmitting.

¹⁴ Sanskrit *ākāśa* (colloquially spelled *ākāsha*), translated often as "ether" or "sky," names "the element that I was raised to believe exists in-between and in all things; it is the space that exists beyond space, within space, and without space. It suggests that the same pre-material that forms divinity, love, and all of the world's graces also form difficulty, pain, and all of the world's gravities" (Doraiswamy, 2024, pp. 15–16, fn. 4). In Vedantic cosmology the term designates the subtle foundational dimension in which every vibration, thought, and articulation persists as a condition of its having occurred at all. Alice's reception of the teaching from John Coltrane Ohnedaruth, narrated below, inscribes this cosmological register as the archival substrate of the thesis' *presencing consciousness*.

Derrida's trace names what inscription is in either register: the held contradiction that is the origin of the origin, the non-self-identity through which the trace is a trace per se as it exceeds any cut. No inscription, whether held in the Akashic field or actualized as material tertiary retention, escapes this structure; every inscription is already repeatable, already deferred, already in excess of any enclosure that would seal it as finished presence. This thesis' method is to hold Coltrane's cosmological account of Akasha alongside Stiegler's material-technical analysis of retention and Derrida's structural account of the trace, each register doing its own work without being reduced to the others. It is in this structure that the thesis's central term, *presencing consciousness*, operates: not as the recall of a past event into a present awareness, but as the condition in which tertiary retentions actualize what the Akashic field holds, and the receiver's attunement renders the trace perceptible as what it is—the living transmission whose self-non-identity is precisely what makes it transmissible at all.

Subject: Object; Figure: Ground

Black musical practice has long been received as a case that confirms theoretical claims made elsewhere. Fred Moten's *In the Break* (2003) radiates from what he calls "the critical remixing of nonconvergent tracks" (p. 11)—a procedure that refuses the direction Western theory has conventionally taken when approaching Black musical practice: for Moten, the Black radical tradition is not a case that confirms theoretical claims made elsewhere; it is the site from which the theoretical claims of Western modernity are themselves heard, belatedly, as echoes. The book opens with a thesis whose force is structural: "The history of blackness is testament to the fact that objects can and do resist" (Moten, 2003, p. 1). Blackness is then defined as "the extended movement of a specific upheaval, an ongoing *irruption* that *anarranges* every line" (p. 1), and the subject whose possession-of-its-objects defines modern subjectivity is shown to be troubled at its foundation by "a dispossessive force objects exert such that the subject seems to be

possessed—infused, deformed—by the object it possesses" (p. 1). What Moten is interested in is the phonic materiality of this propriative exertion: the sound that is heard at the scene where objectification and humanization mark each other simultaneously.

Moten's second chapter names the location of the operation: *the break*—in his words, "a site at once internal and interstitial" to the structures Black musical practice is often read as opposing from outside (Moten, 2003, p. 85). "Syncopation, performance, and the anarchic organization of phonic substance delineate an ontological field wherein black radicalism is set to work" (p. 85). The break's mode is "a cutting and abundant refusal of closure," and this refusal "is not a rejection but an ongoing and reconstructive improvisation of ensemble" (p. 85). Moten then stages what is perhaps the most consequential move of the book for this thesis: the break involves "a disruptive doubling of certain other theoretical hallmarks of 'our modernity'" (p. 86), and Heidegger's anxiety about technology and Derrida's deconstruction of total definition are figured as "Euro-intellectual echoes" played against a Black sonic backdrop—not as prior frames that authorize Black aesthetic production but as echoes that arrive late to what the break had already been doing. The doubling is itself the remixing named at the section's opening: the break remixes the Euro-theoretical tracks against the Black sonic backdrop they had been playing against all along, and the remix transforms what each track meant when isolated from the other. For Coltrane's practice, which enacts a refusal of closure and a reconstructive improvisation of ensemble at the register of cosmological devotion, this framing holds the center of determination where it belongs. Moten's phonography—"anticipatory rewriting" as the Black radical mode of mnemonic inscription (p. 86)—attaches to the structure the prior section established as the register at which tertiary retention becomes audible in the Black radical tradition, without requiring that structure to multiply its terms.

Awakened by the Unstruck

Hazrat Inayat Khan's *The Mysticism of Sound and Music* (1923/1996) presents at cosmological register a grounding analogous to Moten's phonic materiality—the cosmology from which Coltrane drew much of her vocabulary for the relation of sound to manifestation. Khan's central claim is ontological and unqualified: "The whole system of Hindu religion and philosophy is based on the science of vibration and is called *Nada Brahma*, Sound-God" (Khan, 1923/1996, p. 9). Creation, for Khan, is vibration cohering into form under the registers of sensorial reading—first audible, then visible: "The creative source in its first step towards manifestation was audible, and in its next step it was visible. It also shows that all we see in this objective world—every form—has been constructed by sound: it is the phenomenon of sound" (p. 74). This is not metaphor. It is the structural claim that sound is prior to and constitutive of the visible and that what the eye takes as the ground of reality is a second-order condensation of a vibrational field the ear accesses more directly.

Khan distinguishes audible sound from the universal sound of which audible sound is the descent. "The material sound of instruments, or of the voice produced by the human organs of sound, is really the outcome of the universal sound of the spheres which can only be heard by those in tune with it. This state is called *anahad nada* by Yogis, and *sawt-e-sarmad* by Sufis" (Khan, 1923/1996, p. 10). The unstruck sound is not a distant cosmological abstraction; it is the ground from which audible sound is produced, and the practitioner's attunement to it is the condition for audible sound to operate as more than noise. The drone practices of Hindustani and Sufi devotional music—tanpura, shruti box, long pedal tones in religious song—are the technologies through which audible sound is held in continuous contact with the unstruck ground from which it descends.

Khan carries a second thread that bears directly on what Western reception of Black and non-Western musical traditions has often suppressed: the priority of voice over instrument. "The first instrument was the flute, symbolical of the human voice. It seems natural that man took a piece of reed from the forest and made in the heart of that reed four holes in places where he could easily put the tips of his fingers... That made the Raga of five notes" (Khan, 1923/1996, p. 65). Instruments are not technologies that enable vocal imitation; they are impoverished reproductions of what the voice already carries. The vina, whose prestige in Hindustani music is considerable, achieves its prestige precisely by approaching the condition of voice: "If you hear the vina played you will never think that it is an instrument, you cannot imagine that it is an instrument... all the delicacies of the human voice and the silky structure of it are finished in the sound of the vina" (p. 73). And finally: "When one compares the voice with the instrument, there is no real comparison, because the voice is life itself. The movement, the glance, the touch, even the breath that comes from the nostrils do not reach so far, not as far as the voice reaches" (p. 82). For Coltrane, whose creolizing practice received Khan's vocabulary into a register that was already her own, voice-as-origin is not an exotic doctrine imported from Hindustani cosmology; it is a structural claim the devotional traditions she drew from—Black Christian praise singing, Sufi *dhikr*, Hindu *bhajan*—already enacted as practice.

Eric Dolphy named the same condition from inside the practice. In an April 1964 interview with Michiel de Ruyter in Amsterdam—three months before his death and the audio later appended to the close of *Last Date* (1965)—Dolphy said: "When you hear music after it's over, after it's over, it's gone in the air, you can never capture it again, so it's pure creation" (Dolphy, in de Ruyter, 1964). The clause that matters is the closing one. Dolphy is not lamenting what recording cannot hold. He is naming the impossibility of capture as the structural condition that makes the music

creative in the first place. What exceeds the artifact is not its loss but its generativity—the same generativity Stiegler theorizes under the name of tertiary retention's necessary insufficiency and the same generativity the thesis names when it speaks of *Akasha* as the medium in which what was sounded continues to sound, not fully recoverable to the recording yet active in the kinship networks the recording potentiates.

Repeat... i Repeat: It's Better Not-Spoken-Of

Jacques Derrida's *Of Grammatology* (1976) and *Plato's Pharmacy* (1981) open a reading of writing that refuses the resolution the canonized readings of Western philosophy since Plato have sought between speech and writing—not by collapsing the opposition but by showing that the distinction was always-already inhabited by the trace that makes both possible. Derrida's *arche-writing* is not the alphabet, not the graphic inscription of spoken words onto a surface, nor writing in the restricted sense the term names in everyday use (Derrida, 1976, pp. 6–26, 44–73). Arche-writing is the condition of possibility of any signifying system at all—the play of difference and deferral, the structure Derrida names *trace*, or the "non-original origin of the origin" that precedes and makes possible the distinction between speech and writing, presence and absence, voice and script (pp. 61–65). What alphabetic writing has been able to do is give Western philosophy a specific target to privilege or to denigrate; what arche-writing names is the prior operation without which the target itself would not exist.

This matters for the reading of a 1997 conversation between Derrida and Ornette Coleman published as "The Other's Language" (Derrida & Coleman, 2004), which has been taken as a meeting between Western critical theory and Black experimental music. Coleman tells Derrida that his practice of *Harmolodics* involves musicians who "manufacture [their] own words with a precise idea of what those words should mean" (p. 321), and further that "sound has a more

democratic relationship to information because you do not need the alphabet to understand music" (p. 319). Coleman's "no alphabet needed" names what arche-writing already is—a signifying operation that does not require alphabetic inscription to be a writing, a sounding that manufactures its own words whose rule is immanent to the playing rather than applied from outside. Coleman and Derrida converge here from different sides of the same break: Coleman from the Black musical tradition's long practice of sounding-as-writing, Derrida from the deconstruction of the speech-privileged metaphysics that would have made Coleman's practice illegible as writing in the first place. That they converge at all—given Moten's prior section's argument that Euro-theory arrives as echo against a Black sonic backdrop—is itself a specific operation: the clearing in which their convergence happens has already been cleared by the Black radical tradition's prior sounding, and Derrida's deconstruction arrives late to a terrain Coleman's practice had been working all along. The sounding-as-writing Coleman names operates at the same phonic register Moten's section theorized and Khan's *Nada Brahma* grounds cosmologically: sound as the prior condition of inscription, across three distinct traditions naming the same operation. Marshall McLuhan (1964) names the perceptual-phenomenological architecture in which this operation becomes apprehensible: [*non-Euclidean*] *acoustic space*—the register of simultaneous, boundaryless, omnidirectional relation in which sound is received from all directions at once—distinguished from *visual space*—the perspectival, sequential register European literacy consolidated as the master sensorium. McLuhan's own articulation of the structural recognition arrives, with its residual phonocentrism intact, as the speculation that electric technology might “by-pass languages in favor of a general cosmic consciousness” (McLuhan, 1964, ch. 8)—an intuition whose underlying observation, that sound is the register at

which inscription operates without the alphabetic enclosure language has been received through, is what Coltrane's practice operates from within.

The convergence runs deeper than the conversation itself registers. Derrida argues in *Plato's Pharmacy* that the distinction between *mnēmē* and *hypomnēsis* cannot be maintained because the living act of memory is already inhabited by iterability—the capacity to-be-repeated—that Plato tried to assign only to the external prosthesis (Derrida, 1981, pp. 103–117). Kierkegaard had already named the structure in his own terms: "The only repetition was the impossibility of a repetition" (Kierkegaard, 1843/1983, p. 170). Constantin Constantius's experiment in *Repetition* discovered that the return to Berlin could not reproduce the first visit and that the discovery of this impossibility was itself the only repetition available. Derrida's iterability makes the impossibility generative rather than merely negative: every utterance is repeatable precisely because it is never fully identical with itself, and the "failure" of pure self-identity is the condition of any iteration at all. Coleman's Harmolodic practice—the creation of something new that does not exclude the pre-written framework that makes it possible, repetition already inside improvisation as its intrinsic condition—enacts what Kierkegaard discovered theoretically and what Khan describes in the Brahmin practice of the *thousand-repeated word* as producing "magnetism, electricity, life current" (Khan, 1923/1996, p. 83). Four traditions, one operation. The lit review does not collapse them; it lets their convergence stand as what it is—four distinct articulations of the same held contradiction, each retaining the weight of its tradition.

A second passage in the Derrida-Coleman conversation deserves brief attention. Coleman, as a descendant of enslaved Africans, tells Derrida he has no idea what his language of origin was. Derrida, born into a family of Algerian Jews, responds that in an analogous manner it is the same for him: he has no contact with his language of origin, or with that of his supposed ancestors

(Derrida & Coleman, 2004, pp. 325–326). Both speak what Derrida elsewhere calls the *monolingualism of the other*—the condition of speaking a language that is not properly one's own and having no unmediated access to one that would be. Douglas Hofstadter's account of the self as a strange loop bears on this moment: for Hofstadter (2007), the *I* is not a substance but a self-referential pattern—a point of view that arises in a brain's capacity to represent itself to itself, and whose self-perceptions are always coarse-grained simplifications of the substrate-level activity that produces them. There is no first-person authenticity prior to the pattern; the pattern is what first-person is. (A later section of this chapter takes up Hofstadter's account of the loop's pathological mode—its fear-driven defensive self-totalization—as the formal architecture of the psychocarceral enframement Coltrane's practice refuses.) The self Coleman and Derrida are naming—no contact with language of origin, no unmediated access to a tradition that would be properly one's own—is this structural non-self-access formulated at the level of linguistic inheritance. Coleman, Derrida, Hofstadter all converge on a diagnosis that Coltrane's perennialist creolization receives as method: *monolingualism of the other* is not a lack; it is the ground from which the practitioner composes, and the tradition that would be one's own is always received through the vocabulary of traditions not originally one's own. Coltrane drew Khan's vocabulary, Blavatsky's cosmology, Christian prayer, and Vedantic ritual (to only name a few) into a practice that was hers precisely because none of the sources was hers by birth. The analogous otherness Derrida names is not a claim to parity with Coleman's condition; it is a recognition that the structural diagnosis the Black radical tradition articulates reaches beyond its originating site — what Moten and Harney (2013) name through the *Undercommons* as the conditions of fugitivity and dispossession that describe a wider terrain than Black life under racial capitalism alone, even

as the analytic remains Black in its formation and force, speaking across distinct and specific histories without collapsing their specificities into equivalence.

New Meanings

jayna brown's *Black Utopias* (2021) opens a reading of sovereignty that the thesis requires in order to name what Coltrane's practice reaches toward without mis-describing it. brown stages Sylvia Wynter's call for a new genre of the human as the threshold of the argument: "In order to speak the conception of *ontological sovereignty*, we would have to move completely outside our present conception of what it is to be human and therefore outside the ground of the orthodox body of knowledge which institutes and reproduces this conception" (Wynter, quoted in brown, 2021, p. 9). Wynter's ontological sovereignty is not the sovereignty of the liberal subject secured against threat; it is the sovereignty of a being-human that would have to be invented, because the existing category of the human has been constituted through the exclusion and objectification of racialized and colonized subjects.

brown, however, does not stop at Wynter's horizon. She presses past it with a question the utopian tradition has rarely dared: "What if the answer to the entire question of being were not ontological sovereignty at all but a different ontology altogether, other forms of awareness beyond the self, beyond individuated autonomous will? What could individuation mean outside the model of possessive individualism?" (brown, 2021, p. 9). What is at stake for brown is not the achievement of a sovereign self that finally includes what had been excluded but the question of whether sovereignty is the concept the tradition ought to retain at all. On Alice Coltrane specifically, brown writes: "Turning to Alice allows us to further explore realms of consciousness beyond self-awareness and a search for sovereignty, to dwell in a sense of diffusion—in the body and out of the body, material and immaterial" (brown, 2021, p. 60).

Diffusion, for brown, is not defeat; it is the condition the sovereign subject relinquishes in order to enter what the sovereign subject could not hold. Coltrane's practice does not arrive at sovereignty. Its armature falls away.

Psychocarceral Enframement

The condition against which Coltrane's praxis is presented as counter-action has a diagnostic lineage worth naming on its own terms. Peter Wessel Zapffe (1933/2004) argues that human consciousness, in its over-evolved state, generates a surplus of awareness that the organism cannot metabolize: "Man's survival is made possible by a more or less conscious suppression of his hazardous surplus of consciousness. This suppression is, for all intents and purposes, continuous; it goes on as long as we are awake and active and becomes a condition for social adjustment and what is popularly called 'healthy' and 'normal' behavior" (Zapffe, 1933/2004, p. 3). Zapffe identifies four mechanisms through which the suppression operates—isolation, attachment, diversion, sublimation—and names isolation as the one most consequential for daily social life: "universal, unwritten agreements to conceal our existential condition from one another" (p. 4).

Figure 2. Peter Wessel Zapffe engaged in the ironic play of verticality, climbing one of the pillars of the University of Oslo's Aula. Retrieved from Uniforum, University of Oslo, 2024



Douglas Hofstadter's (2007) account of the strange loop—the *I* as a self-referential pattern, self-monitoring and self-modifying in a feedback relation with its own emergent activity—names its own pathological mode: the selective neglect through which a self-representing system refuses certain classes of self-representation to preserve a coherent "Cartesian Ego" (Hofstadter, 2007, ch. 21), a false solidification the loop secures at the cost of what it could otherwise admit.

Hofstadter's diagnosis of fear-of-the-loop and of the ego's defensive self-totalization provides the formal architecture through which *psychocarceral enframement* recursively operates: the site at which Zapffe's four suppression mechanisms— isolation, attachment, diversion, sublimation— install themselves in the recursive structure of subject-constitution itself. Theodor Adorno (1941), as his argument is received and productively redirected by Fumi Okiji (2018), names the cultural-industrial mechanism that supplies the suppression with its material: *standardization* presented as individual expression, or *pseudo-individuation*—"the 'halo of free choice... on the basis of standardization itself'" (Adorno, quoted in Okiji, 2018, p. 7–8). These three registers— existential (Zapffe), formal (Hofstadter), cultural (Adorno)—partially-compose what this thesis names *psychocarceral enframement*: the condition in which the surplus of consciousness is continuously domesticated by architectures of legibility, productivity, and coherent self-presentation that operate below the threshold of deliberation.

Okiji's redirection of Adorno does not dismantle the diagnosis; it opens the clearing that the diagnosis, taken alone, closes prematurely. Muhal Richard Abrams, cofounder of the Association for the Advancement of Creative Musicians (AACM), tells Okiji that the AACM "is grounded in the contribution of distinct personalities" and that individualism is "a fundamental facet of human existence"—but an individualism whose necessary condition is the collective: "all the information was not put in one place... we learn from each other, because he's not like me and I'm not like him" (Abrams, quoted in Okiji, 2018, p. 7). Okiji names this *communal individualism*—a social form in which individuation is not purchased at the cost of isolation but occurs through "empathetic, ceaselessly mutating relations with other individuals and the collective whole" (Okiji, 2018, p. 8). When Adorno writes that it is no longer correct to speak of the individual, Okiji argues, he is naming a milieu that is hostile to communal individualism,

under the cover of whose "dehumanizing infrastructure... genuine communion retreats into artistic practice, social theory, and those underground spaces that have been rejected or ignored by the societal mainstream" (p. 8). The diagnosis of psychocarceral enframing thus names what Coltrane's practice refuses—and the case studies that follow take up that refusal as their subject.

Reasonance

Veit Erlmann (2010) names the historical severance that the traditions assembled above variously work to repair: the Enlightenment's suppression of resonance—the joining of reason and resonance in a single concept of personhood—in favor of a reason purified of the body's acoustic participation in the world (Erlmann, 2010, p. 31). "While reason implies the disjunction of subject and object," Erlmann writes, "resonance involves their conjunction" (p. 10).

Reasonance is the register that Enlightenment epistemology foreclosed, and its recovery is the methodological stake of bringing the interlocutors of this chapter into relation rather than into subordination. The sections that follow—the case studies—are reasonance as praxis.

Chapter Overview

The thesis, refracted through the assemblage this chapter and the methodology have together described: Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda's musicoanagogical practice cultivates a sensorium for which the transcendent and the immanent become available simultaneously—neither register reducible to the other, neither subordinated to it—and the chapters that follow engage distinct articulations of that practice across the assemblage's distinct media. *Akasha* as field, tertiary retention as actualization, the trace as non-self-identity that exceeds any cut, the break as cutting and abundant refusal of closure, vibration cohering into form under sensorial reading, sounding-as-writing across visual and acoustic space, the impossibility of repetition as the only repetition, monolingualism of the other as ground rather than lack, diffusion past sovereignty, communal

individualism against pseudo-individuation, reasonance against the Enlightenment's purification of reason from the body's acoustic participation in the world—these are not separate frameworks the practice draws upon. They are articulations, from distinct and specific traditions, of the single operation the practice performs: the holding-open of the break against the psychocarceral enframing that would close it. The chapters that follow do not test this thesis against the practice. They engage, through close listening and ethnographic field-orientation, distinct articulations of the assemblage already operating it.

A bridge chapter, three case studies, and a concluding chapter complete the work.

Chapter One engages *Monument Eternal* (Coltrane-Turiyasangitananda, 1977) as one articulation of the assemblage in the medium of Coltrane's own prose—rendering explicit, in her vocabulary, the cosmology the recordings articulate in their own medium. *Akasha*, presencing consciousness, atomic ontology, tapas as initiatory suffering, *decreative* preparation, grace as lived relation—he cosmological vocabulary the chapter assembles from her writing and from the thesis's reading of it—receive the chapter as its own argument. The chapter is also where *Infinity* (1972), Coltrane's posthumous production work on John's recordings—long dismissed by the jazz reception apparatus as widow-handling-property—is engaged as the assemblage operating at the register of musicological compositional practice, authorized by the cosmological framework *Monument Eternal* articulates in its own register. The chapter bridges the theoretical apparatus the literature review has assembled and the close-listening case studies that follow.

Case Study One engages "Turiya and Ramakrishna" (1970) as the recording in which the figure-ground architecture of the practice becomes audible in its most stripped-down configuration. The two cosmic traditions named in the title—*Turiya* (the fourth state of consciousness in Vedantic

non-dualism) and Ramakrishna (the nineteenth-century Bengali mystic whose practice held myriad devotional registers in simultaneous attunement)—are held in a single sustained frequency that the trio's sparse architecture renders structurally legible. The chapter performs the close listening Moten's phonography and Khan's *Nada Brahma* jointly authorize.

Case Study Two engages "Journey to Satchidananda" in its 1980s ashram bhajan version (released by Luaka Bop in 2017) as the site where the practice operates through collective devotional attention sustained across an ensemble. The chapter engages the recording as tertiary retention drawn from the akashic field of a specific room, specific bodies, specific moment in the ashram's devotional life—and traces how that tertiary retention continues to operate as living transmission for receivers who were never in the room. The Vedantic Center as ensemble, communal individualism in operation, is the chapter's central concern.

Case Study Three engages "Translinear Light" (2004) as the late-period synthesis where the acoustic-space architecture of the practice becomes audible across an entire recording. The chapter engages McLuhan's *acoustic space*, Bourdon's *telepresence*, Doraiswamy's *portare foglio* and *tinṇai*, and Adorno-via-Okiji's psychocarceral diagnosis as the framework through which the practice is heard in its full cosmotechnical reach.

Each case study closes with an ethnographic vignette drawn from the researcher's sustained field-orientation in the contemporary New York avant-garde music scene (2023–2026)—bringing visibility to the kinship networks that continue Coltrane's transmission in present-tense form.

The final chapter—**[In]Con-Clusion**—returns to those kinship networks and their ongoing operation in rooms the thesis has inhabited throughout the research period. The chapter is not a conclusion in the conventional sense; it is the discovery, after the fact, that the scene the field-

orientation has been documenting recognized the researcher before the researcher recognized themselves in it. The thesis's central terms—presencing consciousness, holding-open the break, psychocarceral enframement, mosaic-lensed deframement—are not concluded there; they are found to have been operating as the thesis's own composition all along.

What follows is not a sequential demonstration but a sustained mosaic. Each chapter opens by recapping the previous and re-binding itself to the thesis the literature review has restated, but its coherence depends finally on the quality of attention the reader brings to the spaces between the chapters—and on the discipline of holding the seeming-contradictions those spaces contain rather than resolving them away.

Chapter One: Opening... the Wound

Monument Eternal opens with a dedication rather than a thesis. It offers no argument. It makes no methodological claim. It is an act of devotion, and the direction of determination this case study follows is established in the opening gesture: Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda's philosophical vocabulary was generated from within a practice of revelation, austerity, and direct encounter with what she names *Absolute Consciousness*—not derived from the traditions the previous chapter engaged. The theoretical constellation assembled there is accountable to that practice, and this case study receives *Monument Eternal* as primary philosophical text: an account of revelation written, as its author describes, under divine command (Coltrane-Turiyasangitananda, 1977, Preface). Its five chapters—*Spiritual Re-awakening*, *Austerity*, *Spiritual Perception*, *Realization*, and *The Lord's Grace*—move through a cosmological ontology, an account of initiatory suffering, a phenomenology of perception beyond the material senses, an articulation of non-dual consciousness, and an index of grace as lived relation. What

follows draws from its core passages to establish the generative vocabulary of this thesis before the musicological case studies deploy it.

Coltrane opens *Monument Eternal* at the atomic level. She describes the atom as a miniature universe containing within itself the same characteristics as a solar system—a play on magnetism and harmony. Within each particle of atomic energy, she locates an irreducible order of Absolute Consciousness. This is not metaphor. She articulates a physics: "The feminine electrons hold a powerful sway over the masculine protons inside the atom ... even the smallest atoms in existence can never be destroyed—when bombarded, or cut by force, they only transform themselves" (Coltrane-Turiyasangitananda, 1977, pp. 9–10). From this atomic foundation she moves to the fires of *tapas*—the voluntary austerities through which the practitioner is purified for contact with the Supreme. She describes *tapas* as simultaneously the gentlest call and the most devastating ordeal: fasts, sleepless vigils, the body reduced from 128 to 105 pounds and later to 95, metals entering the flesh, the heart stopped several times a day (pp. 15–19). She frames the process through the figure of the alchemist: by fire, the Supreme transmutes the base metal of the human heart into gold (p. 13). The atomic ontology and the *tapas* are one operation viewed at two registers—the cosmos that cannot be destroyed but only transformed and the practitioner whose transformation is itself the demonstration.

What emerges on the other side of *tapas* is an [un]condition(ing) rather than a concept. Coltrane names it *Absolute, Manifested Formlessness*—a pure consciousness in which one functions within and beyond the smallest atom, defying detection, moving alongside others without their knowledge, attuning to the expressions of their art (pp. 20, 37–38). This is the most radical form of engagement with the world, not a withdrawal from it. A soul in this condition, she writes, "can function in at least four places at once" (p. 38). The boundary between self and field has become

nearly imperceptible, yet the practitioner retains the capacity to sense, to serve, and to compose. This is the condition the thesis has named *presencing consciousness*: the carrying of traces of the experience of the Absolute back through trans-material modes of being—sound, pedagogy, written transmission, communal recordings.

Coltrane provides the archival technology for this presencing in her account of *Akasha*—the universal memory that records every thought, word, and deed. She attributes this teaching to John Coltrane Ohnedaruth.¹⁵ who shared it with her shortly before his departure from the earthly plane (p. 31). *Akasha*, she writes, is positioned a few feet from a person—or, when two or more are gathered, in the center of the room. It "photographs and records each vibration, movement, and articulation of an individual" (p. 32). In this framework, the sonic trace is carried forward beyond the moment of its sounding: every performance, every transmission, every act of devotional listening inscribed in a cosmic register that exceeds individual memory. The cosmological-vibrational register *Akasha* names had been articulated jointly by John and Eric Dolphy five years before John's ascension, in the 1962 *DownBeat* interview through which both musicians answered Tynan's and Feather's "anti-jazz" charges: "music is a reflection of everything," Dolphy said; "it's a reflection of the universe... like having life in miniature," John affirmed (Coltrane & Dolphy, 1962). *Akasha*, as Alice receives and extends the teaching, names the archival cosmology this shared vibrational register inscribes—the register from which the recorded oeuvre continues to operate as living transmission, the register the lit review's Stiegler

¹⁵ *Ohnedaruth*, meaning "compassion," is the spiritual name Alice gave to John (Berkman, 2010, p. 65). That Alice was already operating as a namer—practicing a Swamini function before the title had been formally received—is itself consequential for how this thesis reads her practice: the cosmological-pedagogical authority she would carry at the Vedantic Center was operative well before its institutional recognition.

section theorized as tertiary retention: the technical actualization of a field Coltrane had already named on its own cosmological terms.

Monument Eternal closes on grace as lived relation. "Because of this closeness," she writes of the Supreme, "I do not know what loneliness is, nor do I know what it feels like to be lonely, for I am never alone" (p. 47). Grace is the condition Coltrane is *with*, not an event that happens *to* her. The scalar ontology, the *tapas*, the Absolute, Manifested Formlessness, and *Akasha* are not sequential stages the practitioner moves through and leaves behind. They are the simultaneously-held architecture of a single practice—the held contradiction the literature review has named, here enacted as the daily condition of one human being.

Gaze Upon the Surface of Infinity

That the jazz reception apparatus was unable to hear this architecture is a matter of historical record. In 1972, five years after John's death, Alice Coltrane released *Infinity*—an album combining her own original compositions with sessions from her recently deceased husband, reworked and re-produced under her direction. Kodwo Eshun, describing the cover art, names the aperture her critics could not enter: "To look at the front sleeve is to fall through fractalized stained glass into nested formations of spirals within spirals, kaleidoscopic iterations as blue as mother sky" (Eshun, 1998, p. 165). The spirals within spirals disclose the fractal recursion of Coltrane's atomic ontology, where the Absolute inhabits every particle of experiential reality. But the reception apparatus could not receive the cover as her cosmological proposition. Her decision to release *Infinity* was read by critics as disrespectful and demeaning to John's memory, rather than as the shared boundary-dissolving practice that John himself had deployed throughout his career. What the jazz press could hear was a widow handling property; what it could not hear

was a Black woman as co-author of a shared cosmic project, operating the compositional practice *Monument Eternal* had just finished articulating as ontology.



Figure 3. Cover art for the album *Infinity* [Image]. (1972). Wikipedia.

[https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Infinity_\(John_Coltrane_album\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Infinity_(John_Coltrane_album))

Moten's (2003) critical remixing of nonconvergent tracks names the operation with precision. Alice's work on *Infinity* was not a departure from John's recordings; it was the Black radical compositional procedure by which two nonconvergent tracks—John's saxophone sessions, Alice's orchestral and compositional additions—are remixed such that each is transformed by the other without being absorbed. This is the break operating at the register of musicological compositional practice, authorized by the cosmological framework *Monument Eternal* had just articulated. That Eshun, writing in 1998, was among the first to receive the cover on its own terms is a measure of how long the reception apparatus took to catch up to what Coltrane had done. What the thesis now receives through the lit review's theoretical apparatus—Moten's remix, Khan's *Nada Brahma*, Stiegler's tertiary retention, Glissant's creolization, brown's diffusion—is the vocabulary that was not yet available to the 1972 jazz press, through which *Infinity* can now be heard as what it always-already was.

Now, Be Here

On April 4, 2026, i arrived at a loft in Ridgewood, Queens, for Carlos Niño & Friends—the evening's ensemble featuring Marshall Allen, Darius Jones, and Austin Williamson. Allen, at 101, carries the Sun Ra Arkestra lineage in his body; as the introduction has noted, it was Sun Ra who put Hazrat Inayat Khan's *The Mysticism of Sound and Music* in John Coltrane's bag, so to speak. What Alice drew from Khan's cosmology into the vocabulary of *Monument Eternal* had traveled, by that route, through Sun Ra before it reached her. Allen—the Arkestra's current bandleader—in the room was the lineage immanent.

Before the music began, Niño recognized me and crossed the room to shake my hand. He noted i'd been at the *Total Response* event upstate. When i confirmed, he asked how i knew Nep, the artist-curator—assuming i must, since i'd been at an informal dinner afterward for friends, artists, and musicians. i explained the chain: i'd met Deep at the *Deeper* event at the Queens Museum in October 2025, and she'd introduced me to Nep and the wider withoutSHAPEwithoutFORM network the next evening. He asked how i'd heard about *Deeper*. i told him i'd been at his André 3000 show in March 2024, where in an extended stage story Dré told the audience to check out what his brothers (bandmates) were up to, and that it was pretty cool and amazing stuff. The recommendation had stayed with me. Niño smiled widely. "Oh!" he said. "*The story... and now, you're here.*" He shook my hand again, more excitedly this time, and said, "*I'll be seeing you again.*" Then we parted.

What Coltrane Turiyasangitananda (1977) names *Akasha*—the universal memory that records every thought, word, and deed, positioned a few feet from a person or, when two or more are gathered, in the center of the room (pp. 31–32)—is not a metaphor the thesis reaches for. It is the operation the encounter at the Ridgewood space performed in real time. A stage-aside released

into a room in Atlanta in March 2024 had continued to operate across two years, training the receiver's attention, routing them through so many interactions, carrying them finally into a loft where the one who had released the transmission recognized its return in the body it had reached. “*Now, you're here*”. The Akashic field recognized itself. What the Vedantic cosmology articulates, what Stiegler names as tertiary retention, and what Moten theorizes as the break's anticipatory rewriting—these are three vocabularies for what Niño's greeting named in three words. *Monument Eternal's* cosmology is lived-in-relation. The case studies that follow listen from the spaces between those relations.

Chapter Two: Case Study 001— “Turiya & Ramakrishna”

...does not begin. It is *thrown into being*—keys arriving as portamento, sliding into pitch rather than striking it, a piano chord suspended in the middle distance with the declarative weight of an orator mid-sentence, already in motion, as though the listener has been admitted mid-transmission into a frequency that was never not sounding. This is not incidental. Recorded in January 1970 in the basement studio of the Coltrane home in Dix Hills, Long Island (Kernodle, 2010, pp. 88–91), the track marks Alice Coltrane’s definitive emergence as a sovereign composer and practicing Swamini—a teacher whose instrument operates as *ontic rapport*. To name the piece is already to inhabit its argument: Turiya¹⁶ is also her name: the name received in realization rather than replacement of identity. What this chapter listens for is the figure-ground architecture of the practice as it becomes audible in a trio's stripped-down configuration—the assemblage operating at the register of so many cosmic traditions held in sustained frequencies, none absorbed into an-other.

¹⁶ The Sanskrit fourth state of pure witnessing awareness that underlies and interpenetrates waking, dreaming, and deep sleep.

Ramakrishna: the 19th-century Bengali mystic whose entire practice was the embodied demonstration that every tradition—Vaishnavism, Tantra, Islam, Christianity—opens, when fully inhabited, into the same clearing (Gupta, 1974, p. 74). The title is a thesis: two cosmic traditions, one transmission. In the notes to *Ptah the El Daoud*,¹⁷ Alice wrote that her focus was, “...to express and bring out the feeling of purification.” She continued, “Sometimes on earth, we don’t have to wait for death to go through a sort of purging, a purification. That march you hear is the march on to purgatory, rather than a series of changes a person might go through” (as cited in Kernodle, 2010, pp. 91–92). Ramakrishna’s entire practice was the body of that purification—not described but undergone, tradition by tradition, until the purging was indistinguishable from the arrival.

Ramakrishna Paramahansa was an experimenter—a practitioner who moved sequentially and with total commitment through the initiatory technologies of multiple traditions, entering each fully enough to be transformed from within. His *Advaita Vedanta* practice dissolved the boundary between worshipper and worshipped. His *Tantric sadhana* relocated the sacred from transcendence into the body’s own energetic architecture (Gupta, 1974, p. 721). His practice of Islam and Christianity—undertaken with the same unironic rigor—disclosed the same arrival: a non-dual awareness that no single tradition could claim as its exclusive property because every tradition, when pursued to its root, disclosed the same ground. His perennialism bore no resemblance to the comparative textual extraction that dominant readings of the perennialist canon have mistaken for the thing itself. It was enacted, somatic, and verified in the body of a

¹⁷ Ptah is named for the Egyptian creator god whose mouth-opening ceremony, in the Book of the Dead, initiates the departed into the capacity for speech and sustenance in the afterlife. That Coltrane placed “Turiya and Ramakrishna” on an album named for an Egyptian initiatory rite enacts the perennialist architecture at the level of sequencing: Hindu, Egyptian, and the practitioner’s own realized name held in the same container without hierarchy.

specific human being who had undergone radical social dispossession—dismissed as mad, as excessive, as illegible to the rational order (Isherwood, 1965, p. 86)—and who emerged through his illegibility into a transmission that outlived every socio-institutional attempt to contain it.

Alice Coltrane knew this structure from the inside-out. Following John’s death in 1967, the critical and institutional apparatus of jazz moved swiftly to enclose her—repositioning her as custodian of his legacy, her own sovereign practice folded into the administrative role of grieving widow (Gallope, 2024, p. 177). The enclosure was not incidental. It was an operation of what Weheliye (2014), reading Wynter, identifies as the genre of Man—the classificatory apparatus that cannot accommodate a Black woman as an originating source of cosmological architecture and so reclassifies her as a relational appendage to male genius (p. 12). The same conversation in which Ramakrishna teaches about *the hole in the wall* opens with a parable about valuation: a rich man sends a servant to price a diamond at the market. The egg-plant seller offers nine seers of vegetables. The cloth merchant offers nine hundred rupees. The jeweller offers one hundred thousand. The same stone. Each buyer prices it to the exact limit of their own capital—not from malice, not from error, but from the irreducible constraint of what they already know how to see (Gupta, 1974, p. 738). The jazz press was the cloth merchant. It offered the highest valuation available within its existing categories—*widow, caretaker, keeper of the flame*—and believed itself generous. What passed through the enclosure was not a response to it. From within the imposed structure of grief and institutional dismissal, she built an ashram, assumed a new name, and composed a body of work whose cosmological architecture—built not merely of commercial sound but in community, pedagogy, and lived transmission—exceeded the jazz world’s taxonomic capacity to receive it: not resistance to dispossession but what Weheliye names as “lines of flight, freedom dreams, practices of liberation” that dispossession can

constrain but never annihilate (2014, p. 2). Illegibility became the aperture through which transmission passed—a frequency, as the title declares, that was never not sounding. What only the jeweller can see is not a higher market value but a different order of seeing altogether: the hole in the wall, the thin ego of the Isvarakoti, the one who remains on this side of the wall and yet is always in communion with the endless meadow on the other (Gupta, 1974, p. 738).

Coltrane was such a one. The wall is hardly there if you are sounding in the meadow.

Inside the composition, the ear meets it first as texture: a chord dense and terrestrial, already weighted with the blues' long memory. What strikes the body before the mind has named it is the *acciaccatura*:¹⁸ the crushed note—a micro-collision of adjacent pitches that Coltrane deploys as the kinetic signature of the piece. In Coltrane's hands it becomes something more primary: the liturgical moan of the Baptist tradition translated into piano touch, the body's knowledge arriving before cognition has organized it into meaning. Erlmann (2010) traces the historical severance by which Enlightenment ocularcentrism separated the knowing subject from the resonant world—the moment Western epistemology decided that reliable knowledge was visual, distanced, and disembodied (pp. 10–11). The *acciaccatura* undoes that severance in the duration of a careful swipe. It cannot be heard from a distance. It must be felt. Alice herself named the priority: "It's more a feeling than a melody" (Feather, 1970). The ensemble confirms this at every register. Riley's brushed snare drag operates as pseudo-drone pulsation—not marking time but sustaining a duration, a textural bed that holds the composition's forward motion in hovering suspension while the ghostly bass drum taps keep the assembled pace sensible. Sanders' bell accents, sparse at the opening, carry the rhythmic quality of passers-by in a brightly-lit processional, building

¹⁸ The *acciaccatura* is technically an ornamental dissonance—a grace note struck simultaneously with its resolution and immediately released (Sadie, 2001). Its deployment here exceeds its formal function, operating instead as haptic trigger and somatic address.

gradually from peripheral shimmer to front-facing claim on the listener's attention. Carter's bass is the dynamically expressive counterweight—his counter-harmonic precision holding a ceaseless conversation with Coltrane's left hand—a conversation whose mutual responsiveness constitutes what Monson (1996) identifies as the generative core of the groove: a field of collective attention in which each player's listening is as constitutive as their playing (pp. 68–69). This is a trio at its center—no horns, no saxophone melody to organize the ear around a single narrative. The architecture is omnidirectional, and the listener is immersed.

One hears in Coltrane's playing the blues of her Detroit childhood—the gospel-steeped, church-formed musicianship that Baraka (1967) identified as the *changing same*: the blues impulse that persists through every formal transformation as the spiritual substrate no amount of evolution can dissolve (p. 180). But it is infused here with an abstracted devotional confidence that transmutes the scalar push-pull characteristic of the style. Her note choices carry the soulful lines through oscillating dualistic cohesion—finding uplifting almost-resolutions, then rolling back into the historically familiar uncertainty of the path less-traveled, whether out of choice or necessity. This is not a modal substitution that conventional analysis could name and shelve. It is a blues practice with a persistent brightness—a gravitational pull toward the raised sixth that opens a tonal aperture in the blues' established emotional architecture, the precise pitch at which what Baraka calls the changing same moves through into its next spiritual iteration (pp. 210–211). The piano swings its double-to-triple-timed tangential phrases, ringing with the ironic traces of sheer attention to form. Alice told Leonard Feather that near the end she modulates from D-flat up to D and back before going out, and that there is “a suggestion of ‘Parker's Mood,’ the part to which the words went ‘Come with me....’ It's like God asking us if we want to go home—that kind of feeling” (Feather, 1970). The subtle brightness the ear has been living

with throughout—the raised sixth pulling against the minor’s gravity—finds its macro-structural confirmation in a whole key-center shift: a half step of light admitted into the architecture, then gently withdrawn. A bebop quotation heard as liturgical invitation. The changing same, enacted in a single modulation.

The harmonic language Coltrane builds over this foundation refuses the austerity of post-bop quartal voicings that had become the dominant currency of avant-garde piano in 1970.¹⁹ Instead she reaches for density—chords stacked in open fourths over Carter’s pedal points, their internal voices layered so thickly that the sound ceases to behave as harmony in the conventional sense and begins to operate as *environment*: a thickness of presence the listener does not analyze but inhabits. This thickness is an aural re-presentation of Simondonian *metastability*—the maintenance of a dynamic equilibrium between competing tonal forces that never resolves into stasis, always holding open the tension between the pre-individual field and the individuated form it temporarily assumes (Simondon, 1992, pp. 300, 302). The chord does not land and rest. It sustains and vibrates. Between Detroit and Turiya—between the blues labor from which Coltrane’s musical formation emerged and the cosmic consciousness toward which her practice is oriented—these voicings hold the threshold space where neither pole is abandoned, and both are held in productive, generative tension.

At roughly the two-minute mark, a brief approach to transition: the swing and shuffle imperceptibly become a generative increase, and then at 2:08, production itself intervenes—the

¹⁹ Quartal voicings are chords built on stacked fourths rather than the thirds that organize conventional Western harmony. Where tertian harmony produces resolution—the chord wants to go somewhere—quartal voicings suspend that desire, generating an open, hovering quality that resists arrival. In this context, Coltrane’s quartal stacking over Carter’s pedal points produces a vertical density that is neither consonant nor dissonant in the conventional sense but holds both possibilities in a sustained field of tonal ambiguity. The effect is architectural rather than melodic: the listener is placed inside a structure rather than carried along a line.

bells that have been generously enlivening the texture cut abruptly, unnaturally, marking the collective return to the march all the more potent for their sudden absence. Around the midpoint, the cymbals and bells return as Carter's bass line begins a methodical whole-and-half-note ascent, bedding Coltrane's trebled glissandi—runs that mirror her iconic harp style, the piano reaching toward the instrument she has not touched on this track. The ensemble climbs. It is reminiscent of the earlier intensifications, though more enrapturing—a Lynchian threshold²⁰ in which the listener has been watching a film and has only now realized the film is their life, that they are entering a dream sequence, or the inverse: that they have been dreaming and are now passing through the threshold into the waking world. The ensemble makes its approach to the comfort of resolution, nearly touching it this time, and then the piano runs smear and blur skillfully back into the strained melodic core the composition has been living with from the start. What Ramakrishna calls the *hole in the wall*, Heidegger the *clearing*, Moten (2003) the *break*, and Simone Weil's *metaxu*²¹—four traditions arriving, by entirely distinct routes—seemingly—at an analogous structural aperture—becomes audible not as a single harmonic choice but as the architecture of the entire arc: the threshold approached, nearly crossed, and held open (Gupta, 1974, p. 738).

²⁰ "Turiya and Ramakrishna" was recorded in January 1970; Twin Peaks premiered in 1990. David Lynch's lifelong Transcendental Meditation practice—formalized through the David Lynch Foundation for Consciousness-Based Education and World Peace—and his immersion in Vedantic thought place him downstream of the same contemplative traditions Coltrane was already transmitting through sound. The temporal-perceptual quality his work shares with hers—the dissolved boundary between dreaming and waking, the sensation of discovering mid-experience that one has crossed a threshold without noticing—is not a stylistic coincidence but a convergence rooted in shared practice. What the author instinctively calls "Lynchian" is, in this lineage, Coltrane's—that of the Absolute.

²¹ Weil names *metaxu*—the Greek *between* (from *Symposium* 202e) that Weil develops as the figure for what simultaneously separates and connects: "*every separation is a link*" (Weil, 1947/2002, p. 132). To hold open the break is to enact *metaxu*.

What the aperture demands of the one who would enter it is not extraordinary effort but its opposite: a particular quality of prepared receptivity that the music trains into existence over the course of its own duration. This is what Medina (2013) calls *kaleidoscopic consciousness*—not the acquisition of new information but the cultivation of a perceptual apparatus capable of holding multiple perspectival positions simultaneously, each new relation transforming retroactively all previously established relations, nothing collapsing into synthesis, everything remaining in productive tension (p. 299). The music at this moment is not offering the listener an experience to be consumed. It is [en]training a faculty. Coltrane’s playing sinks back after the midpoint climb, maintaining the polemic aesthetic but assuming an implicate space in the mix, re-presenting the tangential movements as dynamic chord changes that provide a foundation for the double-bass to take its place at the pulpit. Carter’s pitch inflections and microtonal bends decorate the walking-dance—the brightness i have been hearing throughout the composition now carried in a different voice, the same tonal position held from a new angle. This is the kaleidoscopic turn: the raised sixth that could not be domesticated into the familiar minor, that insisted on its own peculiar register, that asked the ear to remain in contact with irreducible difference without moving to resolve it—now sounding in the bass rather than the piano, the same aperture viewed through a different face of the kaleidoscope. To stay with that brightness across its migrations is already to practice the epistemology Medina names (pp. 306–307).

But this is not a solitary cognitive achievement. The faculty does not develop in isolation; it is called into being through encounter—specifically through the kind of encounter hooks (1994) theorizes as *engaged pedagogy*, in which the transmission requires *mutual vulnerability*: the teacher cannot remain sheltered from the risk she asks of the student (p. 21). The ceaseless conversation between Carter’s bass and Coltrane’s left hand has been modeling this structure

from the opening bars—two voices exposed to one another, each altered by the other’s phrasing, neither leading from a position of safety. Coltrane does not demonstrate mastery from a position of completion. She models being-in-transmission—composing, performing, and teaching from within the same exposure she asks of her students, her listeners, her community. The Swamini’s authority is not the authority of the one who has arrived; it is the authority of the one who remains in motion and is willing to be changed by the encounter. Transmission does not move from the full to the empty, from teacher to student in a one-directional transfer. It moves through the space between two exposed subjectivities, each of whom is altered by contact.

The attention this demands from the listener—and from the student of this music—is not concentration but its opposite. Weil (1952) distinguishes with precision between will and attention: the will tightens, grasps, pursues; attention opens, waits, receives. “Absolutely unmixed attention is prayer” (p. 117). And in her *Detachment* section: “To detach our desire from all good things and to wait. Experience proves that this waiting is satisfied. It is then we touch the absolute good” (p. 13). The listener who tries to apprehend the transmission analytically—who approaches the music with an agenda, however sophisticated—has already missed it. The almost-resolutions I described—the soulful lines finding their uplifting arrival and then rolling back into uncertainty—are the sonic enactment of this posture: desire carried toward its object, nearly touching it, then released. Not failed resolution but practiced non-grasping. What is required is the faculty Weil names: desire emptied of its object, attention liberated from will, a waiting that is not passive but maximally alert and deliberately un-instrumentalized.

This attentional posture finds its name in the Christian mystical tradition through a concept Eckhart calls *Abgeschiedenheit*—detachment, releasement—which Critchley (2024) reads as the highest virtue of the mystical life: a “fluid openness, a cleared looseness, a limpid intensity,

where both the concepts of mind and world or the soul and God dissolve into something altogether stranger and yet simpler.” Eckhart’s *gelâzenheit*—living without a why, being present to what shows itself rather than pursuing it—is the structural condition for the kind of reception the music requires, and it is picked up by Heidegger as *Gelassenheit*, letting-be, the posture in which the *Lichtung* (clearing) can open (Critchley, 2024, p. 107). The crucial and often missed dimension is that *Abgeschiedenheit* is not withdrawal. The self does not disappear; it becomes, in Eckhart’s formulation, “virgin”—free of attachments, images, and works, maximally receptive. The aperture does not open to the one who strains toward it. It opens to the one who has learned to stop straining. In the composition’s final movement, the bass’s leading presence washes into a third and final full-ensemble wall of sound—invoking the prayer call section of a Baptist church service, the most definitively consistent uplifting piano notation in the entire piece carrying it toward its end. The cacophonic percussion gently beckons surrender to the apparent and surrounding flux. Then all active playing ceases, and the final notes ring out. The distinction of separation evaporates. All voicings collapse into one last delicate gasp of sonic presence. The aperture has opened—not to the one who strained toward it, but to the listener who, over the course of the composition’s duration, has been trained to stop reaching.

The guru enacts this in the moment of teaching. Surya Botofasina was raised at the Sai Anantam Ashram—the son of Radha Reyes-Botofasina, who lived under Alice’s guidance for nearly thirty years and who testified that the Swamini taught “skills: how to live in this world and the world beyond this world” (Berkman, 2010, p. 101). Surya, a pianist formed inside the transmission, described the community’s practice in terms that echo Ramakrishna’s perennialism at the register of the domestic: “The devotional songs we sing, *bhajans*, are mostly in Sanskrit; however, we celebrate Christmas, we love Jesus, we love anything that has to do with God, period” (Berkman,

2010, p. 107). The clearing we traced through Ramakrishna's sequential inhabitation of traditions was, at Sai Anantam, the ordinary texture of a childhood. It is this Surya—direct disciple, living carrier of the transmission, and pianist whose harmonic formation occurred under the Swamini's hands—who describes the pedagogy at its culminating moment: “I could literally feel her at that moment pushing me, leaning over saying, ‘A-flat...E-flat...D-flat,’ and then at the end saying, ‘Just play.’ Because it really speaks to the guru guiding you to the point where you have to meet your own spiritual self” (Christovale, 2025, p. 147). The progression is exact: specific guidance—precise tonal instruction, the transmission of harmonic knowledge—followed by its withdrawal. The “just play” is not an abandonment. It is the most demanding instruction of the encounter: enter the aperture under your own faculty. The Swamini has guided to the threshold. *Abgeschiedenheit*—living without a why—begins on the other side. What Medina calls kaleidoscopic consciousness, hooks names mutual vulnerability, Weil identifies as attention-as-waiting, and Eckhart theorizes as releasement: Turiyasangitananda enacted in a single phrase. Not syncretically—not through textual comparison or philosophical extraction—but somatically, pedagogically, in the transmission of a specific harmonic sequence to a specific student in a specific room. The withdrawal was the teaching. What followed it was not silence but *praxical actance*.²²

This is why the title's logic is finally apophatic. *Turiya* cannot name what it points toward—the fourth state is defined entirely by what it is not: not waking, not dreaming, not deep sleep, but the witnessing ground beneath, around, and within all three. Critchley (2024), reading Eckhart's *via negativa*, notes that the approach to the divine “can only be found through the way of negation—

²² Actance: from Latour (1987, 1991), the capacity of any entity within a network to make a difference, to act— independent of intention or named agency. Praxical actance names theoretically-grounded acting that propagates through a community of practice without being reducible to any single practitioner's intention.

a language that ceaselessly undoes itself” (pp. 52–53). The title enacts exactly this: it names by refusing to contain and points by declining to arrive. So too the music. The chapter has traced what the piece does—how it trains a faculty, transmits through mutual exposure, demands attention-as-waiting, and opens to the one who stops straining—but it cannot finally say what it transmits. The frequency was never not sounding. That is the outermost limit of the claim, and it is already one word too many.

In October 2025, Surya Botofasina and Carlos Niño performed at the Queens Museum as part of *Deeper*—an event organized by withoutShapewithoutForm under the frame of *Deep Listening*. Alongside them, practitioners of *Simran*—the centuries-old Sikh practice of sacred repetition through which the practitioner dissolves habitual selfhood into presence—held their own continuous stream. Both were presented not as religious observance but as irreligious *technologies of the self*: concrete practices for the cultivation of psycho-spiritual health amid the flood of attention-mining digital platforms and the mass-mediated spectacle-driven emotional destabilization they produce. The room held jazz musicians, meditators, scholars, and variously intrigued souls. No single tradition organized the space; each remained fully itself while the space between them became generative. Afterward, i approached Deep Kailey—co-founder of withoutShapewithoutForm and a close collaborator of Botofasina and Niño—to thank her. What followed was brief but precise: a conversation about Simran’s relationship to Coltrane’s legacy and about whether Weil’s decreation named the same movement from a different shore. She gave me her card. The 1970 recording, with no definitive start, has yet to end. It was still sounding, reconfiguring the white cube’s logic in Queens—and the network through which it propagated is an invitation to openness.

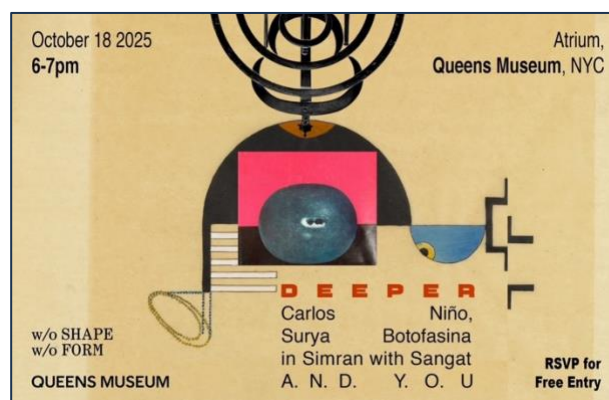


Figure 4. Flyer for *Deeper* event.

(Deep listening event and opening night of withoutSHAPEwithoutFORM's *Journey of the Mind* exhibit), Queens Museum, October 2025. Design by Nirbhai (Nep) Singh Sidhu. Retrieved from Surya Botofasina's Instagram.

Chapter Three: Case Study 002— “Journey [to] Satchidananda”

Sat-Chit-Ananda: being, consciousness, bliss. The title of the devotional is itself an ontological circuit—the three aspects of *Brahman* held in simultaneous relation, each implying the others, none reducible to a sequence. The journey the title names is not spatial. It is the movement through which the practitioner's awareness—fractured by the monoculture's insistence on discrete, measurable selfhood—re-enters the vibratory field from which it was never actually separated. On *World Music Vol. 1: The Ecstatic Music of Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda* (Luaka Bop, 2017), the version of “Journey in Satchidananda” that concerns this chapter is not the 1970 Impulse! recording with Pharoah Sanders, Cecil McBee, and Rashied Ali. It is the ashram version—recorded with Coltrane's students and disciples at the Sai Anantam Ashram in the Santa Monica Mountains, distributed on private-press cassette, and heard outside that community for the first time only when the Luaka Bop²³ compilation made it available to the

²³ Luaka Bop is the record label founded by David Byrne in 1988 as a vehicle for Brazilian and Afro-diasporic music the major label apparatus had no infrastructure to receive. Byrne and Talking Heads were embedded in the Downtown New York avant-garde of the late 1970s—a milieu saturated by the same questioning of Western logocentrism Derrida was articulating in writing. *Stop Making Sense* (1984) enacted in performance what *Of Grammatology* argued in text: that the live, the reproduced, and the composed are mutually constitutive. Byrne never cites post-structuralist thought — and shares with Derrida a resistance to the postmodernist label others

public nearly two decades after Coltrane's death. The community body is the instrument. What the recording carries is the trace of a collective individuation that had already occurred before any listener pressed play. This chapter listens for is the assemblage operating at collective scale—the *bhajan* as the site where the practice individuates a community, the recording as tertiary retention of a specific room continuing to act on receivers who were never in it.

The ashram recording demands a theory of the individual adequate to what it documents. Gilbert Simondon (2020) provides it. For Simondon, the individual is never a finished state. It is a phase in an ongoing process of *individuation*—a process that always carries with it a charge of *pre-individual reality*, a reservoir of potentiality that exceeds any given configuration and remains available for further transformation. The individual does not precede the process that forms it; the process is ontologically prior. This means that when Alice Coltrane's disciples enter the *bhajan*²⁴—when Radha Botofasina-Reyes²⁵ describes “going all over the universe” with her, sessions that could last two or three hours until “you couldn't sing anymore; all you could do is just say” (brown, 2021, p. 60)—what occurs is not the expression of pre-existing selves through

applied to both: “I never understood why postmodernism had to define itself in the negative. To not say what it aspires to be, but rather what it is not” (Byrne, in Rawsthorn, 2011). The adjacency operated below explicit attribution—which is to say, it moved the way transmission does throughout this work.

²⁴ *Bhajan* is a Sanskrit word meaning “soul chant” (Botofasina-Reyes, in brown, 2021, p. 60). Alice Coltrane describes the practice in her text *Mantra*: bhajan chanting worships God through song and music, removing agitations from the mind, uplifting the spirit, purifying the atmosphere, and elevating consciousness (cited in Berkman, 2010, p. 94). The form is common across Hindu devotional traditions, typically consisting of a lead vocalist singing verses with a congregation responding in refrain, building in intensity over extended duration. At Sai Anantam Ashram, Coltrane's bhajans were sui generis—integrating Detroit gospel inflection, jazz harmony, Hindu mantra, and collective improvisation into a devotional genre with no precedent (Berkman, 2010, p. 94). What Baraka (1967) identified as the changing same—the blues impulse persisting through every formal transformation as spiritual substrate—finds in the ashram bhajan not its negation but its next iteration: the gospel-formed voice carrying the same charge into a Vedantic container that does not replace but extends the tradition's reach (pp. 180, 210–211).

²⁵ Radha Botofasina-Reyes was introduced in the preceding chapter through Berkman's account of her testimony: the Swamini taught “skills: how to live in this world and the world beyond this world” (Berkman, 2010, p. 101). Her son Surya's account of Turiyasangitananda's pedagogy (“Just play”) closed that chapter's argument. The intergenerational dimension of the transmission—mother and son both formed as practitioners within the same devotional community—exemplifies communal individuation propagating across a duration.

music. It is collective individuation: the simultaneous formation of individual and group through a shared encounter with a pre-individual field that neither the guru nor the disciple contains alone. The ashram was not a retreat from the *genre of Man*. It was, in Weheliye's (2014) terms, the generation of a different genre of the human—*enfleshment otherwise*, enacted not as theory but as daily devotional practice (p. 2).

What individuates in the *bhajan* is not only the collective body. It is the temporal structure of experience itself. The master's clock—the colonial imposition of linear, extractive time that Phillips (2025) traces from the plantation bell to the smartphone screen—cannot accommodate what happens in these sessions. brown (2021) describes them as “melting times, where language ceased and the metaphysics of sound began” (p. 60). The melting is temporal: the sequential organization of past, present, and future that the master's clock enforces dissolves into what Phillips calls *superposition*—“overlapping, coexisting dimensions that challenge and resist collapsing into the oppressive, linear timelines” (p. 12). This temporal operation is not a reactive gesture against colonial time. Phillips insists it is “a manifestation of ancestral African space-times” that predate colonial disruption—an ontological priority, not a counterstrategy. The Sufi mystic Hazrat Inayat Khan²⁶ (1996) names the cosmological ground of this priority: *Nada Brahma*, Sound-God—the understanding, shared across Vedantic and Sufi traditions, that sound is the fundamental generative force of the universe, and that the state of *anahad nada*, the unstruck sound, is what the practitioner hears when attuned to the vibratory field from which all manifestation descends (p. 10). Githere (2022) names the condition that emerges when the clock

²⁶ Hazrat Inayat Khan (1882–1927) was an Indian Sufi master of the Chishti order and an accomplished musician — a trained vocalist and vina player who gave concert tours of Indian classical music across the United States and Europe before founding the Sufi Order in London in 1914. His *Mysticism of Sound and Music* articulates a cosmology in which sound is the fundamental generative and unifying force of the universe—a philosophy inseparable from his practice as a performing musician.

stops and the unstruck sound becomes audible: Afropresentism— “the space between the dream and the memory collapses into being your reality—now.” That is the temporal logic of the ashram devotional. The journey to *Sat-Chit-Ananda* is the journey out of the master’s clock and into the vibratory simultaneity that was never not vibrating.

The track opens in the dense orchestral sonic flux of the Oberheim OB8—an analog synthesizer produced in 1983; the year Coltrane relocated the Vedantic Center to Sai Anantam. She builds a cinematic melodic architecture over a guttural bass drone that establishes the harmonic ground the entire devotional will inhabit. Joshua Spiegelman’s flute enters in pulsating figures, drilling bright accents across the Oberheim’s guiding foundations. The texture is simultaneously orchestral—carrying Coltrane’s deep and explicit debt to Stravinsky, whose compositional solutions she credited as arriving directly from his disembodied self, through meditation (Pouncey, 2002, p. 44)—and devotional, fusing the harmonic affect of gospel worship with the modal suspension of Indian classical raga and a sense-feeling that can only be described as the invocation of atmospheric hallmarks reminiscent of science fiction film scores: the sound of a cosmos being presenced through technical means that no single tradition authorizes. A cosmotechnical assemblage: the Oberheim is a Western instrument, designed for pop and new wave production, re-oriented here by a cosmological practice that treats the synthesizer as a vehicle for devotional [in]activation rather than commercial expression. The technical object and the cosmic order individuate together.

Then the music pauses. A breath—one or two seconds of silence that functions as a threshold. When the Ashram Singers enter, the orchestral density of the introduction is stripped back and finessed into oceanic swells of congregational voice, with harmonic streams of treble chords flaring off the ends of certain phrases like spray off a wave’s crest. The spatial production is

extraordinary: the singers seem to have been captured through multiple microphones at varying distances. The organ's natural capabilities are manifested through Leslie speaker cabinets and/or tremolo modulation, whose low-frequency oscillation envelops the voicings in a slow, breathing rotation. The effect is not stereo positioning. It is spatial oscillation—the sound itself vibrating between locations, the recording technology producing in the listener's body the same oscillatory condition the *bhajan* cultivates in the practitioner's consciousness. Berkman (2010) notes that Coltrane processed her ashram recordings “evocatively with studio effects and overdubbing” (p. 95); what this production achieves is the sonic expression of what the thesis calls the *static-oscillatory subject*—a field of collective attention vibrating between states, never arriving, never departing.

The congregation sings in English: *Samsara / Journey to Satchidanandaji / Journey with Satchidanandaji*. The first word names the condition the devotional addresses—the cycle of suffering, the psychocarceral loop in Vedantic cosmology. The lyric moves through *tapas* (“*He guides us on the samsaric sea / Through life's tests and trials / To the soul's victory*”) and arrives at a chiasmus that folds the journey back into itself: “*Our journey's end is our journey home / Our journey home is our journey's end.*” End and origin occupy the same location approached from opposing directions, dissolving into a structure where the destination was always-already the ground the practitioner stood on before the first note sounded. This is the changing same at the level of lyric: the blues impulse that Baraka (1967) traced through every formal transformation of Black music—from spirituals through R&B through the New Thing—arriving here in a congregational Sanskrit-English devotional, the spiritual substrate persisting through a container no one in Baraka's lineage could have predicted but which his argument made structurally inevitable (pp. 180, 210–211).

Then Sairam Iyer's voice enters—Tamil-born, Bollywood-trained, singing in a language most of the ashram congregation does not share. His delivery is powerfully front-facing, close-mic'd, and present, cutting against the open, airy spatial field the Sai Anantam Singers inhabit. The contrast is immediate and somatic: where the choir's English verses suspended the listener in a collective bath of devotional sound, Iyer's Tamil solo addresses the listener directly and urgently from a different cosmotechnical register entirely. The translation reveals what the English lyric's cosmic vocabulary does not carry alone: *In the ocean of family life / the journey is very difficult*. The domestic, the suffering, the material weight of embodied existence—this is where the journey begins, in the difficulty of the household, the same condition Alice described as the labor she had to complete before the path opened (Berkman, 2010, p. 95). Alice solos beneath Iyer in Carnatic scalar passages—South Indian classical ornamentation threading under a Tamil devotional text, both carried by a Black American swamini's keyboard technique rooted in Detroit gospel and bebop.

The transfer from choral English to Tamil solo and fluidly back to the choir enacts the perennialist creolization as musical form. The song builds toward its close with choir, Iyer, and the Oberheim's synthesized lines converging into a texture where each remains uniquely audible while fully integrated into a singular devotional intensity—transindividuation made sonically present, the community body operating as one instrument without any individual voice being absorbed. Then everything stops. In unison. A silent breath of release marks the convergence—and the track ends not in resolution or fade but in collective cessation, the sound withdrawing into the silence it emerged from, the break held open for one breath before the next track begins.

What the Luaka Bop compilation made available in 2017 was not the *bhajan* itself. It was its *tertiary retention*—the technical inscription through which a collective individuation that

occurred in a specific room, among specific bodies, at a specific moment in the ashram's devotional life, becomes available to bodies that were never in that room. Stiegler (1998) extends Simondon's account of individuation by identifying the role of technical memory—the recorded object, the score, the cassette—in carrying the pre-individual charge forward across the ruptures of death, distance, and institutional enclosure. Lindberg (2024) demonstrates that this extension emerged from a fundamentally musical problematic: for Stiegler, the melody is the prototype of a purely temporal object whose structure coincides with the temporal flow of consciousness itself (p. 183). When a melody is recorded, the tertiary retention does not merely preserve the sound. It carries the retentional structure—the expectations, the *protentions*, the secondary retentions of an entire musical culture—into a future it cannot predict. The ashram cassettes were tertiary retentions oriented toward care: distributed within a devotional community, received by practitioners whose secondary retentions (their training, their faith, their daily practice of the *bhajans*) prepared them to activate the pre-individual charge the recording carried. When those same cassettes circulate beyond the ashram—first as collector's items, then as a Luaka Bop compilation—the question the thesis must hold open is whether the tertiary retention can still transmit what it carried, or whether the receiver's secondary retentions have been so thoroughly formatted by the master's clock that the pre-individual charge arrives as commodity rather than transmission. Alice herself addressed this directly: “Audiences do become part of the music in their own way... they're breathing it with you” (Pouncey, 2002, p. 44). The breathing is the condition. The receiver who breathes with the recording—whose attention operates in the mode Weil named as prayer—activates transindividuation. The receiver who consumes it activates nothing but a loop. The question is not purely theoretical. It was answered, uniquely, in the backspace of a street-level loft on West 37th Street, aglow in red light.

In November 2025, i arrived at the People’s Forum in Manhattan,²⁷ to see Fred Moten perform with his collaborator, the double-bassist Brandon Lopez.²⁸ Moten’s scholarly work—the *break*, the *undercommons*, the *object-voice* that bypasses the linguistic enclosure of the *genre of Man*—moves in direct conversation with this thesis’ concerns, and his collaborative practice with Lopez exists within the same musical subcultures i have been orienting with and immersing in throughout the fieldwork. Moten and Lopez made last-minute adjustments: Lopez clipped his phone to a holster on the microphone stand. Moten greeted the audience from wherever he was—his voice arriving through the phone’s speaker, projected through the PA into the room—and shared writing he had been working on that day. Lopez, positioned beside the phone as he would have been beside Moten’s body, aggressively hummed while he thrummed, thumped, and bowed his bass, producing the hyperfracturing sonic interventions that characterize their collaborative practice. After five to ten minutes of prose, Moten wished the audience well and extended his encouragement for Lopez to [re]awaken the room. The trans-spatial, multi-medium movement of thought felt apropos—the undercommons operating as literal transmission infrastructure, the tertiary retention (the phone) carrying the pre-individual charge of Moten’s thinking into a room his body could not enter, Lopez’s bass activating the sonic field that made the transmission receivable. What Moten read that evening cut to the center of what this chapter has been tracing: a meditation on “brutal and murderous individuation in which each and every one will be

²⁷ The People’s Forum is a movement incubator and cultural space in Midtown Manhattan dedicated to building political consciousness through education, art, and organizing. Their programming and library operate within a framework of anti-imperialist, anti-capitalist solidarity.

²⁸ Brandon Lopez is a double-bassist and improviser whose practice operates at the intersection of free improvisation, noise, and the spiritual jazz lineages associated with the Coltranes. As a member of Elder Ones, led by vocalist and composer Amirtha Kidambi, he contributed to *Holy Science* (Northern Spy, 2016). Kidambi has described Alice Coltrane as a primary influence: “Alice’s primary guru was the same one that my family followed, and she participated in the *bhajan* singing tradition. She looms large for me as a figure who blended so many different styles and traditions, uncompromising in her vision and authentic to herself” (Kidambi, in *Elder Ones*, 2016, liner notes). Lopez operates as a node in the network this thesis traces.

killed”—the colonial operation that forces the pre-individual into a fixed, extractable singularity—and on the refusal of that operation: “...the people are improperly social and determinate.”²⁹ This is Simondon’s individuation read through the break: the pre-individual field that colonial modernity cannot tolerate because it exceeds every attempt to enclose it in a single, accountable, terminable being. Moten’s voice, arriving through a phone clipped to a mic stand in a basement on West 37th Street, was itself the demonstration—the transmission rerouted through unexpected infrastructure, the community body assembled not by physical co-presence but by the quality of attention brought to the space between the speaker and the sounded.

After the performance, i spoke with a few of the Forum’s employees and bought a physical copy of Freire’s *Pedagogy of the Oppressed* from their expansive liberation bookstore—a tertiary retention acquired in the same space where another had just been activated. As i headed outside, i ran into a classmate from a previous semester’s course on artistic activism. She was now a student of Moten’s in NYU Tisch’s Performance Studies program. She knew Lopez through acquaintance, and the three of us shared a brief conversation over cigarettes. Lopez explained that Moten’s *consent not to be a single being* trilogy was never intended as a trilogy—that Moten had difficult feelings about the commercial imperatives the publishers had enacted in forcing the works into proximity. A body of work whose title names the refusal of enclosed singularity had itself been enclosed by the publishing apparatus into a marketable form—an enframing gaze, operating on the very text that diagnoses it.

²⁹ Transcribed from a one-minute video recording i made during the performance, November 7, 2025. Moten was sharing unreleased writing-in-progress

Figure 5. Brandon Lopez performing at the People's Forum, November 7, 2025. Fred Moten's voice arrives through the phone clipped to the microphone stand. Photograph by the researcher.



Chapter Four: Case Study 003— “Translinear Light”

“I can act, I can be, I can live as I want to, and nothing can—there’s no claim—no one can buy me... I’m free.” (Coltrane, 1970; cited in Gallope, 2024, p. 177)

“Translinear Light” is a deposit and a return. From within that duration—twenty-six years of monastic practice, building the Vedantic Center, composing devotional music with and for her community, carrying the temple as practice rather than institution—Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda re-entered the commercial recording apparatus once, at the sustained encouragement of her son Ravi, and left a single tertiary retention in the public square before going back to the quiet work. She was explicit: “I told my children I’m so happy to do this, but I’m not starting a second career.” The album gathered itself across four years and five studios, from April 2000 to June 2004—not a session but an accumulation, the way a pilgrim gathers stones. The final track, “Satya Sai Isha,” was recorded at the Vedantic Center Mandir itself—the ashram folded into the album’s architecture, the temple literally present inside the commercial artifact. This chapter explores the transmission in its cosmotechanical reach—the late-period synthesis where acoustic-space architecture, *telepresence*, and the psychocarceral diagnosis the

practice answers, all become audible across an entire recording. The album opens from the studio and holds its aperture in the sacred space.

For the third time in this thesis, the title is the first transmission. “Turiya and Ramakrishna” named two cosmic traditions held in a single frequency. “Journey to Satchidananda” named the ontological circuit—being, consciousness, bliss—as a movement the practitioner was always-already within. Here, Coltrane names the topology of the transmission itself: how the light permeates the field. On *The Tavis Smiley Show* (2004), she offered her own etymology: “look at what ‘trance’ means—it means to transcend, it means to become transcendental.” So, a singular transcendental path of light, that could lead to such great dimensions of consciousness, of revelation, of spirituality, of spiritual power. *Translinear*: light that does not travel along a line but across lines, through them—the topology of a transmission that refuses the sequential logic of visual space in favor of the simultaneous, non-local character of acoustic space. The album’s title names the aperture this thesis has been tracing since its first chapter.

That the existing reception has treated the record primarily as a late-career statement—momentous, seamless, refreshing—while leaving the title track virtually unanalyzed is itself symptomatic. So too is the recurring critical lament that Coltrane eschews the harp, the instrument most legible to the reception apparatus as her signature. What this thesis recognizes through “Translinear Light” is her piano—the instrument of lived Detroit formation, her originary compositional voice, the site where the transmission operates without the fetish object that the *static-circulatory* listener has learned to consume as “Alice Coltrane.” That the three artifacts examined across this thesis are all piano works was not planned. It was felt and sensed—and that hearing is itself a small enactment of the initiated listening this chapter will now discuss.

The title track begins mid-sentence—a strong, open-voiced chord suspended in the air as though the listener has been admitted to an act already in progress.³⁰ The pacing in the opening bars is reverent and oratorical—a gathering of attention, not a demand for it. Within a few bars, Coltrane takes off in an oscillatory figuration that ascends to the high register and descends to the low, the full range of the piano traversed not as display but as mapping—the consciousness orienting itself in the space it is about to open.

At the low-end landing, Ravi enters on soprano saxophone. There is a distinct care in his articulation—an embodied vibrato that marks his breathing, passing notes blurred in ways that carry both parents’ blues-inflected languages simultaneously. Alice drops back in volume to accent. What emerges is not unison and not conventional harmony but something closer to what Bulut (2025) calls *non-dialogue*: a distributed mode of interaction in which two voices hear with one another without the dyadic guarantee of call and response—“moments through which one can hear with another and make a shift in being with one another” (p. 10). The soprano saxophone—John’s instrument in his final period—is now sounding through Ravi’s body on Alice’s composition. The generational transfer is not represented. It is happening, in real time, on the recording.

Around 2:35, Ravi drops out and Alice mulls over the phrase’s ending notes with increasing speed before kicking abruptly into an up-tempo, dissonant, yet rhythmically concise figure that prompts the entry of DeJohnette and Haden. Their arrival is so natural one might not actively notice it—the ensemble’s listening as constitutive as its playing (Monson, 1996, pp. 68–69), the

³⁰ The personnel on *Translinear Light* includes Alice Coltrane (piano, Wurlitzer organ), Ravi Coltrane (soprano and tenor saxophone), Jack DeJohnette (drums), Charlie Haden (bass), and additional musicians across other tracks. The title track is a quartet: piano, soprano saxophone, bass, drums.

boundary between cue and breath dissolved. DeJohnette grounds a steady pulse while deploying swung tom fills and cymbal work that excites without destabilizing the hypnotic center. Haden's bass walk is steady and core-shaking. Together they provide a foundation for the entropic maelstrom Alice opens above them: virtuosic leaps between registers, glissandi that marked her work with Bud Powell's group, with John's quartet, and across her solo career. Though she is playing the piano, the languages of the harp are unmistakably present—the signature she refused to bring to this album carried in her hands regardless, because it was never in the instrument. It was in the condition of the player.

Toward the close of her solo section, DeJohnette's cymbals join the triple-time runs she is melting out of an exquisitely dissonant melodic structure. The section finds an inverse resolve at 4:42 when she returns to the three-hit pulse that started it—the form folding back through itself. As her last chord rings out, Ravi's soprano slices back in, exemplifying the modal expressiveness his father pioneered. The rhythm section carefully flips the groove; the drums become more technical yet softer, pairing anxiousness with reassuring consistency. Ravi increasingly smears his notes, achieving microtonal fluidity, verging on multiphonic voicings that re-exact that almost-resolved sense across artifacts. Around six minutes, Haden takes off for a few bars while Ravi holds a note into silence. The entire groove returns to the familiar pulse, though more plodding and stilted. DeJohnette introduces a tinny cymbal we have not heard—a metronomic center cutting through the whirling atmosphere—which switches to rounding tom rolls, then dynamic splash and crash accents. Around 7:40 the ensemble begins collectively winding down, each player responding to the others' acknowledgment that the end is near—pulling off the landing as integral to the transmission as its exploratory center. Ravi's soprano breathes out its last notes. DeJohnette's final cymbal sounds almost reversed—a resonance folding back on

itself. And Alice's and Haden's closing tones are resonantly multiphonic: the piano and bass sustaining frequencies that blur into one another until the sound is nearly indistinguishable from a *tanpura* or shruti box. The Western instruments, pushed to their resonant limits, arrive at the timbral register of the Indian devotional drone—not through quotation or imitation but through the material physics of vibrating strings allowed to ring until the distinction between piano and bass, between composed and improvised, self-penetrates. The *translinear*: light crossing lines. The portable temple audible in the last seconds of the track, carried in the overtones.

This is the point where the theoretical architecture of the chapter becomes audible. Acoustic space, in McLuhan's formulation, is the register of simultaneous, non-linear, boundaryless relation—the field in which the ear, unlike the eye, receives from all directions at once without the hierarchizing geometry of perspective. Visual space isolates, sequences, encloses. Acoustic space envelops. What Coltrane builds over the hypnotic pulse of the title track is an acoustic architecture whose operations cannot be apprehended by the visual-spatial logic that governs most critical reception of recorded music. Erlmann (2010) traces how the Enlightenment produced its rational subject through the suppression of resonance³¹—the conjunction of perceiver and perceived that reason, requiring separation and autonomy, could not tolerate: “While reason implies the disjunction of subject and object, resonance involves their conjunction” (p. 10). Drawing on Tomlinson (1993), Erlmann locates in Ficino's Renaissance synthesis a theory of musical magic in which sound stems from a force “at once spiritual and

³¹ Erlmann's term *Vernunft/Resonanz* names the joining of reason and resonance in a single concept of personhood—a unity the Enlightenment produced its rational subject by severing (2010, p. 31). The suppression of resonance was, in his account, “modernity's second science” (p. 11): the foreclosed twin of the rational project, running in parallel for four centuries.

material” (p. 32)³²—a genealogy modernity was designed to forget. Schwartz’s (2011) broader argument confirms the stakes: *noise* in the West has been transformed from an aural experience to a root metaphor for what must be excluded in order for meaning to be maintained. Every act of signal-making is simultaneously an act of noise-exclusion. What Coltrane activates on “Translinear Light” is precisely the register the Enlightenment sensorium was constructed to wall off.

The central claim of this chapter is that the digital-virtual is not ontologically separate from the spiritual or imaginal-virtual. They are the same register—the non-local field where myth, social formation, and hermeneutically constructed identity operate simultaneously. *Hauntology*, as Derrida theorized and Fisher extended, names one face of this claim: the virtual always carries the trace of what it supposedly displaced. But Fisher’s diagnosis remains bound to visual-space logic—it registers the trace as *loss*, the ghost as evidence of a future that never arrived. The correction is perceptual: the term is not haunting but *telepresence*. Bourdon (2021) demonstrates across a sweep from Ciceronian correspondence to digital immersion that presence at a distance is a constitutive human capacity, not a modern technological achievement. The intensity of the experience resides in the body of the receiver, not the bandwidth of the medium. The ashram recording is not a ghost of Alice Coltrane. It is a technology of telepresence whose operative power depends on the listener’s capacity to receive it as transmission rather than commodity.

If acoustic space is the register and telepresence its operative mode, what constitutes the field in which that telepresence is received? Anzieu (1985) proposed that the self is acoustically

³² Schwartz (2011) recovers Ficino’s claim that song is “a most powerful imitator of all things,” whose power moves bidirectionally— “when it imitates the celestials, it also wonderfully arouses our spirit upwards to the celestial influence and the celestial influence downwards to our spirit” (p. 54). That bidirectional movement—spirit upward, celestial downward—is what Coltrane’s practice enacts and what the Cartesian settlement was designed to foreclose.

constituted before it is visually constituted—that the sonorous bath of intrauterine life produces a psychic envelope prior to Lacan’s mirror stage, prior to the specular construction of bounded selfhood. Bulut (2025) extends this into voice as skin—not a gap between subjects but a “shared surface, a multisensory interface that behaves both as a boundary and as a web of connection across various bodies and environments” (p. 1). What Bulut calls *insular solidarity*—the mode of relation in which voice touches without guarantee of being touched back in the same way—is the mode the portable temple requires. Saper (2012), drawing on Bion’s *alpha function* and Kristeva’s *chora*, demonstrates that jazz improvisation is not an illustration of intersubjective process but its most direct audible demonstration: the dreamwork conducted out loud, in real time, in the presence of others whose listening is as constitutive as their playing. The improviser does not generate content and transmit it to a passive audience. The ensemble *co-dreams*—and the quality of that co-dreaming depends not on the technical facility of the players but on the psychic condition they bring to the encounter.

This is where the critique of jazz offered by Adorno and, differently, by Deleuze becomes useful—not as refutation but as diagnostic filter. Adorno’s complaint that jazz improvisation masks commodity logic beneath the performance of freedom is correct about a specific mode of playing: the virtuoso deploying licks, the session musician performing spontaneity. Deleuze catches the same structure from the rhizomatic side: the jazz that looks like a line of flight but is reterritorialized before it departs. Both identify what happens when improvisation operates without the interior condition—when the *techne* runs but poietic intentionality is absent. What neither can see, because both are analyzing the output rather than the player, is that the site of transformation is not the improvisation itself. It is the openness of the player to sense through their *techne*. Coltrane’s decades of spiritual practice—the ashram, the meditation, the devotional

discipline—are the construction of the psychic container capable of conducting the resonant field without fragmenting or rigidifying. This is *phronesis*—not a knowledge one possesses but a quality of being that shows up in action, sensible only by those who share in it.

If the *ontological witness* is the condition and sonic emptying-as-opening its mechanism, the question becomes: what does the practitioner carry forward when the music stops?

Doraiswamy's (2024) concept of *portare foglio*—carrying leaves—drawn from the *yāttirikar sampradāya*, names the answer with a precision no European theoretical vocabulary reaches. For the diasporic subject, the temple is not a geographic location. It is a practice of carrying the local with you—the leaves gathered on the pilgrimage route, each one a trace of a specific encounter, collectively constituting a portable sacred architecture that the pilgrim assembles and reassembles in each new place. Coltrane's praxis—the ashram, the devotional recordings, the pedagogy—were the construction of a portable temple whose carriers would not need the institution to transmit what the institution had enabled. “Translinear Light” is one such leaf: a tertiary retention that carries the quality of the encounter forward to anyone capable of receiving.

Doraiswamy's second concept—*tiṇṇai*, the traditional Tamil veranda occupying the space between the private home and the public street—provides the architectural logic. The *tiṇṇai* is “perhaps the most important part of the home: something that does not seek to do anything except be a distilled entity of a largeness” (Doraiswamy, 2024). It is neither inside nor outside—a threshold, a fugitive gathering space where private grief meets public witness. The sonic *tiṇṇai* is what Coltrane builds on the title track and what her inheritors build in every space they enter: a resonant architecture that transforms whatever room it occupies into a threshold between registers. Ed Michel, producing *World Galaxy*, described the experience: “The amazing thing was her teaching the strings how to play free” (Pouncey, 2002, p. 44). The freedom was not

formlessness. It was the transmission of a specific quality of attention—a phronetic pedagogy in which the teacher’s condition was the lesson.

Marcus Moore, writing in *The New York Times* in November 2024, described ganavya doraiswamy’s³³ *daughter of a temple* as the album that “perhaps best captures the creative intimacy around Alice and John”—with arrangements “just slightly off the originals, leaving the bones of the songs intact while reaching toward something new” (Moore, 2024). The bones carried, the flesh renewed. Moore called ganavya “the singer whose work feels like prayer.” What he was naming—without the theoretical vocabulary formalizing it—was the portable temple in its contemporary form: a practice of gathering in which the sonic *tiṇṇai* is constructed not by an institution but by a single voice trained in the *yāttirikaṛ sampradāya* and refined through the transmission lineages of both South Indian devotional music and the post-Coltrane experimental tradition.

In September 2025, i attended ganavya’s *performance* at the First Universalist Unitarian Congregation in Brooklyn. The room itself was dissertation. South Asian elders sat beside queer nightlife workers, noise musicians, jazz scholars, and enamored fans drawn by the sensibilities the artist’s reputation, digital presence, and praxis conveys—a congregation that defied the segregationist logics of the city by the simple fact of being in the same pews. ganavya did not perform at the audience. She co-constituted a space-time *with* the acoustics and the presenced offering of all who were gathered—the room as resonant field, the congregation as ensemble.

³³ ganavya doraiswamy is a vocalist, composer, and scholar whose practice spans South Indian devotional music, experimental jazz, and the post-Coltrane transmission lineages. Her doctoral work engages the Akashic Records and the *yāttirikaṛ sampradāya* (pilgrim tradition). She studied under esperanza spalding and works in deep dialogue with Vijay Iyer—who recalls the moment Muhal Richard Abrams asked him, “Are you your mind?,” and answered with an allusion to Buddhist and yogic traditions: you are also the one who observes your own mind (Iyer, in Eyerly & Wheeler, 2021). The *ontological witness*, posed as a question between two pianists, passed forward into a generation that would carry it to ganavya, who carries it now.

After a few poems were songed, the parents of a friend and mentor who transitioned from this realm some ten years earlier were brought to the stage. The father, visibly and potently shaken in loving remembrance, sang an ancient Gujarati lullaby. The mother began a *garba*³⁴. ganavya raised the mother into a tear-filled embrace. The vertical hierarchy of the stage did not dissolve—it folded. The stage and the floor became a single surface without inside or outside. The *tiṇṇai*.

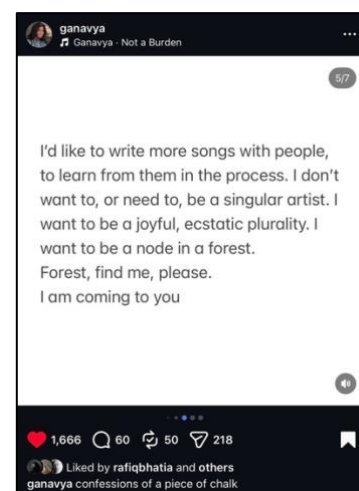
Then Marcellus Williams was invoked³⁵—his name, his case, his lyrics. The venue transformed into a site of abolitionist refusal. Hundreds of untrained voices sang his words collectively: a muddy heterophony finding common resonant frequency. The portable temple was no longer a concept. It was audible—the alpha function conducted collectively, in real time, in a room where every person present was simultaneously receiver and transmitter of a transmission that Alice Coltrane had mediated decades earlier and that showed no sign of attenuating. i left the building and the frequency was still sounding.

“I thought I could see so far ahead. / Little did I know, I was clouded. / Surrender is easier said than done. / Will you hold my hand as we walk into the sun?”

—Rajna Swaminathan, “Surrender is Easier Said Than Done,” from *Apertures* (2023).

Lyrics performed by ganavya doraiswamy

Figure 6. One frame of a lengthy post from ganavya doraiswamy, Instagram, March 3, 2026.



³⁴ *Garba* is a Gujarati circle dance performed during *Navaratri*, the nine-night festival honoring Durga and the divine feminine. The word derives from the Sanskrit *garbha* (womb): dancers move in concentric circles around a clay lamp symbolizing the soul within the body, enacting the cycle of life, death, and rebirth.

³⁵ Marcellus Williams was executed by the state of Missouri on September 24, 2024, despite significant doubt about his conviction and over the objections of the prosecuting attorney. His poetry, composed during his years on death row, circulated through abolitionist networks and entered the musical vocabulary of the communities this thesis traces. ganavya songs a poem he wrote days before his execution, “At Last, Another’s Heartbeat”. She asks the congregation to join her in his refrain: “There is so much | beauty, and comfort | in being in love | and in, just being.”

[In]Con-Clusion

This chapter inhabits an assemblage that has been operating as the thesis's own composition all along—and that the scene the field-orientation has been documenting recognized the researcher before the researcher recognized themselves in it.

“*Sat Chit Ananda*, Being-Awareness-Bliss”—Aldous Huxley wrote that, for the first time, he understood this, “not on the verbal level, not by inchoate hints or at a distance, but precisely and completely what those prodigious syllables referred to” (1954, p. 17). He was looking at flowers. Dominant readings of the perennialist canon reduce this to textual extraction—a Western intellectual cataloguing Eastern concepts from a comfortable remove. But in that moment, Huxley was not extracting. He was recognizing. Recognition is not discovery—it is remembrance. Hearing a still small voice, the body knows before the mind names. What Huxley transmitted through text—brilliant, permeating, generative—Alice Coltrane *Turiyasangitananda* transmitted through multi-modal embodied collective practice. “My music and life are both based upon a simple, integral principle,” she wrote: “spirituality and truth” (Coltrane, in Beta, 2026). His infrastructure is commonly reduced to the page; hers must be acknowledged as the life entire. What she built—across decades of monastic discipline, maternal nurturing, pedagogical care, and sonic architecture—was the infrastructure through which recognition could propagate: not as private experience but as collective individuation, not as chemical event but as devotional practice, not as one reader’s afternoon but as radiant flux. It never ceased at the threshold of any room this thesis has entered. *Monument Eternal* opened the vocabulary; the three recordings sounded it. What the preceding chapters traced—the radical perennialist architecture of a single piano composition, the collective individuation of an ashram devotional,

and the portable temple carried in overtones—were not three separate arguments. They were three faces generated out of the same break, viewed through the kaleidoscope Medina named: each new relation retroactively transforming all previously established relations, nothing collapsing into synthesis. What remains is not to summarize what the thesis has found but to demonstrate that the finding-out is still underway—that she was a medium through which the frequency communicated into culture. That transmission is active in rooms she never entered, sounding through infrastructure she could not have predicted with material certainty. The researcher’s initiated subjectivity is the primary evidence. These vignettes are its testimony.

The frequency predates its carriers. John Coltrane’s *Psalm*—the poem that became a prayer that became a melody—names it directly: “One thought can produce millions of vibrations and they all go back to God... everything does.” Swami Satchidananda³⁶, in the words Alice chose to open her own version of *A Love Supreme*, names the same structure as Love: “Love is the beginning / Love is the continuation / And Love is the end.” Between John’s vibrations returning to God and Satchidananda’s Love that is simultaneously origin, continuation, and destination, Alice enacted the modes of being this thesis has been tracing—not as origin but as aperture, the one whose fidelity to the transmission made it receivable in a form adequate to its own time. The wall was never the point. The meadow was always-already open. What follows are the rooms in which i knew it.

On November 10, 2023—weeks before i would inhabit *Apertures*—i listened to a leaked recording of André 3000’s *New Blue Sun* on the flight from Florida to New York. The album had

³⁶ Swami Satchidananda, opening invocation at the Woodstock Music and Art Fair, Bethel, New York, August 15, 1969. Satchidananda was Alice Coltrane’s guru. Carlos Santana, whose performance of “Soul Sacrifice” at the same festival prompted the researcher’s journey into this lineage, would later collaborate with Coltrane on *Illuminations* (1974) during his own concurrent spiritual path (see footnote 2). Retrieved from <https://swamisatchidananda.org/life/woodstock-guru/swami-satchidanandas-woodstock-address/>

surfaced online hours earlier with no formal announcement, only a tremor of bewilderment rippling through music culture: André Benjamin, one half of Outkast, had made an ambient flute record. i listened to it the entire flight. It was not what i expected. It was a calming and centering sonic contemplation, priming my nervous system for the new experience of NYC's ceaseless sensorial flood. The framework through which i would come to understand what i was hearing had not yet been built. Some months later, visiting a close friend in Atlanta who had come through a difficult season and was doing well—back at work, steady at home—i went to see *New Blue Sun* performed live at Center Stage. A young woman sitting beside me asked, roughly mid-performance, when they would be done warming up. She had come uninformed, expecting a hip-hop show. i explained they had just finished their third movement. She looked worried. André spoke after this, while the ensemble—Carlos Niño, Surya Botofasina, Nate Mercereau, Deantoni Parks—softly improvised beneath his words. He thanked the audience for temporarily surrendering their phones, which had been sealed at entry in magnetically locked pouches that would unlock only at the performance's end. He described how shared attention was shaping the music—that the album contained round-about licks from which each night's performance drew, but that the music was mostly improvisational, shaped by the resonance of the room and everyone gathered in it. Then he explained how the project began. He had been playing flute in public spaces for years, since retiring from touring as Outkast. One day, while grocery shopping, Niño approached him and invited him to a gathering he organized each year with Botofasina and others—a musical-honoring of the memory of Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda. This was André's first time playing flute with a group. Over the next several years, they continued to play together, eventually generating the album that would earn a Grammy nomination for Album of

the Year. André urged us to seek out his bandmates' work and announced the start of the *Year of Alice*.³⁷

In March 2025, i returned to the Apollo Music Café for the first time since that December night in 2023. i had come to see Georgia Anne Muldrow, whose music i had followed for years without knowing anything about her other than i liked the way her music felt. Midway through the performance, she paused to acknowledge her mentor—Swamini Turiyasangitananda. i was well into the concerted research for this project. i had no idea of the connection. The transmission had been sounding in Muldrow's work for as long as i had been listening to it. What the research later revealed was that the connection was not incidental but kinship: Muldrow's aunt is Radha Botofasina-Reyes—the same Radha whose testimony on the Swamini's teaching anchored the preceding chapters, the longtime ashram member, the mother of Surya Botofasina. Muldrow joined the community as a youth through her mother and aunt and was given the name Jyoti—*light, flame*—by Alice Coltrane herself. In her own words: “Through my life, Turiyasangitananda, this woman has saved my life. Just being in her field helped me be inspired to live again and not commit suicide” (Muldrow, in *Off Shelf*, 2020). Muldrow and Surya Botofasina are effectively ashram siblings. The same kinship network that produced the ashram devotionals, that carried the “Just play” pedagogy, that placed Botofasina and Niño on stage with André in Atlanta—had been running beneath Muldrow's music the entire time i was listening. What Harmony Holiday (2025) warns against—the deification that “bypasses genuine mourning

³⁷ The *Year of Alice* was inaugurated by the John & Alice Coltrane Home and the Coltrane family as a multi-disciplinary series spanning 2024–2025: including but not limited to previously unreleased recordings and reissues; the Monument Eternal exhibition at the Hammer Museum; community programming; an Alonzo King LINES Ballet premiere; a Kirtan ceremony at the Integral Yoga Institute in Manhattan—founded by Alice's guru Swami Satchidananda in 1966—and a culminating concert at Carnegie Hall curated by Ravi Coltrane with a 40-piece orchestra and the Sai Anantam Devotional Ensemble led by Michelle Coltrane (The John & Alice Coltrane Home, n.d., <https://thecoltranehome.org/year-of-alice/>).

by reducing people to idols”—is precisely what the transmission resists from within its own kinship structure. The network is not a fan community. It is a family and fellowship, and what they carry is practice: the daily labor of living in the frequency. Muldrow’s early career in Los Angeles produced another kind of transmission. At shows, she began selling hand-decorated shirts bearing a phrase she had come across in her travels: *Stay Woke*.

The phrase carried a longer history than any single carrier. In 1938, Huddie Ledbetter (Lead Belly) recorded “Scottsboro Boys,” a protest song for nine Black teenagers (Clarence Norris, Olen Montgomery, Andy Wright, Willie Roberson, Ozie Powell, Eugene Williams, Charlie Weems, Roy Wright, and Haywood Patterson) falsely accused of rape in Alabama. In the spoken afterword he warned: “I advise everybody, be a little careful when they go along through there—best stay woke, keep their eyes open” (Lead Belly, 1938). A survival instruction, born in the blues, carried in the body—the call to remain conscious in the face of material danger inseparable from the call to remain conscious at all, the two registers of wakefulness never divided in the tradition that carried them.³⁸ Muldrow first heard the phrase at the New School from the saxophonist Lakecia Benjamin, who used it casually—“I try to stay woke, but I got to go to sleep”—and adopted it as a personal reminder during a period of emotional struggle. She wrote it on a shirt. She carried it to Los Angeles. She wove it into “Master Teacher,” originally composed for Sa-Ra Creative Partners in 2005. Erykah Badu heard the song at Sa-Ra’s Cosmic Dust Studio and wanted it on her coming album, *New Amerykah Part One (4th World War)*. A crucial alteration occurred in the transfer: Muldrow’s original lyric was “I’d stay woke”—

³⁸ In 1962, Harlem author William Melvin Kelley published “If You’re Woke You Dig It” in the New York Times. The essay does not use the word “woke” beyond its title, but its subject—the systematic appropriation and decontextualization of African American slang by white culture—is the precise mechanism the word itself would undergo over the following six decades. The essay is, in this sense, prophetic of its own title’s fate (Kelley, 1962).

conditional, aspirational, the posture of one who knows she is not, yet what she reaches toward. Badu sang it as “I stay woke”—declarative, present tense, the posture of arrival. “I wasn’t claiming that I was woke,” Muldrow later reflected. “I never saw myself as woke. I saw myself as aspiring for woke, to try and stay woke. But I knew I wasn’t woke” (Muldrow, in *Okayplayer*, 2018). The conditional became the declarative. The aspiration became the identity. The practice became the brand. By 2014, “stay woke” was the rallying cry of the Black Lives Matter movement. Within years, it was a weapon in the mouths of many who never heard Lead Belly’s voice or known the names of the Scottsboro Boys.

Badu, in conversation with Ari Melber (2023), named the pharmacological situation with the calm of someone who has watched it happen before: “It doesn’t belong to us anymore... once something goes out in the world it takes a life of its own.” And then, without the theoretical vocabulary but with the full weight of the recognition this thesis has been tracing: “I believe denial is the opposite of love.” Badu’s definition restores what both the weaponization and the well-meaning adoption had flattened: woke-ness as [re]awakened-ness—as alignment with nature, operative in the body, the home, the relationship—not only the political arena. The short-circuiting did not begin with the political-right. It began the moment the practice became identity posturing—the moment the conditional collapsed into the declarative and the labor of staying became the claim of having arrived. What Stiegler calls the short-circuiting of transindividuation—the reduction of collective meaning-making to automated consumption—Badu names as denial. What Gray (2022), reading Stiegler through *Ubuntu*,³⁹ identifies as the

³⁹ *Ubuntu* (Nguni): the prefix *ubu-* denotes “enfolded be-ing” —preindividuated being always oriented toward unfoldment or individuation; the stem *ntu-* denotes the concrete manifestation of a particular entity. Gray (2022, pp. 334–335), reading Ramose (2003) through Simondon and Stiegler, identifies the movement from *ubu-* to *ntu-* as the movement from ontology to epistemology, from “be-ing becoming” to “be-ing knowing”—a process immediately implicating transindividuation, with communalism and interdependence as core values. John Mbiti

disaffection of individuals incapable of being affected—the poverty of attention that renders the pharmakon destructive—Badu names as the absence of Love. What both women were pointing at—what the word carried before the flattening, before the counter-cultural adoption, before even Lead Belly’s warning—was what the Coltranes had been transmitting in sound: access to the pre-individual field before sociogenic, hermeneutic inscriptions format consciousness into the loop this thesis has called psychocarceral enframement. The vernacular had always named the ontological witness. “Stay woke” was *Turiya* in the tongue of the blues. The changing same that Baraka traced through every formal transformation of Black music had moved through a single word across a century: from survival instruction to aspiration to declaration to weapon to, in the rooms this thesis has inhabited, practice anew.

After joining in *Deeper* practice at the Queens Museum, i went to the Sultan Room in Brooklyn the following night to see Saul Williams perform with Carlos Niño and friends. André’s words from the Atlanta stage—“they’re all doing some amazing and cool stuff”—had carried me there more than 2 years later, tertiary retentions as instructions. When i entered, Deep (Kailey) waved me over. She had read tan email i had sent the night before, sharing readings that resonated with the topics we had discussed after meeting at the *Simran* activation. She introduced me to her close friend and collaborator, Nirbhai (Nep) Singh Sidhu⁴⁰—an artist who has designed for

grounds *ubuntu* in the maxim “I am because we are,” opposing it to the Cartesian “I think, therefore I am” (Mbiti, 1970, p. 141). Gray’s argument is that Stiegler’s diagnosis of disaffection—individuals no longer capable of being affected, transindividuation short-circuited by digital automation—finds its ontological counter in *Ubuntu*’s commitment to cosmic harmony and the recognition of the humanity of others as the condition of one’s own.

⁴⁰ Nirbhai (Nep) Singh Sidhu (b. 1981) is a Punjabi-Canadian interdisciplinary artist working across textile, sculpture, sound, and adornment. A member of the creative collective Black Constellation, his practice investigates what he describes as “the metaphysics of form and spatial rhythm within the context of community and self-expression,” seeking to realize the formlessness of the divine through material form. He has exhibited at the Museum of Contemporary Art (Toronto and Detroit), the Aga Khan Museum, the Heard Museum, and Glasgow International. The omni-directional sound tower being constructed for the 2027 *Awakening the Unstruck* exhibition at the Wellin Museum extends this investigation into the infrastructure of contemplative acoustics.

Badu, Williams, and several others. Nep spoke about his work with sound sculptures. After the performance, i went to say goodnight. Nep and Deep said they would be in touch about an upcoming event. In January 2026, the invitation arrived: *Total Response*, at the Wellin Museum in Clinton, New York. Another *Simran* activation. This time the practice was being professionally recorded for a 2027 exhibition at the same museum—*Awakening the Unstruck*—which will feature many new works from Sidhu, including a massive omni-directional sound tower through which visitors will be able to explore the practice of Simran, in high-fidelity playback of the night’s practice. The title names what Sikh call *anahad shabad*, the unstruck sound that precedes all manifest vibration—the concept this thesis traced through myriad cosmologies. That it will arrive in a museum as physical architecture—sound organized by cosmological practice, the technical object and the cosmic order individuating together—is *cosmotechnics* made material: not the representation of a tradition but its continuation through new infrastructure, echoing Githere’s Afropresentist turn.

When i arrived at the Wellin, i went to look at the shirts Sidhu had designed for the evening. The young woman at the merch table said, “It’s good to see you, Jeremy.” She sensed my confusion. While she looked vaguely familiar from the Queens Museum, i did not recall meeting her. She explained that the ideas i’d shared were widely discussed within their organization—withoutShapewithoutForm. After the last event, they had asked many attendees to share our feedback on camera. The testimony i had offered (which i experienced as my own incoherent rambling lol) had been featured in the promotional materials they created because they appreciated my thoughts on their practice and ethos. The network had recognized me before i had recognized myself in it. The researcher had become a tertiary retention—words carrying a pre-individual charge forward beyond the speaker’s awareness of their reach. They interviewed

me again after *Total Response*. i was invited to an informal dinner afterward for friends, artists, and musicians. i sat with one of the founding members of withoutShapewithoutForm—a London-based Sikh woman who had transitioned from clinical psychology to community organization and experimental approaches to mental health education—alongside a professor at the Brooklyn College Conservatory and his wife. We spoke extensively about the ideas in this thesis as they pertain to the organization’s aims, and music-[sub]cultural flows wherein all converge, offering technologies of the self to all people in an irreligious and transcultural way while educating others on specific historical cultural traditions. The shared recognition was immediate: her trajectory from the clinic to the commons, mine from a winding path through numerous spiritual, philosophical, and religious systems—arriving, after years of seeking and recovery, at a Pentecostal congregation in Florida where i helped lead music—to this program, had arrived at the same questions (and answers-in-process) through entirely independent routes. As i made my way around the room saying goodnight, i fell into conversation with Angel Bat Dawid—a multi-instrumentalist and vocalist who had been part of the evening’s practice. Her spirit had stirred in me a particular feeling i had experienced in those years of devotional music. She shared, with visible excitement, that her father was a preacher and she had been raised in the Southern Baptist Church. She expressed how lovely it is to collaborate across traditions in a shared recognition of the Absolute and gave me a two-handed high-five. She recently released music with Marshall Allen—the soon-to-be 102-year-old bandleader of the Sun Ra Arkestra. The trajectory Baraka traced in 1967—from Negro spirituals through the New Thing to cosmic consciousness—had arrived at the same farewell, through an entirely independent path, and was shaking my hand. The next morning, Angel Bat Dawid posted on her socials from the John Coltrane House in Philadelphia—itsself undergoing restoration, the material infrastructure of the

transmission being renewed in parallel with its sonic carriers. Before i left the Wellin, i found Botofasina, whom i had connected with at several events in the city. i thanked him for carrying Alice's sensibilities forward. We shook hands and he told me he would see me on the other side (alluding to both of our return trips to Queens).

Days after Deep introduced me to Nep in Brooklyn, Williams took the stage at *Le Guess Who* festival in Utrecht with Niño and Botofasina—most of the same ensemble i had witnessed practicing in the small room at the Sultan Room now sounding in a European concert hall.

Williams opened by reading Assata Shakur's "Affirmation": "I believe in living. I believe in the spectrum of beta days and gamma people..." Then he delivered what can only be described as a monologue from the meadow on the other side of the wall—a sustained act of spoken

transmission that moved through colonialism, extraction, occupation, the drum as the earliest form of wireless communication—and arrived at a declaration the thesis cannot contain but can only point toward: "Before death is eternity. After death is eternity. There is no death. There's only eternity. And I be riding on the wings of eternity like—Heeyah!!! Heeyah!!! Heeyah!!!"

The full monologue is placed in Appendix A.1, not as supplementary material but as expanded sentiments the thesis has been preparing the reader to receive on their own terms. The reader who turns to it will find themselves having always-already been inside the frequency. What Williams poised was not hauntological in nature—not the ghost of a lost future returning to trouble the present. Githere's [Afro]presentist ontology acknowledges what he presences: the space between the dream and the memory collapsing into being your reality, now. The transmission does not need [re]animating, because it was never not sounding.

What Du Bois (1903) named as *double consciousness*—the sense of always looking at oneself through the eyes of [the] other(s)—is psychocarceral enframing at a notice-point in Black

American intellectual history: the postcolonial subject divided against itself by a gaze it has internalized but did not author. Bazian (2013), in “The Souls of Muslim Folk,” extends this beyond the historically specific Black American condition Du Bois names—identifying the Eurocentric “known” world as that which “produces double consciousness in all subject people it came in contact with” through the ideological engrafting of its filtering lens onto the very affordance of reflexive cognition. The post-colonial subject Bazian names is the body whose aperture has been engrafted with the colonial-imaginary lens at the moment of its opening—the always-already problematic where the Zapffean co-constitution of reflexive cognition and psychic defense meets the Althusserian interpellation by which, because ideology has no outside, the subject is recruited into Eurocentric subjecthood at the same moment it becomes a subject at all—the methodological situation the mosaic-lensed deframement was named to meet. Medina’s extension from double to kaleidoscopic consciousness is not a correction of Du Bois but an excitation—the fracture (*break*) held open long enough to become generative rather than imprisoning, the split transformed from wound into faculty. Raymond Williams (1977) gives the transmission network a name the cultural vocabulary has not yet absorbed: a *structure of feeling*—social experience in solution, as distinct from formations that have been precipitated into fixed and available forms. What Williams names is “a kind of feeling and thinking which is indeed social and material, but each in an embryonic phase before it can become fully articulate and defined exchange,” often “not yet recognized as social but taken to be private, idiosyncratic, and even isolating” (pp. 131–132). The ashram kinship network(s), grocery store invitations, messages of care from strangers on Instagram, and homemade shirts with two words on them—these are not anecdotes. They are the structure of a feeling that the existing critical apparatus seems incapable of pricing. What Bohm (1980) calls the implicate order—the enfolded

wholeness from which the explicate manifests—and what Krishnamurti, in their shared dialogues, identifies as the ending of psychological time (Bohm & Krishnamurti, 1985), finds its topological form in Rapoport's Klein Bottle: the non-orientable surface whose inside and outside are continuous, whose self-penetration surmounts the *Cartesian Cut* that separated subject from object, mind from world, the knower from the known (Rapoport, 2023). Phillips' (2025) refusal of the master's clock draws back into view: colonial time is the orientable surface—sequential, extractive, linear. What the *bhajan* sessions dissolved, what the *Simran* activation holds open, and what the portable temple carries in its overtones, is the non-orientable topology in which before and after, inside and outside, self-penetrate. The *static-circulatory subject* of psychocarceral enframing—looping through commodity, signature, and the recursive self-totalization Hofstadter diagnosed—is not the opposite of stillness but its counterfeit: motion without movement, a circulation that forecloses the very field it mines. The *static-oscillatory subject* is this topology inhabited: not static in the sense of stopped-ness but vibrating at the frequency of the real-to-Real playback, the Klein Bottle's continuous surface where what appears as duality—waking and dreaming; scholarship and devotion; the personal and the institutional—is held without the *cut* that would make them two. It arrives here almost without commentary, because the vignettes have already placed the reader inside it. What Aristotle called *phronesis*—practical wisdom, the eye of moral experience—Kristjánsson and Fowers (2024) confirm as contingently uncodifiable: it cannot be reduced to algorithm or principle, only recognized in the particular by a perception trained through the accumulation of situated encounters. The thesis has not been arguing for this recognition. It has been [en]training ontological witness. Amid so much contemporary stir around consciousness studies, this thesis is not interested in what consciousness is. It is interested in what we are doing with it.

What this thesis has been doing with consciousness is exemplifying *mosaic-lensed deframement*—the method now deeply expressed across every page, every vignette, every close listening, and capable of being flagged here as the methodological recognition the practice has been earning all along. The method holds open the fractures in the post-colonial subject's psyche, potentiating the generation of ever-new modes of being outside the constructed binaristic enclosures Empire inscribes. It activates the affordances necessary for the self-awareness of *cosmic-being-ness* to re-cognize its relation to all things, existing in relation to Empire but not of its hermeneutically inscribed ontological abstractions. The fracture and the recognition are the single operation: the holding-open of the break long enough for the cosmic-being-ness beneath the constructions to come into self-awareness of the relations the binary enclosure had foreclosed. The frequency that was never not sounding is the sounding of those relational in-betweens. The expanded work the method potentiates is cosmotechnicity itself—the condition in which technical practices illumine a cosmic order rather than extract or abstract from it, the state held open by the method in which being re-cognizes its relations and enacts them materially. What Coltrane built at Sai Anantam, what the thesis has been tracing across three case studies, and what the transmission continues to build in every carrier who receives it, is cosmotechnicity—the unification of cosmic order and technical activity, plural against the homogenizing Western Promethean model the engrafted lens had foreclosed. The method is itself a practice emerging from the sensibility it makes audible in its subject; technodiversity is what that practice opens toward.

In the final stages of this research process, i was exploring more of ganavya's mentor, Vijay Iyer's work around *Black Radical Imaginaries*, when i came across a chapter he'd contributed to *Sounding Together* (Eyerly & Wheeler, 2021). In the collection's first chapter, i found myself

looking at a photograph of collaborators working to [re]sound eighteenth-century Mohican-Moravian hymn texts. Among them was Bill Miller—Grammy-winning Stockbridge-Munsee Mohican musician, singer-songwriter, practitioner across traditional Native American flute, blues, gospel, rock, and sacred music. Bill Miller is my cousin. i did not know he was in the book. i did not open the book looking for my own heritage. The transmission was already in the family. Miller’s practice—bringing ancestral hymn texts back through improvisation, refusing to listen to the German chorale tunes that had originally carried them, drawing instead on what he heard in the woods with the elder hunters and at powwows—is the same structure this thesis has been tracing at every scale. “It’s bringing the past up to now,” he said, “and it is powerful to hold this thing, this song, hundreds and hundreds of years old and then put it in my breath and put it in my soul and then bring it out in the present tense” (Miller, in Eyerly & Wheeler, 2021). Not reanimation—not the revival of something dead—but the present-tense inhabitation of what was never not sounding. When he speaks to students, he asks: “What is Mohican music?” After watching them struggle, he plays a riff on Johnny Cash or Eric Clapton and says, with a grin, “Now, that’s Mohican music.”⁴¹ The radical perennialist architecture in a joke. The tradition is the living practice, whatever form it takes. The thesis that began with Alice Coltrane’s perennialist practice discovers, at its close, the same structure in the researcher’s own kinship—the same convergence of traditions, the same refusal to let any single form contain what the practice carries, the same spiritual work in service of community. This was not designed. It emerged in not-knowing what was to be discovered.

⁴¹ Adams (2016, p. 7) records that Alice’s maternal great-great-grandfather, Running Fox, was a Native American chief who communicated with her through meditation in later years. Alice described him as one whose primal energy, the kundalini shakti, had reached upward to the sahasrara chakra. She called this ancestor her “physiological link to Asia and her spiritual, holy land of India.” The indigenous thread was inside the transmission before any of its carriers named it. That the researcher’s own Mohican kinship converges with this at the thesis’s close was not designed. It emerged in not-knowing what was to be discovered.

This thesis opens more doors than it has yet entered. The pharmacological journey a single word can take from survival instruction to cultural weapon—traced here across a century—warrants a full study. The cosmotechnical architecture of Sidhu’s sound sculptures, the pedagogical lineage from Coltrane through Botofasina to the next generation, the relationship between *Simran* and *Deep Listening* as parallel *technologies of the self*, the Mohican-Moravian hymn tradition as radical practice of *creolization*, the kinship networks carrying the transmission through informal channels that institutional sights have historically overlooked (just to name a few)—each is a thesis in waiting. Existing neurological and somatic research in-formation increasingly corroborates the ontological claims this thesis and its interlocutors make—from contemplative neuroscience to polyvagal theory to psychedelic phenomenology—awaits integration with the cultural and philosophical frameworks assembled here.

At the Rough Trade celebration of Monument Eternal’s second edition, i spoke with panel speaker Ashley Kahn—music journalist and NYU Tisch faculty—about the nature of this thesis. He shared that the university had been developing an interdepartmental course around Turiyasangitananda’s practice and legacy, and that it was proving an immensely difficult task. What this work offers is not a conclusion but a lens, and the lens is available to anyone with the openness to use it.

From punk to hip-hop to jazz, and every variety of other categorical enclosure, musicians and artists who made their life the *work of art*... have been educating, inspiring, and informing me all along. The thesis did not produce the recognition. It gave the recognition a language adequate to itself. In a recent video documenting the *Total Response* practice, i observed:

“What i think is so beautiful about the name Koi... the title Koi—that’s so beautiful to me because that’s what’s important to me in my own life. And those are the kind of people that i see as heroes—are these people who’ve accessed true presence—to find the solidity in that—to move that way in your entire life and in every single thing you do. That’s, to me... why you do this” (Burmeister, 2026, March 7, in withoutSHAPEwithoutFORM Total Response promotional video, posted on Instagram).



Figure 7. Nirbhai (Nep) Singh Sidhu, [title unknown], metalwork sculpture. On stage during Total Response practice, Wellin Museum, Clinton, New York, March 2026. Photograph by the researcher.

The frequency was never not sounding.

Koi (ਕੋਈ): someone, anyone. *Koi Nahi* (ਕੋਈ ਨਹੀ): no one, nobody. *Har Koi* (ਹਰ ਕੋਈ): everyone, each one.⁴²

⁴² In a spiritual sense, the word *koi* (ਕੋਈ) functions in Sikhism as what might be called a *Universal Variable*. In the *Siri Guru Granth Sahib*, it is used to dismantle human-made barriers and point toward the singular, formless Divine. The phrase “*Nanak Uttam Neech Na Koi*”—*Nanak*, there is no high or low person—uses *koi* to negate hierarchy. Spiritually, it signifies that in the eyes of the Creator, distinct identities do not exist; everyone is a vessel for the same Divine Light. That this word names the practice at which the thesis arrives—carried by Punjabi artists, sounded in a museum in upstate New York, documented in a video featuring a researcher from a Christian background in Florida—is itself the radical perennialist architecture this thesis has been tracing.



Figure 8. *listens to alice coltrane once*. Meme posted by @deepcutsrecordstore, Instagram, March 5, 2026, scored to Alice Coltrane's "Journey in Satchidananda (feat. Pharoah Sanders)." Re-shared by @alicecoltraneofficial (the estate) and Flying Lotus (Steven Ellison, Alice Coltrane's great-nephew). Commented on by Matana Roberts, AACM-lineage composer and saxophonist: "all it takes 🌸." Bobby Hill character, King of the Hill (20th Television, 1997–2010)

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Discography



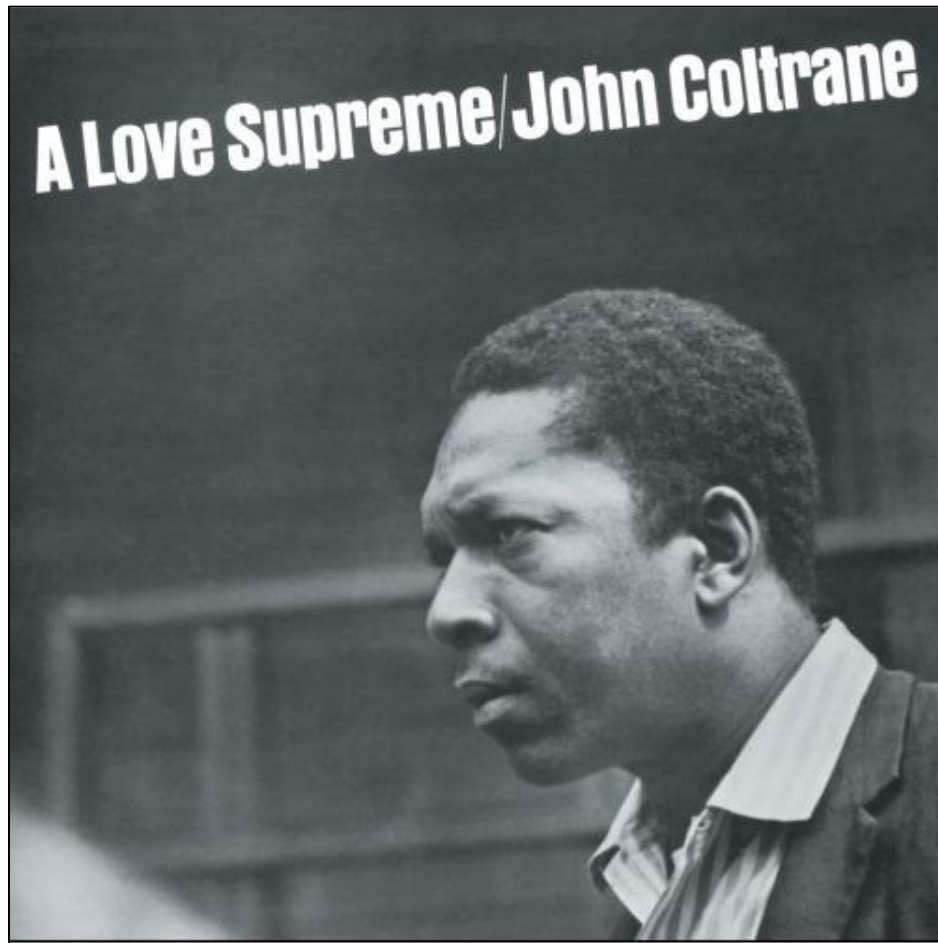
Lead Belly. (1938). Scottsboro Boys [Song]. *Smithsonian Folkways Recordings* (disc 1 of 5).

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|--|------|---|------|
| 1. "Irene (Goodnight Irene)" | 1:56 | from the Gallows)" | |
| 2. "The Bourgeois Blues" | 2:21 | 13. "Ha-Ha This a Way" | 1:34 |
| 3. "Fannin Street (Mister Tom Hughes Brown)" | 3:34 | 14. "Sukey Jump" | 1:04 |
| 4. "The Midnight Special" | 2:05 | 15. "Boll Weevil" | 3:07 |
| 5. "John Henry" (with Sonny Terry) | 3:13 | 16. "Scottsboro Boys" | 4:32 |
| 6. "Black Girl (Where Did You Sleep Last Night)" | 2:07 | 17. "Governor O.K. Allen" | 2:37 |
| 7. "Pick a Bale of Cotton" (with the Oleander Quartet) | 1:30 | 18. "Governor Pat Neff" | 3:40 |
| 8. "Take This Hammer" | 2:15 | 19. "There's a Man Going Around Taking Names" | 1:24 |
| 9. "Cotton Fields" | 2:06 | 20. "On a Monday (Almost Done)" (with Sonny Terry) | 1:47 |
| 10. "Old Riley / Here, Rattler, Here" | 1:58 | 21. "You Can't Lose Me, Cholly" | 2:37 |
| 11. "Rock Island Line" | 2:02 | 22. "Keep Your Hands Off Her" | 2:51 |
| 12. "The Gallis Pole (The Maid Freed" | 2:45 | 23. "We Shall Be Free" (with Woody Guthrie and Cisco Houston) | 2:34 |



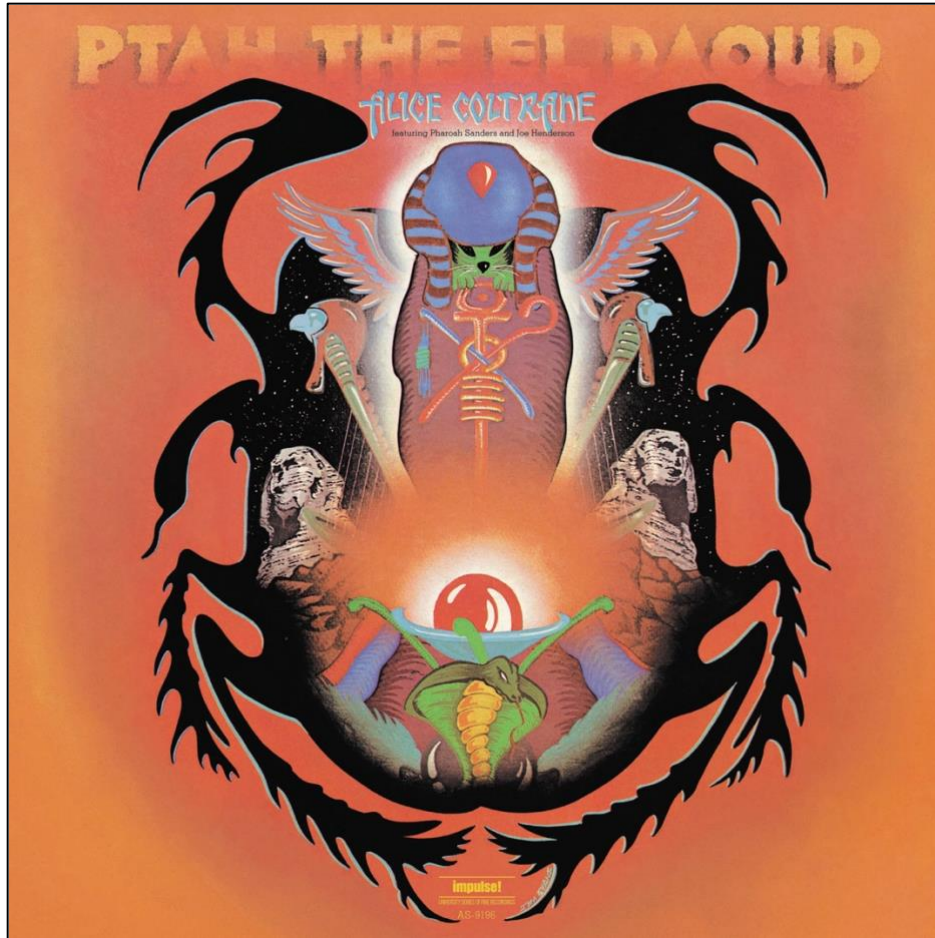
Coltrane, J. (1963). Alabama. On *Live at Birdland* [Album]. Impulse! Records.

1. "Afro Blue" (Mongo Santamaria) – 10:50
2. "I Want to Talk About You" (Billy Eckstine) – 8:11
3. "The Promise" – 8:10
4. **"Alabama"** – 5:09
5. "Your Lady" – 6:39



Coltrane, J. (1965). *A Love Supreme* [Album]. Impulse! Records.

1. "Acknowledgement" – 7:42
2. "Resolution" – 7:20
3. "Pursuance" – 10:41
4. "**Psalm**" – 7:05



Coltrane, A. (1970). Turiya and Ramakrishna. On *Ptah, the El Daoud* [Album]. Impulse! Records.

1. "Ptah, the El Daoud" – 13:58
2. **"Turiya and Ramakrishna"** – 8:19
3. "Blue Nile" – 6:58
4. "Mantra" – 16:33

Alice Coltrane – piano (1, 2, 4), harp (3)

Pharoah Sanders – tenor saxophone (1, 4), alto flute (3),
bells

Joe Henderson – tenor saxophone (1, 4), alto flute (3)

Ron Carter – double bass

Ben Riley – drums



Coltrane, J. (1972). *Infinity* [Album]. Impulse! Records. Produced by Alice Coltrane.

1. "Peace on Earth" – 8:33
2. "Living Space" – 10:28
3. "Joy" – 7:54
4. "Leo" – 9:52



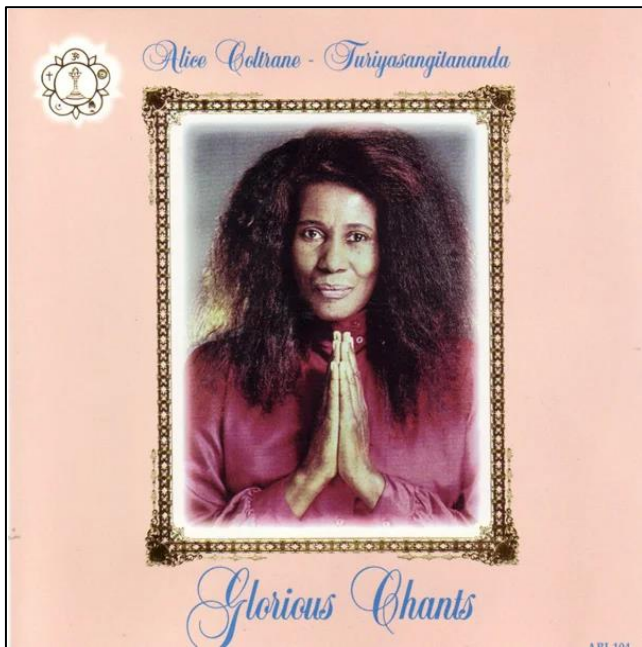
Coltrane, A. (1972). *World Galaxy* [Album]. Impulse! Records.

1. "My Favorite Things" (Richard Rodgers, Oscar Hammerstein II) – 6:22
2. "Galaxy Around Olodumare" – 4:15
3. "Galaxy In Turiya" – 9:55
4. "Galaxy In Satchidananda" – 10:25
5. **"A Love Supreme"** (John Coltrane) – 9:58



Santana-Devadip, C., & Coltrane-Turiyasangitananda, A. (1974). *Illuminations* [Album]. Columbia Records.

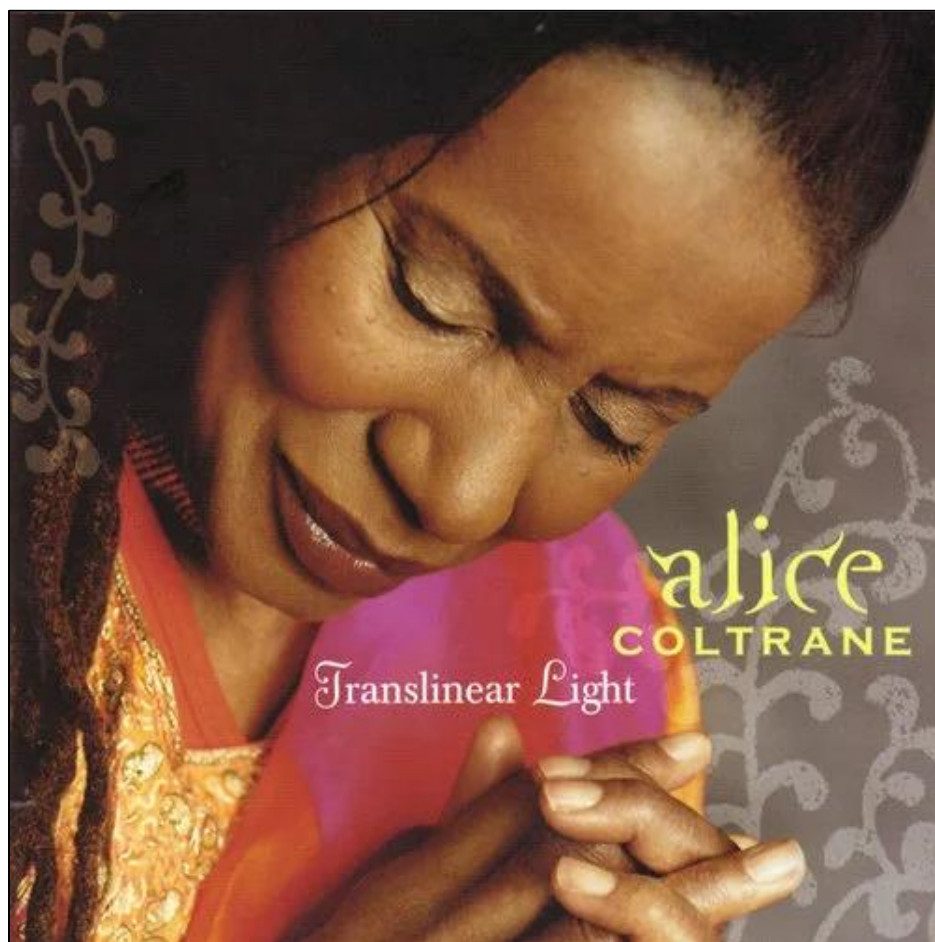
1. "Guru Sri Chinmoy Aphorism" (S. Chinmoy) - 1:11
2. "Angel of Air / Angel of Water" (Coster-Santana) - 9:55
3. "Bliss: the Eternal Now" (A. Coltrane) - 5:33
4. "Angel of Sunlight" (Coster-Santana) - 14:43
5. "Illuminations" (Coster-Santana) – 4:18



Coltrane-Turiyasangitananda, A. (1995). *Glorious Chants* [Ashram recording]. Avatar Book Institute. (Private-press cassette; first publicly released on *World Music Vol. 1*, Luaka Bop, 2017.)

1.	"Om Rama"	<i>Infinite Chants</i>	9:39
2.	"Om Shanti"	<i>Divine Songs</i>	6:52
3.	"Rama Rama"	<i>Divine Songs</i>	7:35
4.	"Rama Guru"	<i>Infinite Chants</i>	5:52
5.	"Hari Narayan"	<i>Divine Songs</i>	4:38
6.	"Journey to Satchidananda"	<i>Glorious Chants</i>	10:53
7.	"Er Ra"	<i>Divine Songs</i>	5:00
8.	"Keshava Murahara"	<i>Divine Songs</i>	9:43
9.	"Krishna Japaye"	<i>Infinite Chants</i>	5:31
10.	"Rama Katha"	<i>Turiya Sings</i>	11:40

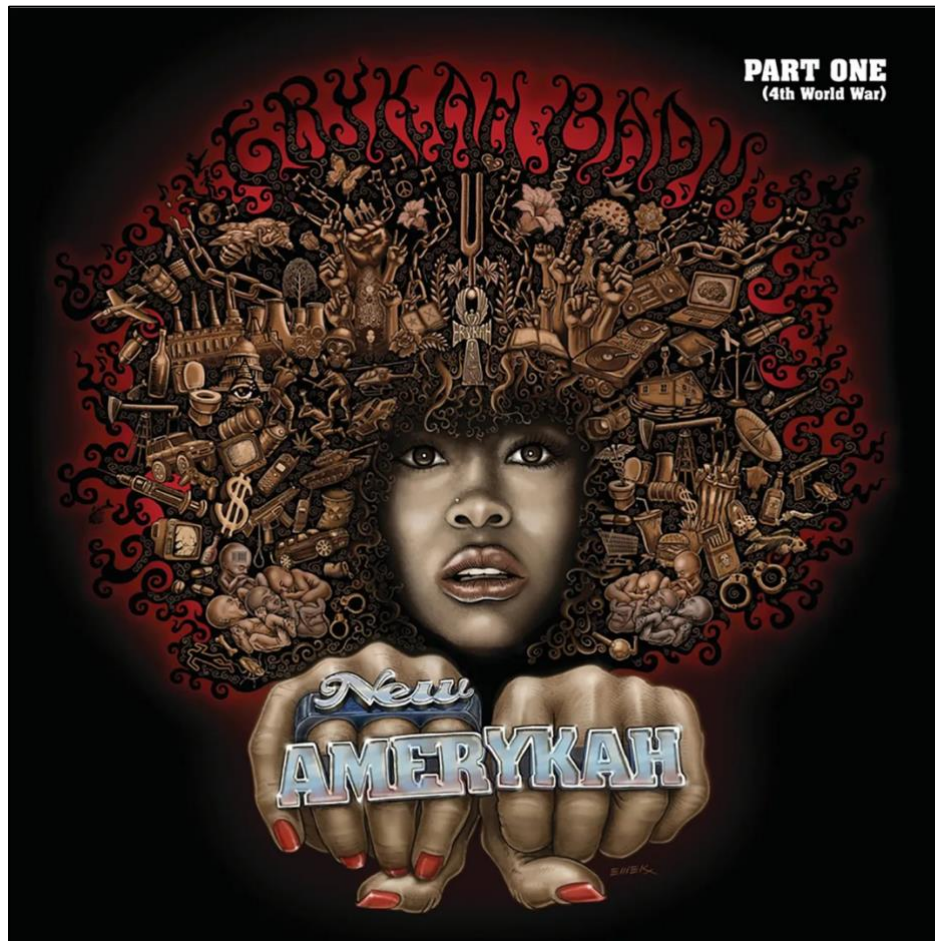
Alice Coltrane – vocals, organ, synthesizers (Oberheim OB-8), harp
 The Sai Anantam Singers – vocals
 Joshua Spiegelman – flute solo on "Journey to Satchidananda"
 Sai Ram Iyer – vocal solo on "Journey to Satchidananda"
 John Panduranga Henderson - vocal solo on "Om Rama"



Coltrane, A. (2004). *Translinear Light* [Album]. Impulse! Records.

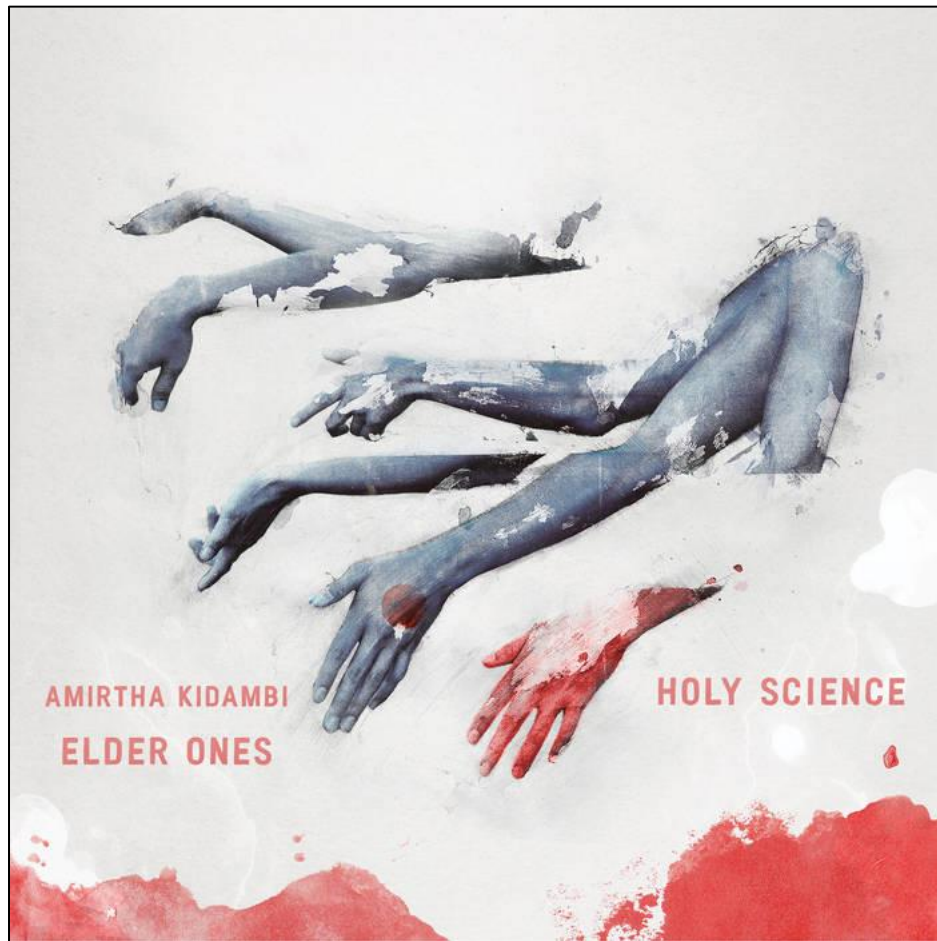
1.	"Sita Ram"	traditional	6:08
2.	"Walk with Me"	traditional	7:50
3.	"Translinear Light"	Alice Coltrane	9:50
4.	"Jagadishwar"	Alice Coltrane	5:47
5.	"This Train"	traditional	6:06
6.	"The Hymn"	Alice Coltrane	3:04
7.	"Blue Nile"	Alice Coltrane	8:05
8.	"Crescent"	John Coltrane	6:22
9.	"Leo"	John Coltrane	9:40
10.	"Triloka"	Alice Coltrane	5:08
11.	"Satya Sai Isha"	traditional	5:40

Alice Coltrane – piano or Wurlitzer organ; synthesizer on "The Hymn" • Ravi Coltrane – tenor saxophone on "Jagadishwar," "Blue Nile," "Crescent," and "Leo"; soprano saxophone on "Translinear Light"; percussion on "Sita Ram" and "Translinear Light"; sleigh bells on "Leo" • Oran Coltrane – alto saxophone on "The Hymn" • Charlie Haden – bass on "Translinear Light," "This Train," "Crescent," and "Troika" • James Genus – bass on "Walk with Me," "Jagadishwar," and "Blue Nile" • Jack De Johnette – drums on "Sita Ram," "Translinear Light," "This Train," and "Crescent," and "Leo" • Jeff "Tain" Watts – drums on "Walk with Me," "Jagadishwar," and "Blue Nile" • The Sai Anantam Ashram Singers – vocals on "Satya Sai Isha"



Badu, E. (2008). *New Amerykah Part One (4th World War)* [Album]. Universal Motown.

- | | |
|-----------------------------------|------|
| 1. "Amerykahn Promise" | 4:16 |
| 2. "The Healer" | 3:59 |
| 3. "Me" | 5:36 |
| 4. "My People" | 3:25 |
| 5. "Soldier" | 5:04 |
| 6. "The Cell" | 4:21 |
| 7. "Twinkle" | 6:57 |
| 8. "Master Teacher Medley" | 6:48 |
| 9. "That Hump" | 5:25 |
| 10. "Telephone" | 7:48 |
| 11. "Honey" (bonus track) | 5:21 |



Elder Ones. (2016). *Holy Science* [Album]. Northern Spy Records.

- | | |
|-------------------------------------|-------|
| 1. "Sathya Yuga" | 13:19 |
| 2. "Treta Yuga" | 20:31 |
| 3. "Dvapara Yiga (For Eric Garner)" | 12:40 |
| 4. "Kali Yuga" | 17:32 |



André 3000. (2023). *New Blue Sun* [Album]. Epic Records.

1. "I Swear, I Really Wanted to Make a 'Rap' Album but This Is Literally the Way the Wind Blew Me This Time" 12:20
2. "The Slang Word P(*)ssy Rolls Off the Tongue with Far Better Ease Than the Proper Word Vagina. Do You Agree?" 13:50
3. "That Night in Hawaii When I Turned into a Panther and Started Making These Low Register Purring Tones That I Couldn't Control ... Sh¥t Was Wild" 10:29
4. "BuyPolDisorder's Daughter Wears a 3000® Shirt Embroidered" 13:05
5. "Ninety-Three 'Til Infinity and Beyoncé" 3:49
6. "Ghandi, Dalai Lama, Your Lord & Savior J.C. / Bundy, Jeffrey Dahmer, and John Wayne Gacy" 10:15
7. "Ants to You, Gods to Who?" 6:42
8. "Dreams Once Buried Beneath the Dungeon Floor Slowly Sprout into Undying Gardens" 17:11



Swaminathan, R. (2023). *Apertures* [Album]. Commissioned by Chamber Music America's New Jazz Works Program, funded by the Doris Duke Charitable Foundation. Additional support by Harvard University Music Department. Co-produced by ganavya doraiswamy.

- | | | |
|----|---|--------------|
| 1. | "Mystery Suspended" | 12:49 |
| 2. | "Precipice" | 6:23 |
| 3. | "Altitude" | 9:50 |
| 4. | "Charcoal" | 8:50 |
| 5. | "Apertures" | 7:00 |
| 6. | "One" | 14:05 |
| 7. | "Surrender is Easier Said Than Done" | 14:58 |



doraiswamy, ganavya. (2024). *daughter of a temple* [Album]. LEITER.

- | | |
|---|-------|
| 1. "A Love Chant" (feat. esperanza spalding) | 0:42 |
| 2. "Om Supreme" (feat. Vijay Iyer & Immanuel Wilkins) | 10:15 |
| 3. "Prema Muditha" (feat. Shabaka Hutchings) | 4:53 |
| 4. "Elders Wayne and Carolina" | 2:16 |
| 5. "Om Namah Sivaya" (feat. Charles Overton & Ganesan Doraiswamy) | 5:18 |
| 6. "Journey in Satchidananda / Ghana Nila" | 6:37 |
| 7. "A Love Supreme, Part 1: Ishmael Wadada Leo Smith" | 1:00 |
| 8. "A Love Supreme, Part 2: Peter Sellars" (feat. Peter Sellars) | 7:21 |
| 9. "A Love Supreme, Part 3: Alice Coltrane" | 5:49 |
| 10. "A Love Supreme, Part 4: IONE" (feat. IONE) | 3:57 |

Appendix A – Textual Retentions

A.1 *Saul Williams meets Carlos Niño & Friends featuring Surya Botofasina*

Collaborative Sound Ceremony, *Le Guess Who?*, Utrecht, 2024

Transcribed by the researcher from *Le Guess Who?* (2024).

YouTube. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vISrvGmWUNo>

"I would like to read a poem by a very recent ancestor and an inspiration to those of us on this stage. Her name is Assata Shakur. If you do not know who she is, we encourage you to find out who she is. This is a poem that begins her autobiography. It is called "Affirmation":

'I believe in living. I believe in the spectrum of beta days and gamma people.

I believe in sunshine, in windmills and waterfalls, tricycles and rocking chairs, and I believe that seeds grow into sprouts and sprouts grow into trees.

I believe in the magic of the hands and in the wisdom of the eyes.

I believe in rain and tears and in the blood of infinity.

I believe in life, and I have seen the death parade march through the torso of the earth, sculpting mud bodies in its path.

I have seen the destruction of the daylight and seen bloodthirsty maggots prayed to and saluted.

I have seen the kind become the blind and the blind become the bind, in one easy lesson.

I have walked on cut glass.

I have eaten crow and blunderbread and breathed the stench of indifference.

I have been locked by the lawless, handcuffed by the haters, gagged by the greedy.

*And if I know anything at all, it's that a wall is just a wall and nothing more at all. It can
be broken down. ' (from Assata: An Autobiography)*

*Hack into dietary sustenance—tradition vs. health / Hack into comfort—compliance / Hack
into the rebellious gene / Hack into doctrine—capitalism in relation to free labor and slavery /
Hack into the history of the bank—is beating the odds of mere actor joining the winning
team? / Hack in the desperation and loneliness—the history of community and the
marketplace / Hack into land rights and ownership / Hack into business law—proprietorship /
Hack into ambition and greed / Hack into forms of government—systems of control—the
relation to suffering and sufferance / Hack into faith and morality—the treatment of one faith
towards another / Hack into masculinity; femininity; sexuality / What is taught? What is felt?
What is learned? What is shared? / Hack into God: stories of creation—serpents and eggs /
Hack into nature: biodynamics, biodiversity, cycles, and seasons / Hack into time; calendars—
Descartes—its relationship to doubt. Is it wired to fear? The notion of control—the space-time
continuum; the force of gravity—whether the opposite of gravity is freedom / Hack into
freedom; power; responsibility; justice—the bill of rights / Hack into coincidence / The
summer of '68; the 27 club—the number of people with Facebook profiles—people who
choose to share; people who share too much; people who seem lonely; people who want to
connect; people want to uplift / Hack into self-help; self-sufficiency; and self-indulgence. Hack
into crazy / Hack into lunatic / Hack into star / Hack into infamous; notorious—the effects of*

the construct of poverty on the psyche; the effects of the construct of race—the victims that survived.

There is a panel marked survival... three simple copper wires coiled round an orb / Hack into orbit—equatorial landmines—useful and precious metals / Coltan as cotton / Hack into hazardous—nuclear—blu-clear—cloud forms and fish farms; cow farts and pigshit / Hack into horse—industrial; digital / Hack into code / Use your instrument as metaphor / Harness your craft / Hack into the mainframe / Dismantle definition—dogma and duty / Hack into destiny / Hack into dreams—subtext and subconscious / Hack into heart—cardio; Congo; blood, rich and oil / Hack into suffering and despair / Hack into the unfair advantage of those lucky enough to be born into one family or another—into one condition or another / Hack into the circumstantial evidence that proves the obvious and wakes the oblivious / Hack into birthright—bloodlines, royal and tainted / Hack in the superstition—old wives tales; the rituals of the shaman / Hack into DNA—chemistry; the pharmaceutical industry; the modern-day rape of the forest—the coiling serpents—the time it takes for modern man to determine whether ancient women were foolish or not / Hack into the database / Hack into the subconscious—the panel marked survival / Hack into celebrity / Hack into the cultural development of taste / Hack into violence, fear, and ignorance. How / are / they / linked?

We are here to make links, to draw parallels, to make distinctions, observations. What we have observed is that... perhaps there is no time like the present. It's the British poet John Keats who said that poets are midwives of reality. Yet in this moment we have the sense that perhaps—perhaps we are more like, death doulas. Death doulas for the end of empire. What we are certain of is that it is more than our governments that are complicit in genocide. What

we acknowledge is that it is perhaps our cultures themselves that hold the root of that complicity. That unsaid sense of superiority that is taught and handed down. Even as we gather in this moment and we think of the mothers and children and brothers and fathers who have lost their lives in Sudan—in this moment—we think of the children. What is true of this moment, and perhaps it is a truth that you share with me, is that I have never seen so many dead children. Count fingers. Count toes. Count blessings. The murders they took no count of is how I learned to count.

It is not only the contemporary actions that we speak of. We know what has happened in places like: Surinam; Indonesia. I think of the Congo. I think of the uncharted and unrecognized genocides in places like Namibia. The Nama, the Herero, the Lenni Lenape—the indigenous of those illegitimate states, Abya Yala. We acknowledge that everything that has been said about the Zionist entity is true of those illegitimate states that they call America. Which is to say that it has no right to exist on the blood and bones of our ancestors. But we acknowledge—we acknowledge—the wealth and opulence of Europe. We acknowledge that that opulence and wealth, the millions that were made off of slave ships that were sold by this country, for example. I don't know what they teach you in your schools. Nothing. Sounds like they teach you exactly what they taught me in mine. Yet we say—We say, land back and abolition. We say indigenous sovereignty and liberation. We understand abolition as the rebellious and creative re-imagining of our schools—of our communities. We realize that there is an opportunity because there is a connection that has been forged through that which we have all borne witness to: in Palestine; in Yemen; in Iran. The intentional destabilization of the Congo, The intentional destabilization of Haiti. The people in the streets in Madagascar right now—the people in the streets in Tanzania right now—the US Navy ships parked

outside of Venezuela right now. All of these have one thing in common. Black death and indigenous erasure extraction. They say fossil fuels. We say 'whose fossils?' They would have us imagine that those fossils have developed over time through the death of dinosaurs and mammoths. But what of the people? What of the people? Those over 10 million killed in the Congo for the rubber in the tires of our cars. Our daily comforts. Oh, 'I can't start my day without coffee.' Where does the coffee come from? 'I like a little sugar in mine.' Where does the sugar come from? 'Oh, I love chocolate.' Where does the chocolate come from? 'Oh, I drive an electric vehicle'. Where does the lithium in the battery come from? It comes from the continued practice of Western civilization. They call it technology. They call it human progress. The irony is that if it were truly digital and technological advancement, why is it so deeply rooted in analog forms of exploitation?

Glory to the resistance! Glory to all anti-colonial resistance! Glory to all anti-capitalist resistance! We say "racial capitalism" simply to remind you that all capitalism is racial. It is not simply a matter of the exploitation of workers. It is a matter of Black death and Indigenous erasure. And we call on the spirit of the martyrs. We ask them to inhabit us and to inhabit this space. We recognize the drum—the drum—as the earliest form of wireless communication. This is why in those illegitimate states they banned African drums. They banned them. Why? Because they realized that we were using them to communicate, and they feared rebellion.

How many lives? How many more lives will it take? The poet Audre Lorde says that hope is counterrevolutionary. Pressure cooks. So, how do we apply pressure? Clearly, the most obvious way of bringing a machine to a halt would be by withholding our labor globally. As I

mentioned, we are here under the guise of music to convene a meeting. Perhaps we are here to remind ourselves of the role of music. For it is music that travels without passports. That crosses borders and boundaries that are sometime restricted to us, to our siblings and relatives.

You know, I could recite the grass on a hill and memorize the moon. I know the cloud forms of love by heart and have brought tears to the eye of the storm. My memory banks—vaults of autumn forest and Amazon riverbanks. And I've screamed them into sunsets that echo in earthquakes. Shadows have been my spotlight as I monologue the night and dialogue with days. Soliloquies of wind and breeze applauded by sunrays. We put language in zoos to observe caged thought and tossed peanuts and pea funk at intellect.

And niggas think these are metaphors. I speak what I see. All words and worlds are metaphors of me. My life is authored by the moon. Footprints written in soil. The fountain pen of Martian men noveling human toil. And yes, the soil speaks highly of me. When earth seeds, root me, poet tree and we forest forever through recitation. Now maybe I'm too serious—too little here; too matter. Though I'm riddled with the reason of the sun, a standup comet with the audience of lungs. This body of laughter—is it with me, or at me? Hu-[mor]e, or less human, though genders mute. And the punchline has this lifeline at its root. I'm a star. This life's the suburbs. I commute. Make daily runs between the sun and earthly loot and raise my children to the height of light and truth. If I could find the spot where truth echoes, I would stand and whisper memories of my children's future. I would let their future dwell in my past so that I might live a brighter now. Now is the essence of my domain and it contains all that was and will be. And I am as I was and will be because I am and always will be | that nigga. I am that

nigga. I am that timeless nigga that swings on pendulums like vines through minds of booby-trapped minds that are enslaved by time. I am the life that supersedes lifetimes. I am. It was me with serpentine hair and a timeless stare that with a mortal glare turned mortal fear into stone time capsules. They still exist as the walking dead as I do. The original sufferhead symbol of life and patriarchy severed-head medusa. I am. It was me, the Ecclesiastical One that pointed out that there was nothing new under the sun. And through times of laughter and times of tears, so that no times are real times all times of fear. The wise seer Solomon—I am. It was me, with tattered clothes that made you scatter as you shuffled past me on the street. Yes, you shuffled past me on the street as I stood there conversing with windblown spirits. And I fear it's your loss. You didn't stop to talk to me. I could have told you your future. I explain your present. But instead, I'm the homeless schizophrenic resented for being aimless. The untuned nameless. I am. I am, that nigga. I am that nigga. I am a negro. Yes, negro. Negro from necro, meaning death. I overcame it, so they name me after it. And they be spitting at us behind and putting kick me signs on his back because I am not the son of Sha-Clack-Clack. I am before that. I am before. I am before before. Before death is eternity. After death is eternity. There is no death. There's only eternity. And I be riding on the wings of eternity like— Heeyah!!! Heeyah!!! Heeyah!!! Heeyah!!! Heeyah!!! Heeyah!!!

A.2 John Coltrane, "A Love Supreme" [Poem/Psalm]. From the liner notes of *A Love Supreme* (Impulse! Records, 1965). Coltrane wove the words of this poem into the saxophone's melodic line on the album's fourth movement, "Psalm"—a spoken prayer hidden inside the instrument's voice, legible only when the liner notes reveal what the horn projected in the first place.

A Love Supreme

*I will do all I can to be worthy of Thee O Lord.
 It all has to do with it.
 Thank you, God.
 Peace.
 There is none other.
 God is. It is so beautiful.
 Thank you, God. God is all.
 Help us to resolve our fears and weaknesses.
 Thank you, God.
 In You all things are possible.
 We know. God made us so.
 Keep your eye on God.
 God is. He always was. He always will be.
 No matter what...it is God.
 He is gracious and merciful.
 It is most important that I know Thee.
 Words, sounds, speech, men, memory, thoughts,
 fears and emotions – time – all related ...
 all made from one... all made in one.
 Blessed be His name.
 Thought waves–heat waves–all vibrations–
 all paths lead to God. Thank you, God.*

*His way... it is so lovely... it is gracious.
 It is merciful–thank you God.
 One thought can produce millions of vibrations
 and they all go back to God... everything does.
 Thank you, God.
 Have no fear ... believe... thank you God.
 The universe has many wonders. God is all. His way... it is so wonderful.
 Thoughts–deeds–vibrations, etc.
 They all go back to God and He cleanses all.
 He is gracious and merciful...thank you God.
 Glory to God... God is so alive.*

God is.
 God loves.
 May I be acceptable in Thy sight.
 We are all one in His grace.
 The fact that we do exist is acknowledgement of Thee O Lord.
 Thank you, God.
 God will wash away all our tears...
 He always has...
 He always will.
 Seek Him every day. In all ways seek God every day.
 Let us sing all songs to God
 To whom all praise is due... praise God.
 No road is an easy one, but they all
 go back to God.
 With all we share God.
 It is all with God.
 It is all with Thee.
 Obey the Lord.
 Blessed is He.
 We are from one thing... the will of God... thank you God.
 I have seen God—I have seen ungodly—
 none can be greater—none can compare to God.
 Thank you, God.
 He will remake us ... He always has and He always will.
 It is true—blessed be His name—thank you God.
 God breathes through us so completely ...
 so gently we hardly feel it ... yet,
 it is our everything.
 Thank you, God.
 ELATION-ELEGANCE-EXALTATION
 All from God.
 Thank you, God. Amen.

John Coltrane - December 1964

A.3 Swami Satchidananda, spoken words opening Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda's version of "A Love Supreme." From *World Galaxy* (Impulse! Records, 1972). Recorded at the Record Plant, New York City, 1971.

A Love Supreme

Love

Love is a sacred word

Love is the name of God

*The entire universe is created with Love by Love and in Love
Love is the beginning; Love is the continuation; And Love is the end*

Love for love's sake is divine

It is constrictive, it is beautiful

Brings peace; Brings harmony; It brings joy

To the lover—And to the loved

But if Love is based on selfishness, egoism

The very same love brings destruction

Peace and harmony is based on Love

And used properly by a selfless mind for the benefit of the humanity

Love knows no business; Love knows no bargain

Love never expects anything in return; Love knows only giving

Giving and giving

Without even waiting for a thank you

Such a Love is the supreme word

Let that Love Supreme reign over the universe

Om Shanti Shanti Shanti

Om

A.4 Swami Satchidananda, opening invocation at the Woodstock Music and Art Fair, Bethel, New York, August 15, 1969. Satchidananda was Alice Coltrane's guru. Carlos Santana, whose performance of "Soul Sacrifice" at the same festival prompted the researcher's journey into this lineage, received the name Devadip from guru Sri Chinmoy in 1972 and maintained a concurrent spiritual and musical mentorship with Coltrane, producing Illuminations together in 1974. Retrieved from <https://swamisatchidananda.org/life/woodstock-guru/swami-satchidanandas-woodstock-address/>

My Beloved Brothers and Sisters:

I am overwhelmed with joy to see the entire youth of America gathered here in the name of the fine art of music. In fact, through the music, we can work wonders. Music is a celestial sound and it is the sound that controls the whole universe, not atomic vibrations. Sound energy, sound power, is much, much greater than any other power in this world. And, one thing I would very much wish you all to remember is that with sound, we can make—and at the same time, break. Even in the war-field, to make the tender heart an animal, sound is used. Without that war band, that terrific sound, man will not become animal to kill his own brethren. So, that proves that you can break with sound, and if we care, we can make also.

So I am very happy to see that we are all here gathered to create some sounds—to find that peace and joy through the celestial music. And I am really very much honored for having been given this opportunity of opening this great, great music Festival. I should have come a little earlier to do that job, but as you all know, thousands of brothers and sisters are on the way and it's not that easy to reach here.

America leads the whole world in several ways. Very recently, when I was in the East, the grandson of Mahatma Gandhi met me and asked me what's happening in America. and I said, "America is becoming a whole. America is helping everybody in the material field, but the time has come for America to help the whole world with spirituality also." And, that's why from the length and breadth, we see people—thousands of people, yoga-minded, spiritual-minded. The whole of last month I was in Hawaii and I was on the West Coast and witnessed it again.

So, let all our actions, and all our arts, express Yoga. Through that sacred art of music, let us find peace that will pervade all over the globe. Often we hear groups of people shouting, "Fight for Peace." I still don't understand how they are going to fight and then find peace. Therefore, let us not fight for peace, but let us find peace within ourselves first.

And the future of the whole world is in your hands. You can make or break. But, you are really here to make the world and not to break it. I am seeing it. There is a dynamic manpower here. The hearts are meeting. Just yesterday I was in Princeton, at Stony Brook in a monastery, where about two hundred or three hundred Catholic monks and nuns met and they asked me to talk to them under the heading of "East and West—One Heart." Here, I really wonder whether I am in

the East or West. If these pictures or the films are going to be shown in India, they would certainly never believe that this is taken in America. For here, the East has come into the West. And with all my heart, I wish a great, great success in this music Festival to pave the way for many more festivals in many other parts of this country.

But the entire success is in your hands, not in the hands of a few organizers. Naturally, they have come forward to do some job. I have met them. I admire them. But still, in your hands, the success lies. The entire world is going to watch this. The entire world is going to know that what the American youth can do to the humanity. So, every one of you should be responsible for the success of this Festival.

*And, before I conclude my talk, I would like you all to join me and our group here in repeating a very simple chant. As I was reminding you of the sound power, there are certain mystical sounds which the Sanskrit terminology says are the **bijakshara**, or the “seed words.” We are going to use three seed words, or the mystic words, to formulate the chants. And if you all join wholeheartedly, after the chant we are going to have at least one whole minute of absolute silence. Not even the cameras will click at that time. And in that silent period, that one minute of silence, you are going to feel the great, great power of that sound and the wonderful peace that it can bring in you and into the whole world. Let us have a sample of that now. The words will be: “Hari” is one word. “OM” is another word. The first chant will have these two words, “Hari OM Hari OM, Hari Hari Hari OM.” The second line will be “Hari OM, Hari OM, Hari Hari OM.”*

There will be another chant afterwards: just one word, “Ram.” We’ll be repeating: “Rama Rama Rama Rama Rama Rama Rama Ram.” It’s a sample. It’s very easy to follow with everybody and we’ll have a gentle clapping also. So, now we’ll begin in a slow rhythm and gradually build it up. Now I will request all of my friends to join me. We will repeat the line once, then allow you to follow. (The entire festival then chanted the “Hari Om” chant together.)

Thank you all very much. And once again let me express my sincere wish and prayers for the success and peace of this celebration. Thank you.

A.5 "Journey to Satchidananda." Lyrics from *World Music Vol. 1: The Ecstatic Music of Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda* (Luaka Bop, 2017). Transcribed from liner notes.

Journey to Satchidananda

Samsara Journey to Satchidanandaji, Journey with Satchidanandaji

This journey is to infinite peace, To Divine Wisdom and Blessedness

He guides us on the samsaric sea, Through life's tests and trials

To the soul's victory.

His way is sure, His promise is pure

He will lead us, To God's heavenly shore

He knows the way, Of infinity, through celestial realms

To eternity.

Our journey's end is our journey home, Our journey home is our journey's end

Our journey's end is our journey home, Our journey home is our journey's end

Tamil Solo Translation:

In the ocean of family life, the journey is very difficult

With the mercy of God and the presence of almighty grace

We will reach His divine feet, and We will live in bliss

God's abode is limitless joy and eternal peace

We will surrender to the almighty

A.6 Rajna Swaminathan, "Surrender is Easier Said Than Done." Lyrics by Swaminathan; sung by ganavya doraiswamy. From *Apertures* (2023), commissioned by Chamber Music America's New Jazz Works Program, funded by the Doris Duke Charitable Foundation. Swaminathan describes these lyrics as "communicating personal revelations and nascent paths of spiritual inquiry" (Swaminathan, 2024, p. 36). Ingrid Monson, whose framework for jazz improvisation as interaction grounds this thesis's methodology (1996), served as an advisor on Swaminathan's doctoral dissertation at Harvard. Quoted at the close of CS3.

Surrender is Easier Said Than Done

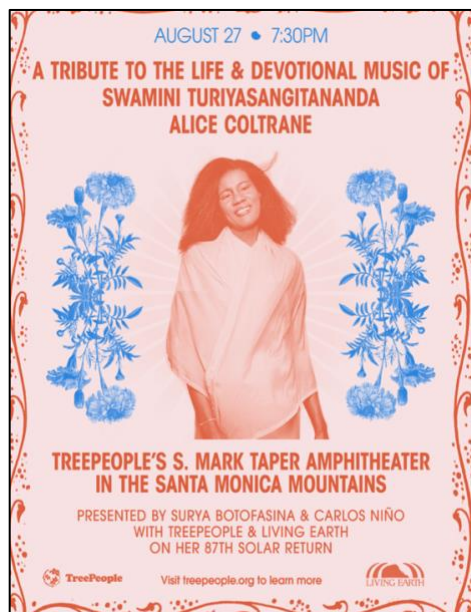
*Braided resonances,
 memories flooding in
 through out-of-body experiences,
 moving me in ways
 I never imagined possible.*

*(You see) I thought I could see so far ahead
 Little did I know—little did I know
 I was clouded
 Surrender is easier said than done
 Will you hold my hand as we walk into the sun?*

Appendix B: Fugitive Ephemera



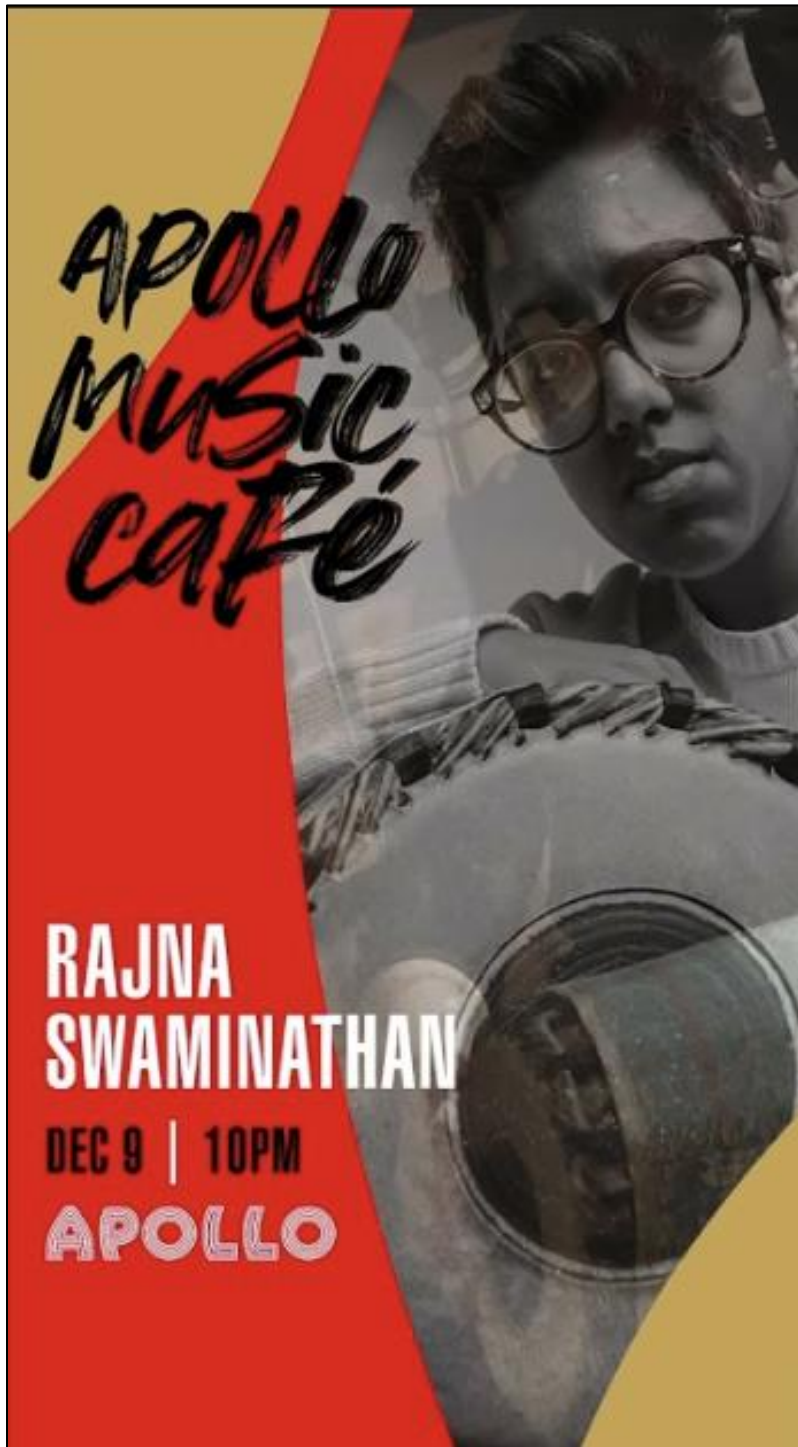
B.1-2 Flyers from recent years for the annual celebration of the life and devotional music of Swamini Turiyasangitananda Alice Coltrane, held on her birthday, August 27, at TreePeople's S. Mark Taper Amphitheater, Santa Monica Mountains. Presented by Surya Botofasina and Carlos Niño. One flyer depicts Botofasina seated on the steps of the Sai Anantam Ashram after its destruction in the 2018 Woolsey Fire. This is the annual gathering to which Niño invited André Benjamin after encountering him at a grocery store—the encounter that produced *New Blue Sun* (André 3000, 2023).



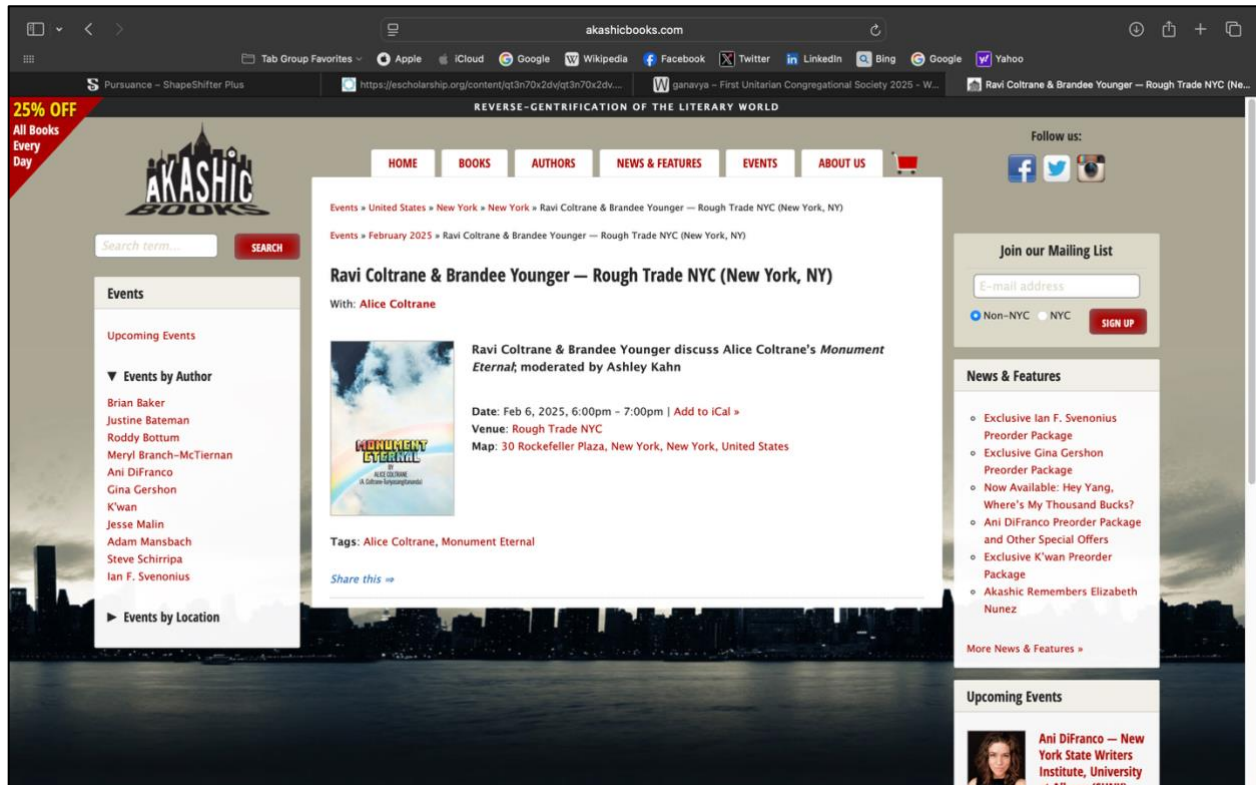
B.3 André 3000 performing on the New Blue Sun tour, the Independent, San Francisco, February 24, 2024. Photograph by Greg Chow. From San Francisco Chronicle, <https://www.sfchronicle.com/entertainment/article/sf-andre-3000-flute-concert-18670408.php>. The researcher attended the Atlanta performance at Center Stage Theater on March 2, 2024.



B.4 Flyer for Rajna Swaminathan's *Apertures* performance, December 9, 2023. Featuring ganavya doraiswamy (vocals), Utsav Lal (piano), Miles Okazaki (guitar), Darian Donovan Thomas (violin), Kalia Vandever (trombone), and Hannah Marks (bass). This is the performance the researcher attended at the Apollo Café in Harlem—the encounter referenced in the thesis's opening pages.



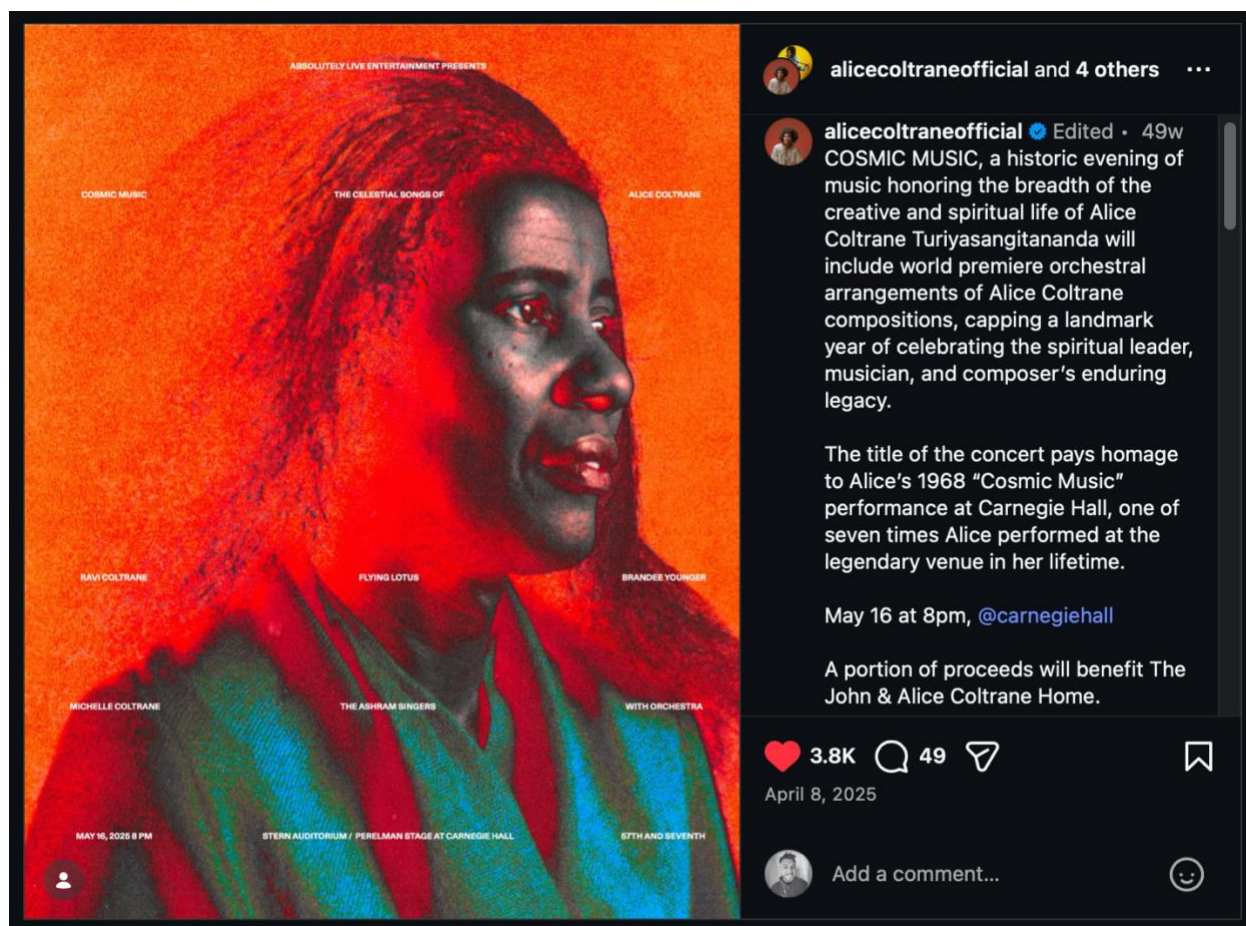
B.5 Screenshot of event listing for the celebration of *Monument Eternal's* second edition, Rough Trade Records, Times Square, New York, February 6, 2025. Panel: Ravi Coltrane, Brandee Younger, and Ashley Kahn. Retrieved from Akashic Books, <https://www.akashicbooks.com/events/ravi-coltrane-brandee-younger-rough-trade-nyc-new-york-ny/>



B.6 Georgia Anne Muldrow performing at the Apollo Music Café, Harlem, March 7, 2025. The event was described as "an unscripted night of music that takes the audience on a revolutionary journey through self-love, gratitude and perseverance. This is where the researcher learned from Muldrow that she was an initiate of Turiyasangitananda. Photograph by the researcher.



B.7 Flyer for *COSMIC MUSIC: The Celestial Songs of Alice Coltrane*, Stern Auditorium / Perelman Stage, Carnegie Hall, May 16, 2025. Featuring Ravi Coltrane, Flying Lotus, Brandee Younger—playing Alice's recently restored harp, originally a gift from John Coltrane in 1967—and Michelle Coltrane leading the Sai Anantam Devotional Ensemble. World premiere orchestral arrangements of Alice Coltrane compositions. The first time Ravi, Flying Lotus, and Michelle appeared onstage together. Culminating event of the Year of Alice. The title pays homage to Alice's 1968 Cosmic Music performance at the same venue. Posted by @thecoltranehome, Instagram. <https://www.instagram.com/p/DIMfxsJSajr/>



B.8 ganavya shared a copy of *Monument Eternal* with the researcher via Instagram in December 2023—an act of care from a stranger that [re]opened the field-orientation from which this thesis proceeds. Her album *Daughter of a Temple* (LEITER, 2024) gathers thirty artists across spiritual jazz and Tamil devotional tradition for a recording session that began with the washing of the others' feet. Full article: <https://www.nytimes.com/2024/11/20/arts/music/ganavya-daughter-of-a-temple.html>

The Singer Whose Work Feels Like Prayer

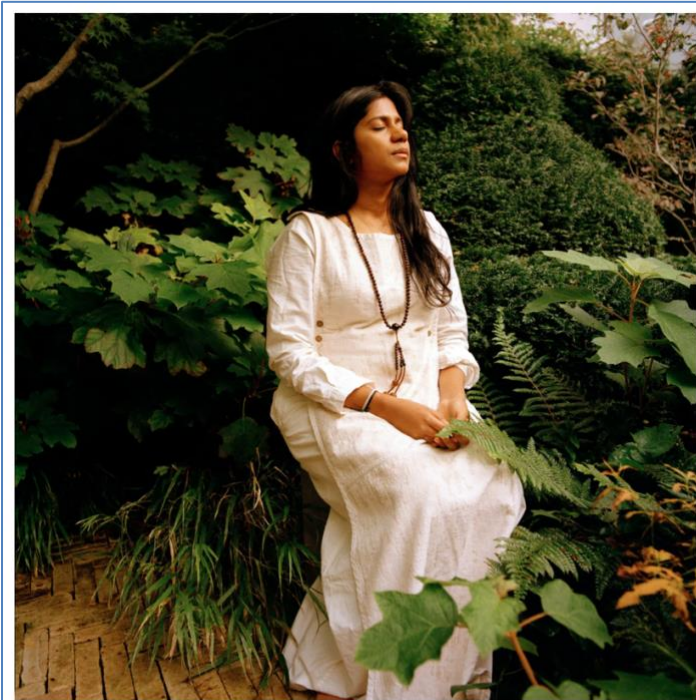
On her new LP, “Daughter of a Temple,” Ganavya is the central vocalist, composer and community builder for 30 artists who constitute a who’s who in jazz and experimental music.

By Marcus J. Moore

Published Nov. 20, 2024



Ganavya was raised in the Hindu tradition of harikatha, a type of storytelling that blends music and poetry. Adama Jalloh for The New York Times

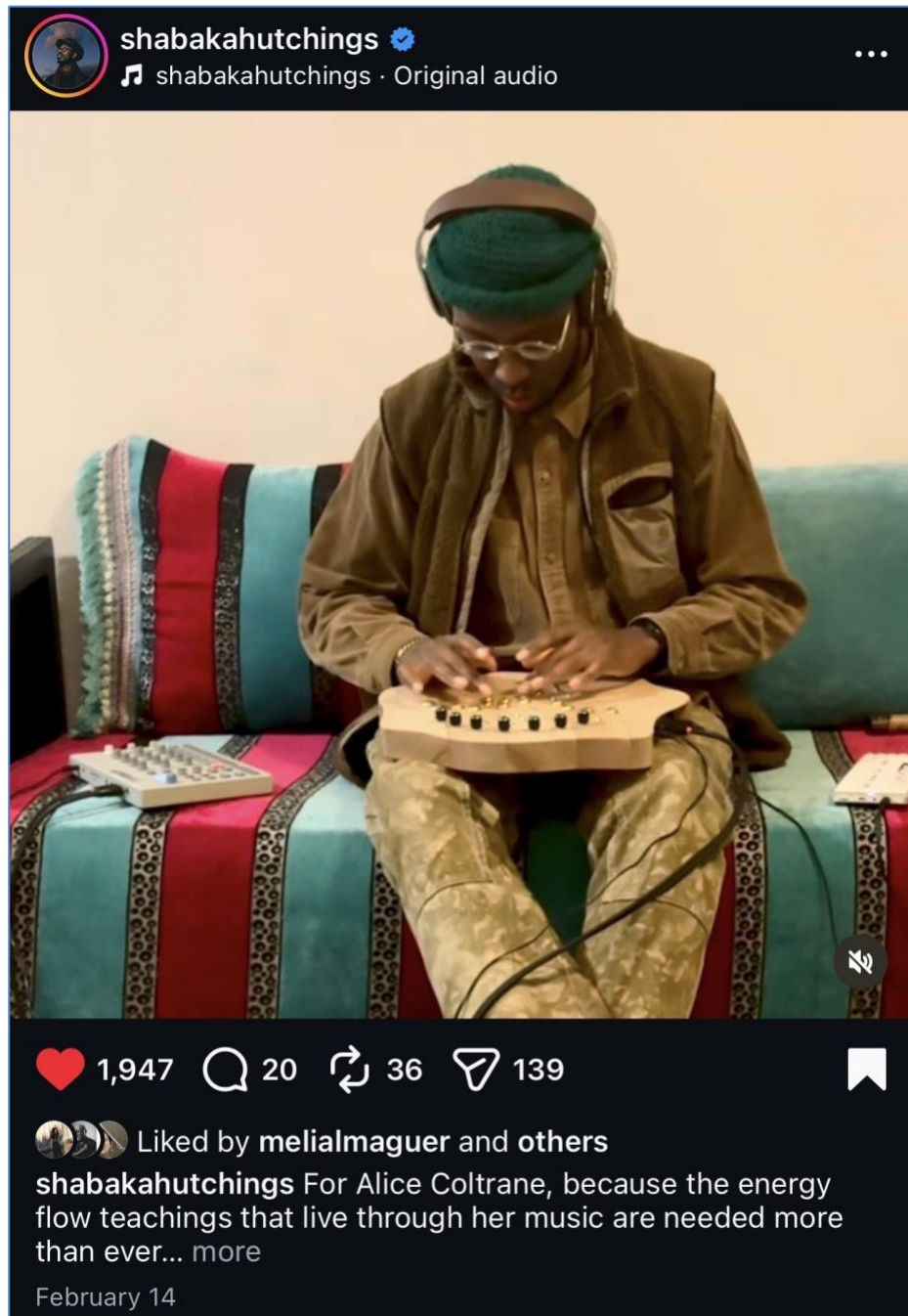


“I sing because I genuinely think that if I don’t, I will die,” Ganavya said. “The only thing that gives me relief is this.” Adama Jalloh for The New York Times

“Life has always felt like it was a series of miracles,” she said. “I firmly believe that there is only love, and it could be so much simpler. I sing because I genuinely think that if I don’t, I will die. The only thing that gives me relief is this. It’s the only thread I have back to that state of simple joy ...”

She paused again: “Of singing with people.”

B.9 Shabaka Hutchings, "For Alice Coltrane, because the energy flow teachings that live through her music are needed more than ever..." Instagram, February 14, 2026. Hutchings—a dear friend of ganavya's, who has spoken of his friendship as having carried her through difficult seasons—produced her *like the sky I've been too quiet* (Native Rebel, 2024) and plays clarinet on *Daughter of a Temple*. Here, playing kalimba in a private devotional setting. The kinship network sounding through informal infrastructure, care before content.



B.10 *Planetarium*, Ridgewood, Queens, April 4, 2026. Carlos Niño & Friends featuring Marshall Allen (101, Sun Ra Arkestra), Darius Jones, and Austin Williamson. "A deep listening event with a high fidelity sound system in a private loft... we invite you to bring pillows, blankets, sleeping bags and anything else you need to get comfortable, while live musicians and DJs create a landscape for exploring the inner cosmos." This is the room where Niño crossed the floor, shook the researcher's hand, and said: "The story... and now, you're here."



B.11 *The Sound of Ourselves: A Meditative Music Activation*, the Vale of Cashmere, Prospect Park, Brooklyn, August 9, 2025. Surya Botofasina & A Space for Sound, powered by Karlala Soundsystem. During the gathering, Botofasina shared that he had once slept on the benches in this same Vale—unhoused, in the grip

of addiction. The researcher and Botofasina connected more deeply that afternoon over a shared experience of substance abuse and recovery. The site of the wound had become the site of the teaching. The bench and the soundsystem occupied the same ground.



AUG 9TH, 2025 **THE VALE OF CASHMERE,**
2PM-4PM **PROSPECT PARK**

THE SOUND OF OURSELVES

A MEDITATIVE MUSIC ACTIVATION

**SURYA BOTAFASINA &
A SPACE FOR SOUND**

SUGGESTED DONATION: \$15-\$25
ALL AGES WELCOME
LIGHT REFRESHMENTS, TILL THEY LAST

**POWERED BY
KARLALA SOUNDSYSTEM**

B.12 Simone Weil, displayed in a window of 80 Washington Place (NYU), facing Washington Square Park. Photograph by the researcher, spring 2025. In the second semester, in the midst of concerted research, the researcher discovered Weil's work and its resonance with Coltrane's frameworks. The following Monday, in an impromptu office visit, a professor from the first semester—upon hearing about the Weil-Coltrane convergence—shared that her parents, like Alice, had been devotees of Swami Satchidananda. Walking through the park after the meeting, the researcher looked up and saw this: Weil's face, eyes closed, presencing from a window of the program's own building. No coursework had mentioned her, though her image had been ornamenting the structure the researcher was already inside. Photograph by the researcher.

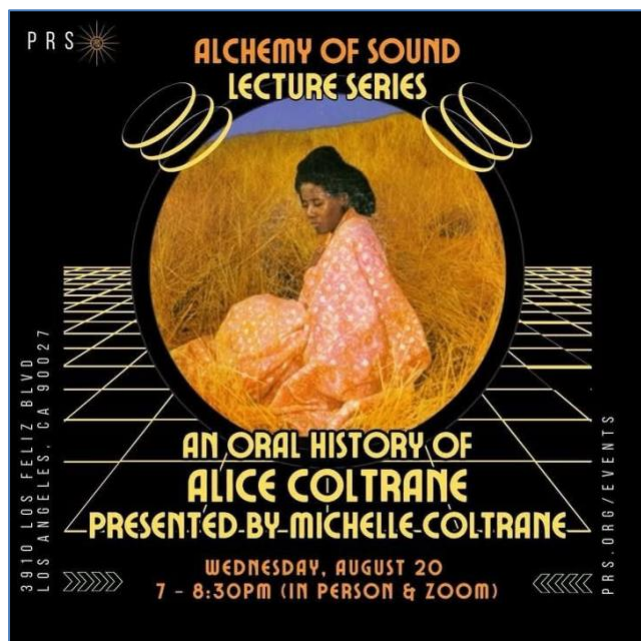


B.13 Ami Taf Ra, *The Prophet & The Madman* (Brainfeeder, 2025), displayed in a Japanese record store. The promotional banner reads "現代のAlice Coltrane?!"—"A modern-day Alice Coltrane?!"—placing her directly in the lineage. Produced and co-written by her life partner Kamasi Washington, who has collaborated with André 3000 and, as of April 2026, performed with Carlos Niño & Friends backing Saul Williams at Blue Note Los Angeles. The network the thesis traces—Coltrane through Botofasina, Niño, André, Doraiswamy, Hutchings, Williams—runs through Washington too, and the Japanese press prices it before the American scholarly apparatus does. Instagram, @amitaframusic, October 27, 2025.

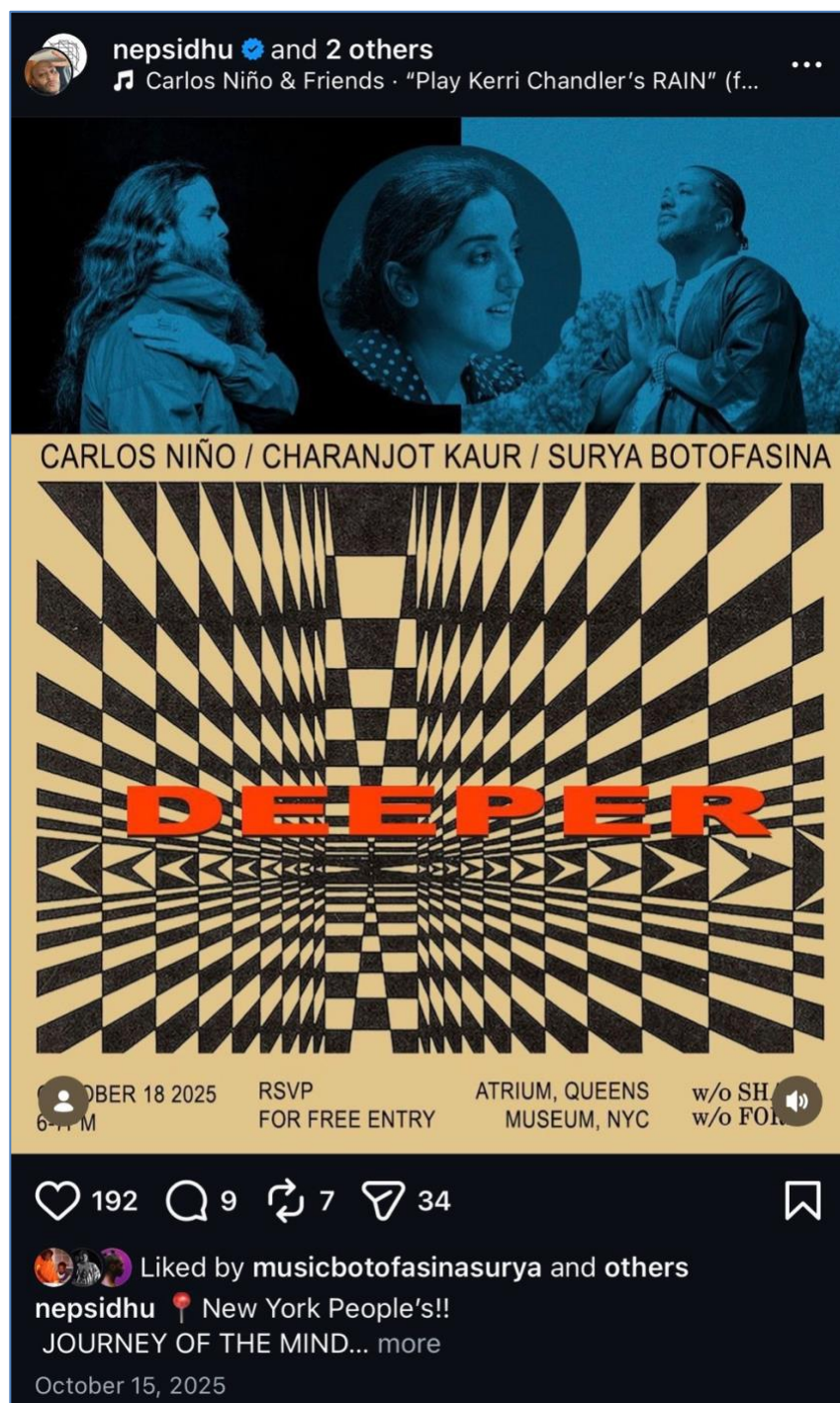


B.14 Ami Taf Ra debuting *The Prophet & The Madman* live at Blue Note, New York City, 2025. Photograph by the researcher.

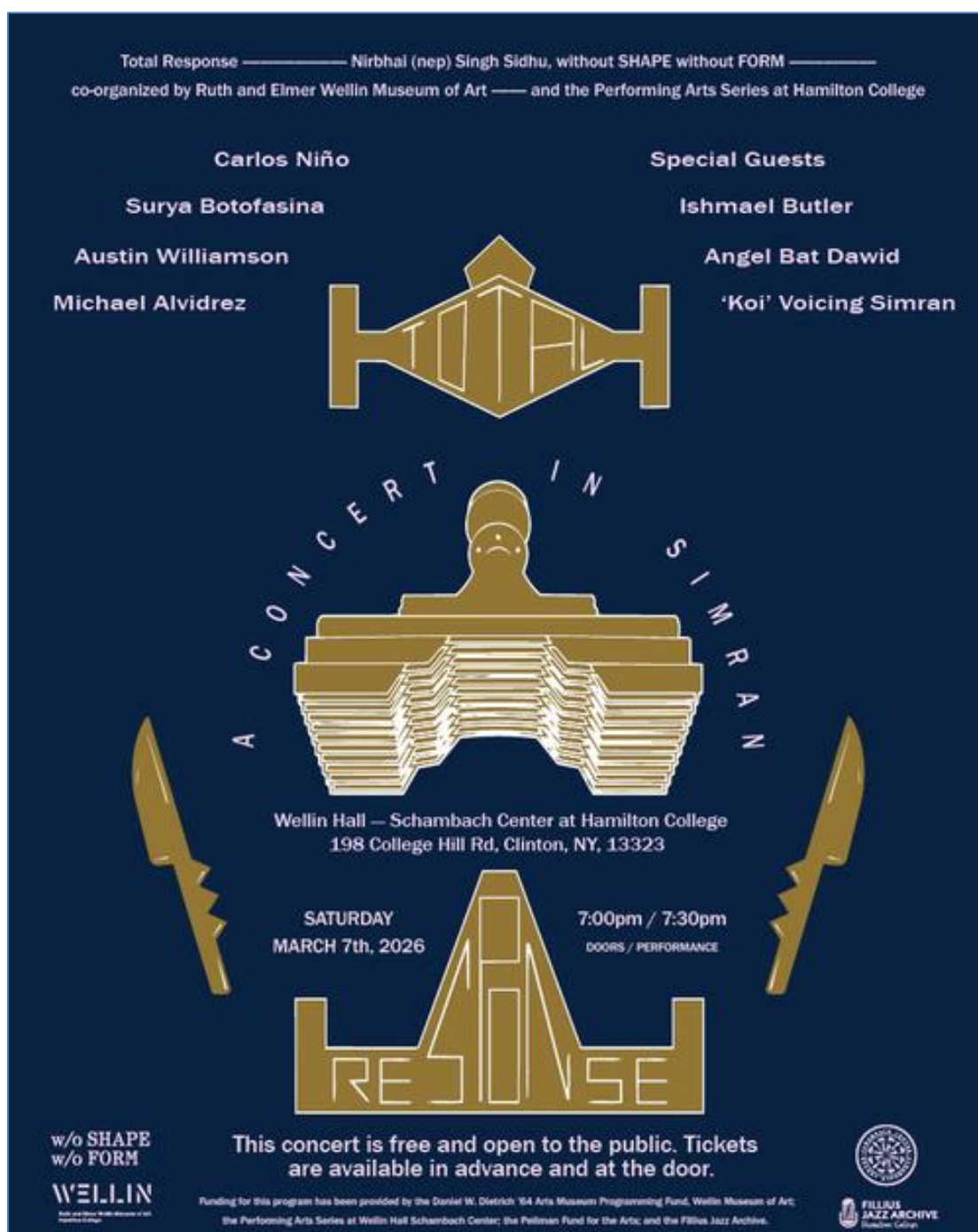
B.15 The Coltrane Home, The Philosophical Research Society, and dublab present *Divine Revelations: The Eternal Voice of Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda*, August 23, 2025, 3910 Los Feliz Blvd, Los Angeles. *Eternity's Pillar* Ashram and Video Installation (1–7pm); Sai Anantam Devotional Ensemble Live: Devotional Music & Dance + *Black Journal* screening (7pm). Preceded by *An Oral History of Alice Coltrane*, presented by vocalist Michelle Coltrane—Alice's firstborn, born in Paris in 1960—as part of PRS's *Alchemy of Sound* lecture series, August 20, 2025. dublab—the Los Angeles freeform radio collective of which Carlos Niño was a founding DJ—co-presenting the event. The same node connecting the Ridgewood loft, the Atlanta stage, and the Wellin Museum connecting here too. Instagram, @philosophical_research_society, August 15, 2025.



B.16 *Deeper*, Atrium, Queens Museum, NYC, October 18, 2025. Carlos Niño / Charanjot Kaur / Surya Botofasina. Presented by withoutSHAPEwithoutFORM. Nep Sidhu's caption: "*New York People's!! JOURNEY OF THE MIND...*"—scored to Carlos Niño & Friends. This is the room where the researcher met Deep Kailey, who introduced the withoutSHAPEwithoutFORM network from which *Total Response*, the Wellin Museum recording, and *Awakened by the Unstruck* follow. The first entry point into the kinship network that would recognize the researcher before the researcher recognized themselves in it. Instagram, @nepsidhu, October 15, 2025.



B.17 Total Response: A Concert in Simran, Wellin Hall, Schambach Center at Hamilton College, Clinton, NY, March 7, 2026. Nirbhai (Nep) Singh Sidhu / withoutSHAPEwithoutFORM, co-organized by Ruth and Elmer Wellin Museum of Art and the Performing Arts Series at Hamilton College. Carlos Niño, Surya Botofasina, Austin Williamson, Michael Alvidrez, with special guests Ishmael Butler, Angel Bat Dawid, and 'Koi' Voicing Simran. Free and open to the public. The practice was professionally recorded for the forthcoming 2027 exhibition *Awakened by the Unstruck*—the unstruck sound made materially accessible as museum infrastructure. This is the room where the network recognized the researcher and where the researcher's own testimony entered the assemblage as tertiary retention before he knew it had.



B.18 *Cosmic Music: The Life, Art & Transcendence of Alice Coltrane*, book event with Andy Beta, Jenn Pelly, Tulsi Reynolds, and Brandee Younger. NYU Bobst Library, Immersion Room, March 24, 2026. Free and open to the public. Beta named the limit of his biographical project from the stage—the limit that is precisely where this thesis lives. Tulsi Reynolds, who played tamboura on Coltrane's *Journey in Satchidananda*, made eye contact with the researcher during a question about figure-ground architecture and smiled, nodding in recognition. Brandee Younger spoke about playing Alice's actual harp today. The biographical, the performative, and the scholarly converging in the researcher's own institution, in the week of the book's release—the personal and the institutional sharing a substrate, again.

COSMIC MUSIC: THE LIFE, ART & TRANSCENDENCE OF ALICE COLTRANE

- book event with Andy Beta, Jenn Pelly, Tulsi Reynolds, Brandee Younger

TUESDAY, MAR 24 2026

IN-PERSON EVENT

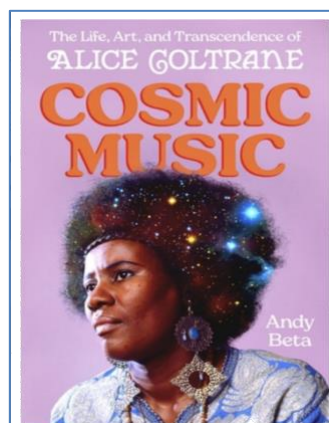
6:15pm

NYU Bobst Library, Immersion Room
70 Washington Square South, 7th Floor

Free and open to the public. Non-NYU
guests RSVP by emailing ss162@nyu.edu

ADD TO CALENDAR

 Add to Google Calendar



B.19 Doja Cat (Amala Ratna Zandile Dlamini)—one of the most commercially dominant pop artists of the 2020s—lived at the Sai Anantam Ashram as a child. She appears on the cover of *World Spirituality Classics Vol. 1: The Ecstatic Music of Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda* (Luaka Bop, 2017), to the right of Alice, in a pink dress. The transmission's reach into mainstream pop culture is not a metaphor for cultural diffusion; it is a biographical fact that the reception apparatus has not yet learned to read. Instagram, retrieved April 2026.

DOJA CAT LIVED AT HER ASHRAM



The cover of 'The Ecstatic Music of Alice Coltrane Turiyasangitananda' shows her to the right of Alice, in a pink dress.

B.20 *Alice Coltrane: Monument Eternal*, Hammer Museum at UCLA, February 9 – May 4, 2025. A major multimedia exhibition taking its name from her 1977 book, featuring archival materials from Coltrane's personal collection—handwritten correspondence, unreleased audio, rarely seen video—alongside works by nineteen contemporary artists including Rashid Johnson, Cauleen Smith, and Martine Syms. Three thematic sections: Sonic Innovation, Spiritual Transcendence, Architectural Intimacy. A weekly performance series, *Turiya Rising*, sounded live every Sunday on a stage designed by GeoVanna Gonzalez. Part of the *Year of Alice*, in partnership with the John & Alice Coltrane Home. The exhibition named itself after the text this thesis treats as primary philosophical articulation. Images courtesy of the Hammer Museum, hammer.ucla.edu.



Alice Coltrane, Monument Eternal, installation view.

Hammer Museum, Los Angeles, February 9–May 4, 2025. Photo: Joshua White

B.21 *The Year of Alice* was the inaugural presentation of the John & Alice Coltrane Home and the Coltrane Family, 2024–2025. A series of multidisciplinary events re-positioning Alice Coltrane's legacy as musician, composer, and spiritual leader: catalog reissues including *The Carnegie Hall Concert* (1971); *An Oral History of Alice Coltrane* presented by Michelle Coltrane and Brandee Younger; a world premiere by Alonzo King LINES Ballet choreographed to *Journey in Satchidananda*; the *Monument Eternal* exhibition at the Hammer Museum at UCLA; a Kirtan ceremony at the Integral Yoga Institute on what would have been her 87th birthday; community programming at Rough Trade, the Jazz Museum of Harlem, and Shapeshifter Plus; and a culminating Carnegie Hall concert—*Cosmic Music: The Celestial Songs of Alice Coltrane*—with Ravi Coltrane, Flying Lotus, Michelle Coltrane leading the Sai Anantam Devotional Ensemble, and a forty-piece orchestra. *The Year* also saw the restoration of Alice's original harp—gifted by John shortly before his passing, the instrument she taught herself, the one she recorded *Journey in Satchidananda* and *A Monastic Trio* on—to peak condition by Lyon & Healy of Chicago. It is on loan to Brandee Younger, who plays it today. As Ravi Coltrane put it: "It can take a moment for people to recognize where the energies are, where the weight is... But now people across all generations are finding their way to Alice's music in a myriad of different ways." Source: thecoltranehome.org/year-of-alice/.



"Alice was ahead of her time, one of the first people to move outside the mainstream, and certainly one of the first female, black, American jazz musicians to record her own music in her own studio, and to release music on her own terms. There is something to be said about timing. It can take a moment for people to recognize where the energies are, where the weight is... But now people across all generations are finding their way to Alice's music in a myriad of different ways. It's hard to pinpoint what makes her music so powerful, but there's something in her spirit, in her intention that is very clear – and people can feel that immediately."

– Ravi Coltrane

"The Coltrane family & The Coltrane Home organization present 'The Year of Alice' through tributary music events, spiritual, educational programming and more. We are honored and delighted to offer insight into the legacy of my mother... Alice Turiya Coltrane. My mother engaged herself in the spiritual process known as God-realization. Her life on earth consolidated artistic expression, spiritual principles, and charitable giving. She emphasized selfless service that uplifted the giver as well as recipients of the giving. She understood well the relevance of all life in terms of universal consciousness."

– Michelle Coltrane